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ELEVEN SHORT STORIES ABOUT LOVE

ELEVEN SHORT STORIES
ABOUT LOVE

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For the Literary Lions

CHAPTER ONE

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‘Shall we begin?’ said the woman with the massive conk sitting on my right. I’m not joking, it really *was* massive. Every time I turned to say something to her, I got an eyeful of her oversized hooter. Could I go out with someone with a proboscis that large? Am I so shallow I believe that size matters? You might argue that I wouldn’t notice it as much if I were facing her, but then she’d only have to turn her head slightly and I’d bloody well notice it. Jesus Christ, this is the twenty-first century. Had the woman never heard of cosmetic surgery? Besides there was no way that I could contemplate dating her anyway. She’d just told me she read the *Evening Standard*.

‘Shouldn’t we wait for the sixth person?’ said the woman sitting on my left. Good point, I thought, we should. She had a perfectly proportionally-sized nose, but she was at least a couple of inches taller than me, which wasn’t a good start from the prospective dating perspective. I hadn’t yet determined whether she read the *Evening Standard*, but she looked the type. I had however discovered that her primary

pastime was golf. The only time I had ever played golf had been the game on my mobile phone. I'm sure she looked very fetching in her golf attire. (Actually, no, I'm sure she didn't. Golf attire must be just about the most unerotic form of clothing ever devised by humankind.) But there are some types of people who are just not meant to be together and I somehow couldn't see us spending our Sunday mornings in matching his'n'hers v-neck Pringle sweaters and plus-fours perfecting our swings with the club professional.

'There is always someone who doesn't turn up at these things,' said the guy on golf woman's left. 'There's no point waiting any longer for them.' I couldn't remember what he'd said his name was. Jamie? Johnnie? I'm terrible at remembering people's names, but he looked like the kind of person whose name would end in "ie", not that his name really mattered. He was right though that there was nearly always someone who didn't turn up at these things. Which was hardly surprising. How many people really wanted to spend their Friday evening exchanging awkward social chitchat with a group of complete strangers? A Supper for Six dinner was like going on a simultaneous blind dates with five people. And that didn't mean five times the embarrassment and humiliation, it meant something like twenty-five times as you had to take into account the fact that everyone else would be aware of your embarrassment and humiliation in front everyone else, so that the humiliation fed back on itself. One day I must write a Monte Carlo stimulation of the situation to determine the exact factor by which the embarrassment and humiliation are amplified. 'We can't wait forever.' Jamie/Johnnie continued. The evening already seemed to me as though it had lasted forever. 'I'm getting hungry.' Hungry? Hungry? For God's sake, it's only just gone eight o'clock. Our stomachs could surely cope with another five minutes' wait?

'Yes, yes,' said nose woman, 'let's order. It's nearly ten past.' It would be polite to wait for the sixth person and politeness, I had thought, was a key ingredient of the glue that bound society together. But there didn't seem any point in me saying anything. The truth was

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that I desperately wanted the sixth person to turn up. Partly because whoever it was might have more interesting conversation than the four grotesques who surrounded me now, but mostly because the sixth person would be the third woman. For me, the whole point of being at the meal was to meet women and I'd ruled out the two who were already here. Of course, Supper for Six tried to argue that the dinners were about business networking as much as dating. Yeah, right. Bollocks to that. There was only one reason why I was here and it had nothing to do with collecting a business card from a chartered surveyor who lived in Croydon.

We were sitting in a Sardinian restaurant in Notting Hill. It was supposedly a good Sardinian restaurant, a very good one. It had better be from the prices on the menu. It was the kind of restaurant in which ordering was easier said than done as nose woman was finding as she attempted to summon a waiter, all of whom had been schooled in the many subtle ways of completely ignoring requests for attention from patrons. Of course, some of the clients were undoubtedly the kinds of people who *deserved* bad service. I could, for instance, easily imagine Jamie/Johnnie behaving like a complete arse towards waiters when he thought it might impress the people he was with.

Jamie/Johnnie and nose woman were frantically signalled to the waiting staff.

I took a long slug of my G&T. They had least got that right even if they would no doubt charge for it at an eye-watering rate at the end of the evening. Perhaps I should just make my excuses, leave now and save myself seventy quid.

Out of the corner of my eye, I saw a figure being lead over towards us. Could this be. . . ?

'I'm so sorry I am late.' I leapt to my feet; the others followed in a more laggardly fashion. I eyed the newcomer carefully. She was quite short, about five feet three, but then I liked short women. She had red hair that reached down to the middle of her back. But then I liked women with red hair. And I liked women with long hair. She had miles and

miles of curves. And I liked women with miles and miles of curves. She was wearing a black knee-length dress and black tights. And I liked short dresses and tights. (The thing about tights is not so much the tights themselves — although they do look good — but the fact that you can imagine that they are stockings. Of course, the dress was too short for them to really be stockings and even leaving that aside, it was highly unlikely that she would wear stockings to dinner with five strangers, but if she were happy to wear tights on a “first date” (so to speak), there was a reasonable chance that her underwear drawer had some aesthetically pleasing contents. Well, a man can dream, can’t he?) She was wearing black stilettos. And I liked black stilettos. There is just something incredibly sexy about a woman in high heels. So far, she had one minor strike against her (being a few minutes late, which, given that it is a woman’s prerogative to be late, is arguably not a strike against her at all in the dating domain) and five major strikes for her (OK, OK, it was possible that she was wearing tights because she didn’t shave her legs. But (a) she didn’t look like the type of woman who didn’t shave her legs; (b) the idea was just too horrible for me to contemplate. Until I had positive evidence that she didn’t shave her legs, I was prepared to give her the benefit of the doubt.) I had only heard her speak ten words, but already I was in love.

‘Zoë,’ she said, ‘Zoë.’ Someone must have asked her her name. Zoë, eh? Do you write it with a diaeresis over the ‘e’ I nearly blurted out. At some point, I must have shook her hand and told her my name, but my the focus of my attention was somewhere elsewhere altogether. ‘I’m so sorry I’m late,’ said Zoë. ‘The Circle Line was suspended, so I had to get the District Line to Earl’s Court to change for the Edgware Road branch, but the District Line trains were messed up too. So instead of taking me ten minutes, it took me three quarters of an hour.’ Well, as an explanation, it made perfect sense to me. It was the kind of thing that could happen to anyone. She was forgiven in my eyes.

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‘We were about to order,’ said Jamie/Johnnie. For God’s sake, couldn’t he see that woman needed to get her breath back for a minute or two?

‘That’s OK, I’m sure I’ll be ready by the time you’ve all made your choices.’

‘Apparently,’ said Lewis, ‘a lot of celebs come here. A friend of mine was here the other week and he saw Hugh. Really. Hugh!’ Lewis’s name I had remembered. It was the kind of name you remembered. After all, what kind of name was Lewis? A surname that was what kind of name. I know, I know, but I’m old fashioned that way. Lewis did at least look like a ‘Lewis’. He was a tall, slim guy with floppy hair and wearing a polo neck jumper. I looked around me. No obvious celebs and the fact that none of the four (*Grazia/Heat* readers (I excluded Zoë from that category naturally) at the table had recognised anyone suggested that there were no celebs below my recognition level here either. Pity Hugh wasn’t here tonight. His presence might have livened up the staff a bit.

The waiter who had brought Zoë over to our table had buggered off now, so it took a couple of minutes to persuade one of the the staff to pay us any attention. Eventually, one of the sleepwalkers deigned to saunter over to our table and take our order. At least the delay had given Zoë a chance to study the menu properly. She was seated opposite me between Jamie/Johnnie and Lewis, across the chaotic vastness of the round table. I couldn’t help noticing her fingering an amber amulet that hung from a silver chain around her neck. She allowed it to fall back against her neck and I saw that the colour of the stone perfectly complemented the colour of her eyes, hair and skin.

‘Apparently,’ said Lewis again after we had ordered, ‘the restaurant is named after the town in Sardinia where the owners come from.’ Apparently, “apparently” was one of Lewis’s favourite words. But whichever way, Lewis, I could also google as well as the next person. And I had, Lewis, I had. And I knew that the town was called Terranoa in Italian and that there was probably an interesting story of class and

ethnic conflict behind the difference between in names. But even my research skills could only take me so far.

‘Sounds romantic,’ I said. ‘I wonder if it sounds as romantic in Sardinian?’ As the name of a seaside resort, it might be actually be the equivalent of Skegness for all I knew. But Skegness isn’t the kind of word that one uses in polite company.

Lewis gave me a look. It was what I would generally call a funny look. At least try and not be so cynical, Alex. There’s no point *deliberately* antagonising these people more than absolutely necessary. And if you do have to make a crack, for God’s sake, at least make sure it’s not a cheap one. Definitely time to retreat to where I belonged: in my shell.

‘Excuse me for a minute,’ I said. ‘I need to... I need to go to the... er...’

The toilets at least proved to be the kind that one hopes to find in an expensive restaurant. At least I was getting something for the price of the meal. And they looked safe enough to risk a number two. So I decided to have one even though I didn’t really need one. It would kill a few minutes before the starters arrived. At least, I wouldn’t have to try and make out what Lewis and Johnnie/Jamie were saying to Zoë. I thought vaguely about having a wank while thinking about her, but this was, I felt, neither the time nor the place. Besides, I’d already had two stiff G&Ts and it would take me *forever*. So, I sat down on the expensive-feeling wooden toilet seat and tried to squeeze something out. Nothing much seemed to be happen. Damn it. It was going to take ages at this rate. I strained harder. Jesus, careful there, Alex, feeling a bit faint, old chap. Don’t rupture yourself. . .

* * *

There was something not quite right about the Punjab tonight. Firstly, it wasn’t called the Punjab. It was called the Krakow. And secondly, it wasn’t an Indian restaurant, it was a Polish one. Part of my brain

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kept flagging up those facts as indicating that there was something very wrong, while another part reassured me that there was nothing at all to worry about. The Krakow had always been the Krakow. It had been here since 1951. I had eaten good Polish here many times in the past. I remembered the evening I had come here with Sue. God, I hadn't thought of Sue and me on that date in the Krakow for years. That's because it wasn't the Krakow, it was the Punjab, you idiot. No, that can't be right, it was the Krakow. The Punjab! The Punjab? What kind of name is that for a restaurant? It's an Indian restaurant. Well, of course, I mean, there are a few Indian restaurants in London. I've even been to Indian restaurants a couple of times, but the Krakow's, well, the Krakow, London's oldest south Polish restaurant. What else could it be?

OK, OK. My date with Zoë. That's what I'm here for. What time are we meeting? Eight o'clock. What time is it now? Heh, I thought I was wearing a digital watch. What the hell is a *digital* watch? You know. . . a . . . digital watch. What on Earth am I thinking? A digital watch? Yeah, a quartz watch. An electronic watch. An electronic. . . *watch*? Wouldn't it be a little. . . er. . . big? Anyway, anyway, the time. Five to. Phew. I'm not late. Thank, God for that. OK, OK, wait for Zoë. Outside. No, no. She said in her pneu — *pneu*? — wait for her inside, she might be a few minutes late getting away from Imperial.

I went into the restaurant. Yes, there was a reservation for Blackwell for two people at eight o'clock. The waiter showed me to the table.

'Would you like something to drink, sir?' he said in a heavy Eastern European accent.

Well, yes, but what do you drink in a Polish restaurant? A beer would seem reasonable. A Polish beer. But what were the names of the Polish beers they sold in a Polish restaurant in London when it shouldn't be a Polish restaurant at all, it should be an Indian restaurant?

‘I’ll have a Tyskie Gronie,’ I heard myself say. ‘and two glasses.’ Well, OK then, that’s what we’ll have. But I couldn’t order four poppadoms and pickles. What did one order as a pre-starter in a Polish restaurant? Did they even have pre-starters in Polish restaurants? Bread? They must do bread as a pre-starter.

‘And can I get some black bread, please?’

‘Certainly, sir.’

OK, OK, I think I’m starting to get the hang of this now. I’m in a dream. A dream? It doesn’t feel like a dream. Well, what does a dream feel like? Not like this. Anyway, I can’t be dreaming. I’m not asleep. I’m in a Sardinian restaurant in Notting Hill, not a Polish restaurant in Neal Street that is in fact an Indian restaurant. Look, will you just leave it now? This is the Krakow. All right?

A couple of minutes later, the waiter returned with my beer, bread and Zoë. She was wearing a long skirt with matching jacket and a cream blouse with a high neck. Her skirt was longer than at half of me had been expecting, falling well down the thigh, but was cut in a way that removed any hint of frumpiness. Around her neck, from a silver chain, hung an amber amulet. I noted that she was wearing high heels and sheer black tights. Frankly, she looked pretty damned good.

I stood up and kissed her on both cheeks. ‘You look amazing,’ I said, if somehow different than I had remembered. Remembered from when? We only met a few minutes ago. But this is our second date. Second date? We haven’t been on a first date yet. It’s OK, Alex, it’s a dream.

We sat down and I poured beer for both of us.

‘Have you ever had one of those dreams, you know the ones in which it feels completely real and you do something terrible like have a massive row with your boss or someone important, even murder him, and then you wake up and you feel absolutely dreadful because you think you’ve had a massive row with your boss or even murdered him and it’s only after a what seems like ages that you realise that you haven’t murdered your boss and it was all just a dream?’

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Zoë looked at me carefully. Don't say "No." Don't say, "I never have that kind of dream." Don't say "It's good to see that you've decided to cut out the small talk and get straight down to philosophical matters." Don't say "Are you fucking nuts? You have that kind of dream? Are you a fucking borderline schizophrenic off your meds?"

'I have them all the time,' she said. 'Just before I did finals, I had a dream that I had finished them. I woke up and felt happy and free. Then I realised that, no, I hadn't done finals and there were still two weeks before the first exam. I felt a crushing weight of depression descend upon my soul.'

'I've often wondered,' I said, 'whether everything I think has happened to me has happened to me — in real life. OK, you have a surreal dream and when you wake up it doesn't take long to realise that your boss couldn't have been wearing lederhosen with two lamb chops balanced on his shoulders, at least not at the sales presentation to Post Office Telephones. But if the dream had been about a dull team meeting discussing changes to the expenses system, you might well go into work the next day fully convinced that a daily allowance was going to replace actuals.'

'Do you often have dull dreams?' said Zoë, munching on a pickle.

'Well, I don't often have dreams about my company's expenses system, no. But if I did it might not be until my next trip abroad that I discovered that we hadn't shifted to a daily allowance, even though I could clearly remember Jonathan telling us we were going to in a team meeting a few weeks ago.'

Zoë took a sip of beer. 'There is a third possibility. Lucid dreaming: you are in a dream and you know you are in a dream.'

Well, this couldn't be real — could it? — and I knew it couldn't be real, so I had to be in a lucid dream.

'How can you tell if you in a lucid dream?' I said.

'You can try pinching your nose.' I squeezed my nostrils shut with my thumb and index finger. 'Can you still breath?'

'Not through my nose.' My voice was a squeak.

‘OK. Look at your watch.’ I looked at it. The second hand ticked out a few seconds. ‘What time is it?’

‘About ten minutes later than it was when I looked at my watch outside the restaurant.’

‘Right then,’ Zoë continued, ‘what does the menu say?’ I picked it up and felt my stomach rumble. Definitely getting close to time to order.

‘Barszcz, kaszanka, golabki. . .’

‘OK. Look up from the menu.’ I looked up and looked into Zoë beautiful, brown eyes. ‘Now, look at it again. What does it say?’

‘It still says barszcz, kaszanka, golabki,’ I said.

‘In my professional opinion,’ said Zoë, ‘you’re not in a lucid dream. Trust me,’ She leaned forward and touched my hand. I felt a bolt of sexual electricity shoot up through my arm. I only just managed to stop myself from jerking my hand away. ‘I’m a doctor.’

I wanted to tell her that this had to be a dream. I looked again at the menu. It still said barszcz, kaszanka, golabki. But it shouldn’t do. Not if this wasn’t a dream. I had no idea what any of those dishes were, but simultaneously I knew that they were beetroot soup, black pudding and stuffed cabbage. Why were they serving Polish food in an Indian restaurant. And what was I doing in Covent Garden anyway when I should be in Notting Hill?

I put my other hand on top of Zoë’s hand. ‘I trust you, Zoë.’

‘So are you a telephone engineer who dreams he is Zhuangzi or a butterfly who dreams he is a telephone engineer?’

I’m on a date in a restaurant having dinner with a beautiful woman. Well, I’ve been on dates in restaurants having dinner with women before. Many times. Too many times really for the pleasure I’ve got out from the dates. But a *beautiful* woman? A beautiful and intelligent woman. A beautiful and intelligent woman who seemed to be interested in the things I was saying?

Yes, this must be a dream.

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In ordinary circumstances, I wouldn't have put my hand under the table and touched Zoë's leg. But this was a dream. A *lucid* dream. I was in control. After a fashion. Perhaps. I might as well try and make what I could of it. I ran my hand slowly up her thigh. Halfway up there was a bump. Oh, my God, she was wearing stockings! She looked at me knowingly.

'How come you only went to King's?' said Zoë. Only? But I felt my nether regions shrink at the question.

'Well, I, er. . .' I must have told her about King's on our first date. I tried to recall anything about that, but there was only a fog.

'It's OK. I'm not going to stop being interested in you because you didn't go to Cambridge.'

Thanks. 'Well, I spend too much time playing role-playing games, you know *Dungeons and Dragons* and *Traveller*,' that's what I intended to say, but it sounded like "Kriegspiel" when I came out of my mouth, 'and too much time fiddling around with my ZX Spectrum,' which sounded like "amateur radio gear" and "chemistry set" 'and too much time in the library reading science fiction and books about science,' which sounded the same. 'And not enough time revising for my A-levels,' "Higher School Certificate". 'How come you *did* get to go to Cambridge then?'

'I liked maths and physics,' said Zoë, 'and I was good at them. Most of my close relatives had been to Cambridge and done maths or sciences, so it wasn't an odd one to want to do. I also didn't have as many distractions as you when I was doing my HSC. No Kriegspiel or amateur radio gear or chemistry set, although I did spend a great deal of time in the library reading science fiction and books about science.' Well, at least, we had something in common other than an interest in epistemology and metaphysics.

'Perhaps we should try and order?' I said.

'Yes, I'm getting hungry.'

I looked at my watch again. A perfectly self-consistent couple of minutes had passed since I had last looked at it. The menu still promised Polish food. And I could still feel Zoë's suspender through the thin material of her skirt. But if this wasn't a dream, what did that make the idea of a Sardinian restaurant in Notting Hill?...

* * *

... I was back in the cubicle.

I looked at my watch. My Casio was on my wrist. The LCD told me that it was 20:16. The same time it had been when I had looked at my watch in the Polish restaurant a moment ago. What the hell had just happened? I couldn't have fallen asleep. Not when I was still at least two-thirds sober. Had I fainted? I'd never done that before. I certainly felt odd, but, if anything, the opposite of faint as someone (or something) had opened up my skull and poured a bucket of information-rich goop directly into my brain cavity. I closed my eyes. I could see Zoë sitting across the table from me in the Krakow. I could feel the warmth of her body on my hand pressed against her leg. I could also feel my buttocks pressing against the wooden toilet seat.

I opened my eyes, stood up and adjusted my clothes. Fuck me, I had just been abducted by aliens. I must have been. My arse didn't feel as though it had been anally probed though and there was no time missing. And why the hell would aliens want me to think I'd spent fifteen minutes with Zoë in a non-existent Polish restaurant in Neal Street?

I washed my hands and splashed some water on my face. I closed my eyes. The image of Zoë had faded. I touched the palm of my hand to her cheek. Could I really still detect her warmth? I opened my eyes again and splashed some more water on my face. Then I closed my eyes again. The image had become the faintest shadow. I opened my eyes and looked at my face in the mirror. Christ, I was getting too old for this game, especially if I was starting to hallucinate restaurant scenes

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with attractive women to whom I had not spoken more than a single word as well as losing my hair and getting bags under my eyes. I dried my face on a towel and I felt my stomach rumble. The starters should have arrived. Time had better get back to the dinner. And the real Zoë.

She was still chatting to Lewis and Johnnie/Jamie. I stopped and closed my eyes. The vision was gone. I opened my eyes. I Time to try and make conversation to strangers again.

‘We nearly sent your food back,’ said nose woman. ‘We’re sure where you had gone.’ I looked across the table. Did Zoë eyebrow rise quizzically? ‘Er... sorry, I... well, it took me longer than I had... er... expected.’

I had ordered the scallops for starter. They were grey and rubbery. I swallowed them down in a few bites. The mains arrived soon after. Mine was calf’s liver for main. As a child, I had hated liver. This was because my mother cooked it the same way she cooked everything: she boiled it until it turned grey. As an adult, I discovered that liver could be wonderful. Provided that it wasn’t overcooked. It seemed the chefs at Terranoa had been taking lessons from my mother. The liver was grey and rubbery.

As I chewed my liver, I looked over at Zoë. She was in what appeared to be an animated conversation with Lewis and Jamie/Johnnie.

‘... a physicist...’ I heard Zoë say. Damn this bloody noisy restaurant with its hard wooden floors and painted walls. Don’t the people who own these restaurants realise that you can barely hear a bloody thing anyone is saying? ‘... cosmology...’ A cosmologist? From her look, I’d had Zoë down more as a management consultant or an investment banker.

If the Circle Line had been running properly, Zoë would have got here twenty minutes earlier and I would be sitting next to her now rather than bloody Golf Woman and Nose Woman. And I would never have gone to the toilet and I would never have had my funny turn. Such are the vagaries of fate. The incessant wittering of the two women on either side of me to one another was an additional reason why

I couldn't hear properly what the other three were talking about. They certainly seemed to be enjoying themselves. Zoë was smiling and laughing at what seemed from the cadences of the conversation to be the appropriate places. It was clear to me that both Lewis and Jamie/Johnnie fancied their chances with Zoë. I wondered what she thought of them.

The mains were finished and I hoped that someone would suggest the old trick of the blokes moving round a couple of places for pudding. No-one did. In hindsight, it was a mistake to order the panna cotta as I had already detected the rubbery theme from the Terranoa brigade du cuisine. At least they were consistent. I chewed my way through the pudding in mournful silence.

Coffee and digestifs were brought. Lewis and Golf Woman left the table for comfort breaks. I could feel the pressure building up in my bladder, but I wasn't sure I wanted to run the gauntlet of the alien abductors again just yet, but that might be the only way I would get to talk to Zoë tonight. Had I really had a funny turn earlier in the evening or did I just think I had? Was the whole episode a false memory implanted by incorrectly firing neurones. I sensed a shape in my peripheral vision. I turned my head.

'Do you mind if I sit down?' said Zoë.

'No,' I said, 'no, of course not,' She sat down on the chair just vacated by Golf Woman. I definitely didn't mind. Would Golf Woman?

'We haven't had the chance to talk,' said Zoë.

'Er... no, we haven't' I said. 'It's not always easy to get to talk to everybody at these things. Especially when it's quite a large round table.'

'Indeed. A rectangular table tends to minimise the sum of the distances between the diners. It's a bit more complicated than that, but I'd have expected Supper for Six to have applied some basic mathematical reasoning to the question of the optimisation of the dining experience and made it a requirement of its partner restaurants that they use rectangular tables.' I nodded. My thoughts exactly. 'You seemed to be having a pretty good time with Jane and Gemma though.' She must

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mean Golf Woman and Nose Woman. Given that Nose Woman — was she Gemma or Jane? — was still sitting a couple of feet away from me talking to Johnnie/Jamie, I felt I couldn't disagree with her.

'Yes,' I said 'I was. Well. . . we talked about golf.' Golf Woman had I think, been trying to persuade Nose Woman to take lessons.

'Do you play?' said Zoë.

'Play?

'Golf.'

'Good lord, no,' I said.

'I understand,' said Zoë, 'that it's the hot new way for singles to meet.'

'It is?' Oh, my God, please don't let Zoë turn out to be another golf bore. An image of her hair pushed up under a golf cap, plus-fours and tightly fitting, diamond-patterned Pringle jumper came unbidden into my mind. OK, OK, if those kinds of clothes had to be worn, there were some people who I would rather look at in them.

'Yes, I read it on the web somewhere. I shan't be doing it myself though.' Did she mean she wouldn't be doing it because he didn't want to play golf or because she wasn't single and therefore didn't need to bother with ways for to meet singles, new, hot or otherwise?

Was Zoë single? My default assumption had been that she was, on the grounds that if you weren't single, why on Earth would you put yourself through the hell of a Supper for Six meal? But then Zoë was a very attractive woman (in my opinion) and very attractive women typically weren't single. In my experience, very, attractive women invariably had boyfriends, more often than not very possessive boyfriends. In one way, I rather hoped she was going to reveal in the next few seconds that she did have a boyfriend. I wouldn't have to bother trying to impress her and that would be a great weight lifted off my shoulders.

'Are there any particular ways you think singles should be meeting one another then?' I said.

'I'm not sure about *should*,' said Zoë, 'but they could go on a Supper for Six dinner.'

I couldn't exactly come straight out and say to Zoë 'Look, are you single? And, if so, would you like to go on a date with me?'

'I suppose they could,' I said. 'Is that the kind of thing you would do?'

'I am here, aren't I?' I had a good, hard look at Zoë. And there was plenty to have a good, hard look at. I had the feeling that she was having a good, hard look at me having a good, hard look at her. I started to feel distinctly uncomfortable in more areas than one. I took a sip of grappa.

'You certainly seem to be. Do you come to this kind of thing often?' I could hear her saying 'No, this is my first time and it will be last' and also 'Only when my boyfriend is out of the country'. One part of my brain recognised that these two statements were arguably mutually contradictory. Another part recognised that the words didn't match the movement of Zoë's lips. A third part of my brain finally got round to informing my central cognitive processes what she had in fact said was 'I've been to a couple of them before. How about you?'

Which was interesting. This evening wasn't a one-off, never to be repeated aberration for her. It wasn't just the terminally sad like me and the motley quartet who had been to more than one of these damned things.

'Er. . . yes, I've been to a couple. Three to be precise before this one.' It just seemed more.

'This is my fourth too. My, what a lot we've got in common! What do you do? No! Let me guess.' She put out her hand and touched the sleeve of my jacket. Not quite skin on skin. But still. 'You're a beekeeper.'

'A beekeeper?' I said. 'Do I look like an apiarist?'

'What do apiarists look like? You don't *not* look like a beekeeper. You could be a beekeeper. Bees are fascinating. They evolved from wasps.'

'I didn't know that.' Which I didn't. Zoë fingered her necklace. Please don't get a brain tumour and have to go to Switzerland to kill yourself! Where had *that* just come from? I took another sip of grappa.

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Things were definitely feeling very odd tonight. ‘So bees and wasps aren’t an example of convergence evolution.’

‘There’s plenty of examples of that though,’ said Zoë. ‘Ants and termites.’

‘I read about the different kinds of eusocial insects in *The Selfish Gene*,’ I said. ‘And, of course, naked moles are the only example of an eusocial species of mammal.’ Well, I’d put the word ‘naked’ was out there. Better not to think too much about that right now.

‘Humans could be said to be eusocial too perhaps. But I like the idea of insect colonies as models of both human societies and of human cities. What might cities look like if they didn’t look like cities?’

Was now the time to raise *The Algorithmic Beauty of Plants* and *L-systems* issue?

‘And there’s the whole simple rules leading to complex behaviour thing. I used to play a lot of *SimAnt* back in the early Nineties. Very cellular automata.’

‘I think I’m getting it now,’ said Zoë. ‘If not a beekeeper, something in computers?’

‘Well, yes,’ I said. ‘I am a software engineer. It’s a long way from bees.’

Zoë smiled. ‘Not so far as we have established. Thank God, you do something real, Alex.’ Real? ‘It’s so refreshing to meet someone who does something. I’ve lost count of the number of accountants, lawyers and flaming management consultants I’ve met.’ She raised her hand to mouth and whispered: ‘Like Lewis and Jamie.’ Louder: ‘Give me a decent software engineer any day.’

It was my turn to smile. ‘I’m glad someone appreciates us.’ Although the question I was asking myself was rather how much does she appreciate *me*. Bugger other software engineers. ‘I understand you’re a cosmologist.’

‘I am. It involves a great deal of programming too.’

‘What kinds of cosmology programming do you do?’

Zoë laughed. ‘Which version would you like? The cocktail party version or the *Astrophysical Journal* version?’

‘What about the *Scientific American* version?’

Yes, she was a physics lecturer, a pretty geeky thing to be, but there was geek and there was geek. And from where I was sitting, Zoë didn’t look much like a geek. Having said that, it was easy to imagine her with her hair in a ponytail, wearing in DMs, jeans and a babydoll “I Love My Geek” t-shirt from ThinkGeek. I’d wanked off the other day to a the customer action shots of the women in that t-shirt on the website. That kind of thing is better than Pr0n for some of us. And free. But Zoë certainly scrubbed up well too.

‘OK, we can save the *Astrophysical Journal* version for later.’ Later as in “later tonight”? Or later as in “on a date”? ‘But the *Scientific American* version is that I’m developing programs to simulate the evolution of the very early universe.’

‘Just how early are you talking?’ I said. ‘A few billion years? Millions? Seconds? Attoseconds?’

‘You’ve been reading my papers,’ said Zoë. ‘Attoseconds. I’m developing a model to investigate whether immediately after the Big Bang quantum gravitational effects can cause the formation of pocket universes — miniverses — that might help explain various phenomena of our universe.’

‘Such as?’

‘The imbalance between matter and antimatter.’

‘And dark matter?’

‘Yes,’ said Zoë, ‘one idea is that dark matter might, in part at least, be the gravity of miniverses.’

‘But what about the effect of multiple universes?’ I said.

‘Heh, you *have* been reading my papers!’

‘Well, I did read something about this in *Scientific American* a few months ago.’

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‘Yeah, the article was by a colleague of mine who I did a postdoc with at Stanford,’ said Zoë. ‘He’s very keen on the multi-worlds interpretation of quantum mechanics. I’m not so sure.’

‘Why’s that?’ I said.

‘I don’t buy the idea that the universe splits into multiple copies of itself all the time. Energy conversation for one thing, but it seems just so clumsy and *inelegant* to imagine that at this moment enormous numbers of mutually orthogonal copies of Alex and Zoë are being in this Sardinian restaurant in Notting Hill.’

‘Or a Polish restaurant in Neal Street.’

I noticed Zoë touch her amber amulet. ‘There are no Polish restaurants in Neal Street,’ she said. ‘But there is a very good Indian one.’

‘The Punjab?’ I said.

‘My favourite Indian.’

‘We’d have been much better off going there tonight. I thought it was a pretty dreadful meal tonight,’ said

Zoë took a sip of her grappa. ‘I’ve always been slightly dubious about Italian food,’ she said, ‘and this meal has confirmed me in my prejudices.’

‘French food I can go for,’ I said, ‘but then French food is basically just British food done properly.’

‘Or rather British food is French food just done without the panache and attention to detail’ I took a large gulp of my grappa, which in hindsight was not a particularly sensible thing to do as I was barely able to control the coughing reflex induced by the fiery liquor and thus only just avoided spluttering a mouthful over the front of Zoë’s dress. ‘I like pizza as much as the next woman, but I’ve had too many overpriced Italian meals that have underdelivered like this one. I hate fake Italian waiters too. If they are really Italian, they don’t have to mug it up as they are starring in some sketch from a bad 1970s variety show and if they’re not Italian, so what? I don’t necessarily expect waiters in French restaurants to be Polish. I just expect them to be competent.’

What I wanted to ask Zoë was whether or not she would like to go to a decent restaurant with me sometime. Perhaps the Punjab in Neal Street. Or even a Polish restaurant. There were plenty of them in London even if there were none on Neal Street. I could feel the words forming in my mouth and almost taste them coming out. Each time I didn't quite say them, I felt a slight sense of surprise that I hadn't. If I carried on like that, I would sit there all night gawping like a frog.

'Would you like to go to a good restaurant sometime?' said Zoë.

'I go to good restaurants all the time,' I said.

'I'm sure you do. Would like to go to one with *me*?'

'Ah. Sorry! Sorry! I didn't quite catch your meaning there for a second.' Oh, my God! 'Yes. Yes, of course, I'd love to go to a good restaurant with you. Perhaps the Punjab in Neal Street. Or even a Polish restaurant. There were plenty of them in London even if there were none on Neal Street. I have a feeling that a Polish restaurant would be exactly the right place to go.'

'Yes,' said Zoë. 'I have the feeling it would be too.' She handed me her card.

IMPERIAL COLLEGE LONDON
Department of Physics
Zoë E. Heriot-Shaw
Lecturer in Theoretical Physics

I smiled. I'd been right about the diaeresis.

CHAPTER TWO

PARALLEL 01973 ↑ 5 ↑ 31

9100 WORDS — MARCH 2026

I had been pleased to find the letter from Déjeuner à Deux on the doormat when I had got home a few nights before. I was pleased because going out on a date was always fun. Scratch that. Going out with someone could be fun and going on a date with someone was an necessary prelude to going out with them. I had been a member of D4D for nearly four months now and not all of the men I had met had been borderline psychostalker serial killer candidates. I had been on one or two entertaining dates, which were fine as far as they went, but there was no denying that I was in my mid-thirties now (just) and a women has certain needs that cannot be satisfied by the contents of her goody drawer. I was old enough to know that finding The One was just a fantasy (“Was it?” the voice at the back of my head kept saying, “why should it be just a fantasy?”), but I did at least want to meet The Four-Fifths or, at a pinch, The Two-Thirds. I am a mathematician (I work in a physics department, but don’t let that fool you) and I knew that dating was a numbers game. Although the probability of meeting The One (or

The Four-Fifths or The Two-Thirds) on any given day was very small, the probability of not having met The One (etc.) after a hundred dates was also very small, which meant that it was worth persevering through ninety-nine lousy dates. The mathematics told me so. (The voice at the back of my head told me that this might be one of the reasons why I never met The One (etc.). I ignored it. One thing I did know was that numbers couldn't lie.)

The good thing about DàD was that as a way of getting dates, it was low effort. You just rang up, spoke to one of the consultants (Debbie if you were lucky, who at least did a good imitation of being competent), told them which nights you were free and asked them to arrange a dinner date for you. (Despite the name, they never seemed to arrange lunches, which was fine from my perspective as I'd never got the hang of the half-hour lunch date at a Wendy's when I'd been a postdoc at Stanford. I preferred my dates to have a slower pace than that, to have good food, to offer the possibility of a glass — or two — or three — of decent red, and allow me to unwind and carry out the inevitable post-date post-mortem at home rather than having to go back to work afterwards.) A few days later, you got a letter through telling you to go to Such-and-Such restaurant at a particular time to meet So-and-So. No tedious trawling through profiles, no speculative emails disappearing into the noösphere. No leaving of awkward voicemail messages that were never returned. No trying to think of a decent bar in the Covent Garden area. Dead easy. The bad thing was that you knew nothing about the man before you met other than his first name at that (in this case, Alex, I had discovered on opening the letter), not useful for a search (there are many "Alex"s on the net). You gave guidelines to DàD as to the kind of person that you wanted to meet, but in my personal experience these tended to honored more in the breach than the delivery. I had asked to meet a man who was tall(ish), dark(ish), handsome(ish), professional (no ish about that one) and interested in the arts, culture and science, (*no* ish about those either). However, for some reason, I often found that my dates were short, ugly, blond men who worked as

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recruitment consultants and thought that watching the occasional History Channel documentary on Isambard Kingdom Brunel on demonstrated an ample interest in culture.

I hadn't been so pleased when I had searched for the restaurant. DàD tended to send me on dates in middle-of-the-road, sort-of-all-right-because-you-knew-what-you-were-going-to-get kinds of places like Chez Gérard or Livebait, not restaurants I would choose to go to myself, but the sort of establishment that one might end up at on a not very exciting, but not disastrous first date (which meant middle-of-the-road, sort-of-all-right-because-you-knew-what-you-were-going-to-get kinds of dates). Now and then, they sent even me to good restaurants like Skylon, places I would choose of my own volition, which at least meant that the date began on a positive note. All too often though, I found myself being dispatched sent to the kind of restaurant that I would never dream of visiting myself — overpriced hotel restaurants, North African restaurants serving overcooked vegetables and undercooked lamb, the most egregious type of Italian restaurant with fake Italian waiters and even faker Italian food. Next Tuesday, I discovered from googling the restaurant I was going to be enjoying Traditional British food. I had nothing at all against Traditional British food. I liked few things better than going to one of London's many fine gastropubs and having cream of potato and chervil oil soup, followed by steak and kidney suet pudding with triple cooked beef dripping fat chips and spotted dick with custard for pudding (I also went to the gym five times a week). It would have been good if DàD had decided to send me on a date at one of London's many fine gastropubs. Bumbles was, I read, a restaurant frequented by American tourists and best-known for Mr Bumble's steak and ale *pie*. I had long before learnt never to trust a restaurant that names a dish after itself, much less one that names a dish after its fictional proprietor. The prospect of a date there was not one that electrified my weekend.

I got to Bumbles early. Public transport willing, I always ended up getting to the restaurant early because I always overestimated the time

it would take me to get there and I was always too nervous and self-conscious to walk around the block until the exact time (or, in an ideal world, a few minutes after in order to exercise my prerogative). I always regretted it. It meant that I had to sit in the restaurant for an age while all the waiting staff (who after all knew that I was on a blind date from DàD) and other customers cast glances out of the corners of their eyes at me sitting there on my own as I sipped my glass of still mineral water. If the bloke didn't turn up after a few minutes, which, given that I was often quarter of an hour or more early, was more often than not, I ended up ordering a stiff gin and tonic or a large glass of red in a vain attempt to try and harden my resolve. This made things worse because everyone who had been thinking "Who is this sad, pathetic women (reduced to meeting complete strangers in downmarket restaurants)?", was now thinking "Who is this sad, pathetic, *alcoholic* woman (reduced to meeting complete strangers in downmarket restaurants)?"

I sat there and sipped my glass of red. It had arrived in a small cut-glass goblet; they only did one size. I remember that I had once gone for Christmas dinner with the family home of a boyfriend whose parents had had identical glasses. I never thought I could cope across something quite so d'eclass'e in my life again. Yet here I was on a romantic (ha!) date at a restaurant that used the same glasses. The bloke hadn't even turned up and already the date felt ruined. Perhaps he'd searched for Bumbles and decided to make a run for the hills. I couldn't blame him if he had. It would be just my luck if he turned out to be as unappealing as the glassware, another chartered surveyor from Croydon. Consider the bloke I had had my last "lunch" with. A banker called Alastair. Not bad looking. My type: tall, dark and handsome. They got that much right. He even resembled Miles from certain angles. Did something in the City. *God* was he dull and stupid. That had been a complete waste of three hours of my life. Every date I went on like that made me wonder why I even bothered trying.

I felt a crushing weight of depression press down on me and took a small sip of wine (the glass wasn't big enough for the slurp I wanted to

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take). It wouldn't be so bad if the universe were constructed in such a way that one bad date would be compensated by a good one next time. The world, I had discovered, did not work like that. Each date was an independent event and thus the probability of it going nowhere was the same, all things being equal, which given that I had no say over who I met through DàD was a not unreasonable assumption. This Alex might be even worse than Alastair. He might even be worse than the bloke who didn't know where the National Theatre was and thought that there ought to be a statue of the Queen Mother on the fourth plinth in Trafalgar Square. He might even be worse than the man who had asked me over a shared starter of duck liver pate on brioche with apple and fig chutney whether I had ever had a threesome. It had been all I could do to prevent myself spitting half-chewed pieces of pate, brioche and chutney all over his Hackett jacket. I had had a threesome, both kinds in fact, but I wasn't going to tell him that twenty minutes after we had met. He might even be worse than the bloke who was 55 if he were a day and went on and on about his ex-wife (despite the fact that I had requested that I didn't want to meet any divorced men) and his children (despite the fact that I had requested that I didn't want to meet any men with kids). This Alex had much to live up to.

I heard a cough behind me. I was jolted out of my reverie.

'Madam,' said the waiter, 'your... *friend*.'

I stood up and turned round. About 5'9", thinning brown hair, cute rather than handsome. His suit looked well cut though. Difficult to tell for definite at first glance, but I didn't think he was my type.

'Hi, I'm Alex.'

'Hi, I'm Zoë.' We shook hands. Firm enough and dry enough. 'It's good to meet you.'

'I'm really sorry I'm late,' said Alex. I glanced at my watch. It was twenty-five past seven. He was five minutes early.

'That's all right,' I said. 'Sit down, please, sit down.'

He sat down and picked up the menu. I hadn't been able to face the thought of Mr Bumble's steak and ale pie. I picked up my menu.

We sat there. The menu was 30 centimetres in front of my face, but I couldn't make out a thing on it. My brain was trying so hard to think of something witty and pithy (or anything at all) to say that it had been forced to close down my visual processing circuits in order to use the processing capacity for verbal reasoning. I had a PhD in theoretical cosmology from Cambridge and I couldn't think of anything to say. I had been struck dumb by the sheer ridiculousness of how we were intending to spend the evening.

'It's, er. . . not a very exciting menu,' said Alex.

Now that we a conversation topic, my visual processing circuits were able to snap back into visual processing mode. I looked at the menu. He wasn't wrong. Mr Bumble's steak and ale pie looked the most appetising thing on it.

Alex sat back in his chair and surveyed the restaurant for a few seconds, the decor, the diners, the food, the waiters. Then he leaned forwards towards me.

'You know,' he said, 'we don't have to stay here. We could go to a proper restaurant.'

I took one look at my half-full wine glass. I picked it up and drained the remains in one gulp.

'We're out of here.'

A minute and a half later we were on the street.

'What kind of food do you like?' said Alex.

'Good food,' I said. 'What do you like?'

'Good' he waved his hand towards Bumbles, 'traditional British, modern British, French, Indian, Polish.'

'Indian's always good,' I said.

'Yes,' he said, 'it is.' Alex turned round, put out his arm and a taxi drew up. I almost laughed out loud. Had he had the taxi waiting around the corner all the time? He opened the door for me and I got in.

'The Punjab restaurant in Neal Street, please,' said Alex. The Punjab? *My favourite* Indian. It was too early to tell Alex that though.

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Twenty minutes later, we were in the restaurant, munching poppadoms and pickles. and drinking Cobra.

‘What do you do?’ I said. ‘Boring question, I know, but it has to asked sooner or later.’

‘It’s a bit complicated,’ said Alex. ‘I’m basically a project manager for a software company. Which is about as dull as it sounds.’

‘What sort of software?’

‘Ah,’ I saw Alex perk up. He dipped his poppadom in the mango chutney and took a bite. ‘That’s where it does start to get genuinely interesting,’ he said through a mouthful of poppadom. In ordinary circumstances I wouldn’t find someone speaking with his mouth full attractive, but there was something about the enthusiasm in Alex’s voice that managed to overcome that reflex. ‘We started off modelling the diffusion of innovations, that is to say stimulating the behaviour of customers in buying new products. A bit like one of those computer games in which you watch simulated people living out simulated lives.’

‘Like *The Sims*,’ I said.

‘Yes,’ said Alex, ‘a little bit like the *The Sims*, but on a giant scale, without the graphics and aimed at the marketing departments of large corporations. But then we realised that what we had, in effect, created was an entire online world. And massive multiplayer online roleplaying games are the one of the flavours of the year. So, we thought, since we’ve already got the world and the underlying software engine, all we need to do is tweak things a bit to turn it into, well. . . a sort of entertainment. So that’s what we did. It’s been up and running for a couple of months now. It’s not really a game, but it is fun to just watch the antics the simulated people get up to. And it’s much more interesting than the work I was doing until a few months ago anyway.’

Our starters arrived and we eat for a short while before I resumed the conversation.

‘What’s its USP?’

Alex’s brow creased. His hand stopped in mid-air with a piece of chicken chat halfway to his mouth.

'The Oracle runs on PCs. OK, PCs are rather more powerful today than they were ten years ago, but even with what is in effect a super-computer on your desktop, you can't match the raw computing power of the server farm — like the one our company has set up. And, this is our USP: your characters get to interact with the characters that other people have created, not just pre-canned ones included with the software. Which makes things both more interesting and more realistic. Of course, the great thing for us, is that we can run our business clients' simulations on top of our consumer clients' ones. It's win-win situation. Everyone gets a better simulation, a more accurate one and a more interesting one.'

I swallowed a piece of my pakora. 'How do you calibrate the simulations?'

'That bit,' said Alex, 'is more of an art than a science.'

'I can believe it.' I took a drink of lager. I was glad Alex had suggested bailing out of Bumbles. 'It's a problem I have all the time. I carry out simulations of the evolution of the early universe. Quite different from your simulations, but in both cases we have to make sure that results of the simulations match empirical reality — as far as we can measure it.'

'On the entertainment side, the paying customers gets what they get and if they don't like it, they can go somewhere else. Of course, if too many customers were to do that we'd be in trouble. But for the business clients we have to put a huge amount of time and effort in making sure that the simulations really do match the empirical data on customer behaviour. It's a nightmare, an interesting nightmare sometimes, but still a nightmare.'

The waiter cleared away the remains of our starters.

'How do you cope with this nightmare?' I said.

'They say,' said Alex, 'that a fly's behaviour can be modelled using about a hundred transistors.'

I raised an eyebrow. 'Transistors? A hundred doesn't seem very many. And people are rather more complicated?'

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‘Well, indeed,’ said Alex. ‘The human brain is the most complex object that we’ve so far encountered in the universe. But it’s surprising how realistic the behaviour you can get seems to be just by adjusting a few parameters that control the behaviour of each software agent in the simulation. It’s like ants in *SimAnt* or in real life following a few simple rules over and over again. As far as the results of the simulation are concerned what matters isn’t what individual people might think or feel, it’s how they interact with other people. And there are only a limited number of ways in which people can interact with one another.’

‘Fight, flight,’ I said, ‘or the other word that begins with an “F”.’ Alex looked as though he had just discovered that there was a flake of very hot chilli stuck between two of his teeth.

He took a long drink of lager. ‘The simulation isn’t pitched at quite such a purely Hobbesian level. There are a few more options than those three in the game.’

‘I should hope so, but sex and violence seem as popular in virtual worlds as they do in the real one.’

‘It is a simulation rather than a game,’ said Alex. ‘You set up your characters and then you see what they do. Which is only rarely fight or flight given that we are mostly trying to model Britain in the first decade of the twenty-first century.’

‘Twenty-first century Britons do do more of the third “F” though,’ I said.

‘We don’t not really emphasise that particular angle. It does go on to a certain extent, but it’s all very discreet.’

‘Don’t you think you are missing a trick there?’ Alex looked as though he had discovered another chilli flake.

‘It’s something we could look into the future, I suppose,’ he said, ‘but we aren’t really that kind of business.’ I had to admit that he did look cuter when he was discomforted.

‘Would you say then that what you are doing is an application of artificial intelligence.’

‘Not in the substantive sense. But it is artificial life.’

‘You use genetic algorithms?’ I said. ‘With random mutations?’

‘We do,’ said Alex. ‘But I don’t mean just in that sense. The agents in the game, yes, they aren’t intelligent in the way that humans are, yes, they aren’t self-aware in the way that higher animals are, but they are, I think, at least as alive as amoebae in a pond are alive. They take in resources from their environment, they, in a certain sense, excrete waste products, they interact with other agents, they are born, they reproduce, they die. That seems pretty much like life to me.’ Our mains had arrived. I munched on a piece of pomegranate lamb. It was a pity that Alex was only cute rather than tall, dark and handsome. This was the kind of pillow talk I had always wanted, but so never got. If I had a choice between great sex with hot-looking guys and pillow talk about the philosophical implications of the existence of artificial life, I would have to ask why I couldn’t have both.

‘The difference though,’ I said, ‘is that the agents only do what you do because you programmed them to do it. They didn’t emerge in a spontaneous way as life did in our universe through the workings of physical processes over time.’

‘That’s true, but does that mean they aren’t alive?’

‘A machine like a steam engine isn’t alive. Neither is an AIBO even if it is, in some ways, a good simulacra of a real dog.’

‘We wouldn’t typically think of a steam engine as being alive,’ Alex said. ‘It has a metabolism, but it doesn’t really interact with its environment in the way that a biological entity does. I think though that a case could be made for an AIBO being as alive as the agents in our simulations. But I don’t think that the fact the agents were created rather than evolved means that they can’t be alive. We know theoretically that self-replicating machines are possible. Von Neumann proved that in the fifties. It would have embarrassing if he hadn’t because we have plenty of empirical existence proofs for self-replicating machines. But the ability to self-replicate, a pretty good working definition of life, I think, can arise either through creation or evolution.’

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‘It would be easier to convince me that an AIBO was alive than that your software agents were,’ I said. ‘At least it’s instantiated in the real, physical world. It would be even easier if it were self-reproducing.’

‘But a computer is instantiated in the real, physical world. Computer life is just implemented on a different physical substrate. Why should it be necessarily less real than non-computer life? For all we know, our world might just a non-random fluctuations in the quantum vacuum or just one simulation in an infinite stack of simulations.’

‘I think we can distinguish between the real world and virtual ones. I’ve spent more than a decade studying cosmology. I ought to be able.’

I thought I detected Alex raise a sceptical eyebrow.

‘Would you like a coffee?’ he said.

This was the kind of conversation to have over coffee and Calvados, but it was a school night and besides I wasn’t sure how much I fancied Alex. I liked him and he was interested in the kinds of things I was interested in and as a software engineer working in artificial life/artificial intelligence he did something more conversation-worthy than the average doctor or lawyer or management consultant or banker that I meet through DàD. I was looking for The One and it was much more probable that The One would be a doctor or lawyer or management consultant or banker than a software engineer — wasn’t it?

We walked to Covent Garden tube. Half my brain seemed to be having be having an animated and, by all accounts, enjoyable conversation with Alex about how it was possible to distinguish between real and artificial life. The other half was pondering two things: (a) was Alex going to ask me out again? (b) how was I going to turn him down. I could take the offensive position and say to him ‘Alex, thanks for a great evening and thanks for saving us from the nightmare prospect of three hours in Bumbles, but I don’t think there is enough chemistry between us and I don’t think there would be any point us meeting up again.’ Alex would know where I stood and the walk back to the tube and the pressure of forced good humour and unrealistic expectations would be lifted. It was much easier to follow my usual pattern. It was possible

that he might not ask me out again in which case problem solved and there would have been no need for me to embarrass myself by saying anything. If he did ask me (and from his body language I was rather fearing that he might), I would just have to say no, or rather something non-committal sounding that amounted to saying no. In the world of twenty-first century dating, “maybe” meant “if you ever come within five hundred metres of me again, I will slap a restraining order on you so fast, you’ll discover that time travel does exist in our universe.”

It would be best for both of us if I were to grasp the nettle right now. ‘Alex,’ I said, ‘I enjoyed our conversation, but. . .’

I could see Alex’s face fall

‘Yes, yes,’ he said, his voice higher than it had been, ‘I did too, but, yes, if that’s what you want, then, of course.’

That went about as well as it could have, I thought, and any untoward awkwardness on either side had been avoided.

I woke up the next morning. I was thinking soft and fuzzy thoughts about Alex. The higher cognitive functions of my brain switched on and I jolted awake. What the hell was I doing having soft and fuzzy thoughts about Alex while I was asleep? I mean, when I went on a good date, I quite often woke up with softy and fuzzy feelings about the guy. Last night hadn’t been a good date. Had it? I needed to speak to Nicola. Quarter past seven in the morning. Too early to call her? Not in a crisis like this.

‘What was wrong with him?’ she said as soon as I had outlined the situation.

‘He wasn’t my type,’ I said.

‘Meaning that he wasn’t tall, dark and handsome?’

‘Well. . .’

‘OK,’ said Nicola. ‘Was he handsome?’

‘He was quite cute, I suppose,’ I said, ‘and he was wearing a good suit.’

‘There you go then. That gives you something to work with. Was he blond or a ginga?’

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‘No. . . .’

‘So, dark-ish then?’ said Nicola. ‘Two out of three isn’t bad. What did you talk about?’

‘Artificial intelligence,’ I said.

Nicola snorted with laughter. ‘This guy whisks you again from some God-awful restaurant, takes you, quite by chance to your favourite Indian restaurant where it turns out that all his favourite Indian dishes are your favourite ones, spends the evening talking about the kinds of scientific matters you like talking about, pays for dinner and you wake up dreaming about him and you don’t know why? Zo, what planet are you on? When was the last time you met a guy who you clicked with like that?’

‘Er. . .’

‘Exactly,’ said Nicola. ‘And why don’t you want to go on a date with this guy? I’ll tell you why. Because he’s not Miles, that’s why.’

‘Hold on,’ I said, ‘there wasn’t any chemistry between us.’

‘That’s because you wouldn’t let the reaction getting going. Look, give him a second chance. What’s the worst thing that’s going to happen, and before you say *that*, what’s the worst thing that is actually likely to happen? You go on a second date, you talk about matters scientific, philosophical and literary for a couple of hours and there’s still no chemistry. But it’s obvious there *is* chemistry or you wouldn’t be dreaming about him. Give him a second chance. Give *yourself* a second chance.’

‘I can’t. I don’t have his email address or phone number.’

‘Jeesh, Zo,’ said Nicola. ‘You might have a first class degree in mathematics, but you wouldn’t make much of a private detective. Ring up Déjeuner à Deux and ask for his number.’

‘I can’t do that,’ I said. ‘They wouldn’t tell me. They’d think I was some kind of stalker.’

‘No, they wouldn’t because you aren’t. OK, do you know his surname?’

‘No.’

‘OK,’ said Nicola, ‘not helpful. Do you know what he does?’

‘He works for some kind of computer company,’ I said, ‘that runs an online game called something a bit like *The Oracle*.’

‘Bingo! That’s a pretty good lead. Narrows things down a lot. This is the twenty-first century. You search for the name of the company. There’s a good chance that you’ll get find his surname on the company website. Then you can email him.’

‘I can’t email him! What would he think?’

‘He’d think: “An attractive woman with whom I went on a fun date last night and then blew me out has changed her mind and asked me out on a date after all. That’s rather nice”,’ said Nicola What do you think he’d think. Jeesh, Zo, you’ve got to get over this “All men are complete bastards” way of thinking. All men aren’t bastards. Yes, some men are and, yes, Miles was one of them, but there’s no reason to tar Alex with that brush after you’ve only met him for three hours and especially if you are waking up thinking about him, which means that your subconscious obviously doesn’t think he is a bastard. Anyway, Zo, I’ve got to run to work. I’ll see you tomorrow. And I’ll want to know exactly what you’ve done by then to track down this elusive Alex.’

As soon as I got to the office and had my computer turned on, I typed

Alex "massive multiplayer online
role playing game" "The Oracle"

into the search engine and pressed RETURN.

There were a number of hits. *The Oracle* was a popular game and Alex a not uncommon name of its players, but I didn’t have to go down the list far before I found my man. I clicked on the link. There was a corporate publicity shot of Alex. It was recent one and he was wearing what appeared to the same suit as last night. I had to admit to myself that in the picture, he did look cute.

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‘Alex Blackwell: Project Manager — Software Development,’ the paragraph under the picture read, ‘Alex has worked at Electra Research since 1999 in a variety of roles including software engineer and systems designer. He is currently project manager for *The Oracle* project. Alex has a BSc in Chemistry and Computing from King’s College London and previously worked as programmer in defence research and the pharmaceutical industry. Contact Alex on alex.blackwell@electra-research.com.’

I had email address and an invitation from his company to contact him. I now knew a little bit more about his academic and career history. King’s College London? I did my first postdoc at King’s College London. It wasn’t Imperial College or my own alma mater, but it was a good enough university. I couldn’t give to Nicola as a reason for rejecting Alex. enough to reject. She’d gone out for five years with Darrel, a guy with a two-two from Lancaster. He had been very rich and very good looking though, whereas Alex was just intriguing and sort of cute.

If I were ever going to be able to look my best friend straight in the eye again I had no choice but to email him.

Alex,

Zoe here from the Dejeuner a
Deux date at Bumbles or rather
the Punjab. Thanks for
suggesting we change restaurant.
I did have a good time last
night. Sorry for any confusion
at the end of the date. If you’d
like to meet up again that would
be cool.

Have a fun day,

Zoe

My heart thumping as I clicked SEND. What had I let myself in for?

I looked at my watch. It was later than I had realised. Time to forget about Alex. I was meeting my friend Zac. He had managed to persuade me to be his 'date' at a Have You Met My Friend? dating event. He had told me that I was the only single woman he knew and the USP of the event was that participants were supposed to bring a single friend of the opposite sex. There might be some men there who were closer matches for my non-negotiable criteria than Alex.

An hour later I was standing in the corner of the upstairs area of a bar in the City with Zac, sipping a glass of overpriced Gamay Noir.

'Women always complain that there are no decent men out there,' I said 'and men always complain that there are no decent women.'

'Yet here we are,' said Zac, 'two counter-examples to the proposition that there are no decent single men or women out there.'

'Yes, but that only works for us if they is at least one additional decent pair of men/women out there somewhere for us.' I scanned the room. Where there any single decent men in the room? The best looking man by far was the organiser of the event. He was surrounded by a cloud of female admirers. No point trying to compete with them. Most of the rest of the men matched the description of the kind of man one would expect to find at a low-rent dating event on a Thursday evening.

I took a sip of wine. Was Zac the next best man here? I liked him, but he was called Zac. There was no way I could bring myself to go out with someone called Zac. Miles, yes. Alex, why not? Zac (or even Zachary), no. More relevant was the fact that there was no way that I could bring myself to go out with someone two inches shorter than me. I'm 5'3". Zac always insisted that Paul Simon was 5'1" and he had married Carrie Fisher. I always pointed out that they got divorced eleven months later. Zac was also younger than me and I have always gone for older men and as he was only two years younger, he could not qualify for a special dispensation as a toy boy.

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It was not as though I did not feel terrible about it. He was not ugly and he did not have any non-ignorable personality defects. He was just very short. At Zac's height, there weren't that many women shorter than him and most women I know want a man who is taller than them. Finding taller men was not a problem for me, but even if Zac had been 5'5", I would still have ruled him out as a potential partner. I wanted my partner to be at least two or three inches taller than me even when I was wearing killer heels, which means 5'8" as a minimum. Zac had to make up for his lack of height with his sparkling personality. I often joked that if he had to rely on that, he might as well give up his hunt for a girlfriend now.

'No-one you're interested in?' I said.

Zac sucked on his bottle of beer. 'Humh. I'll tell you one thing that I find off-putting,' he started gesticulating with the bottle to rhythm of his words. 'Women in their dating profiles going on how all their friends are getting married and having babies. Now, of course, writing that in their profile indicates that they are desperate and desperate is good because you'd have to be desperate to go out with me, but I always feel that there are some things better left unsaid and that's one of them.'

'They're just sending out the message,' I said, 'that they want to get married and have children. In evolutionary terms, it doesn't always pay to be too subtle.'

'But a bloke would never write something that like that.'

'Of course not,' I said.

'That's not fair. What about a level playing field for both sexes?'

I laughed. 'A level playing field? If only you men knew. I would think any man who wrote something like that was a self-pitying wimp.'

'But why is then it OK for women?'

'Our biological clocks are ticking. It's just not the same if you're a man. The quality and quantity of your sperm might go down with time, but you can still impregnate women in your eighties. I'm 33. If I met someone this week, I'm not going to move in with him until I've got to know him well, which takes at least a full annual cycle, 12 to

18 months. After we've moved in together, I'm going to want to live with him for at least another 12 to 18 months to make sure that we are compatible. That's an average of 30 months before deciding to get married. Add another 6 to 12 months before the actual wedding and that's an expectation value of 39 months before I can start trying for a baby. On average it takes 6 to 12 months to get pregnant, maybe longer given that my fecundity is plummeting as we speak, and other 9 months before the baby is born. That's a mean of 57 months, almost five years from before I have the baby. I'd be 38. That assumes that nothing goes wrong during that period like falling out of love with the person or him running off with someone 10 years younger or things just taking longer because time goes so fast. So, yes, I can much understand why those women write what they do in their profiles.'

'I didn't even know,' said Zac, 'that you wanted children.'

I took another sip of wine. 'I might tell you a lot of things, Zac, but I don't tell you everything.' I didn't know if I did want children, but I knew that I didn't *not* want them. Zac was a man. I didn't tell him everything. I couldn't. He wouldn't believe it.

'You know. . . ' said Zac, 'if you ever did want to have children. . . '

'Know what?'

'Well. . . my services are. . . I mean I'm always available.'

'Available?' I said. 'What do you mean. . . Oh, my God, you cannot be serious?' A vision of Zac humping away on top of me like a miniature marmoset mating with a flashed through my head followed by one involving Zac coming out of the bathroom and handing me a spunk-filled turkey baster. 'Good God, no! What the hell are you thinking?'

'Well,' said Zac, 'lots of people have pacts. You know the kind of thing. They agree that if both of them are still single when they get to, oh, I don't know, say. . . 35, they'll get married.'

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‘No, Zac, no,’ I said. ‘Lots of people don’t. People have that kind of pact in bad chick lit novels. Not in real life. In case, you haven’t noticed, we aren’t in a bad chick lit novels. This is real life. I am not getting married to you when I am 35.’

‘Well, OK, 40 then.’

‘Or 40.’

‘We don’t even have to get married,’ he said. ‘We could just live together. Or I could just father your child and come round at weekends and holidays.’

Zac, I thought, if you and I were the last two people left on Earth, I’d have to let the human race die out rather than spawn a race of mid-gets. I thought it best though not to say that to him. ‘It’s just not going to happen.’

‘Well, it’s a standing offer,’ said Zac. ‘Think it over. There’s no need to dismiss it out of hand straightaway. It’ll be still be there if you do need it.’

I sipped by drink and took another look around the room. ‘Where are all the decent men?’ I said. Zac raised his eyebrows. ‘Apart from you, of course.’ I thought back to last night. Alex had been quite cute, I suppose, in a sort of spoddy college boy kind of way. Spoddy college boy wasn’t my type. For years, I had pretended that I didn’t have a type, in part because I was a spoddy college girl myself and in part because it wasn’t considered the done thing to have a type. It wasn’t until I was doing my post-doc at SLAC that I realised the kind of man I could date. Dotcom millionaires. Sand Hill Road venture capitalists. Swiss bankers like Fabien. Hot-shot lawyers like Miles. Which was why I didn’t want to start dating men like Alex or Zac again.

It wasn’t that men hadn’t talked to me that night. It was just that I didn’t want to talk to the ones who did. They were too short or too ugly or too fat or too bald or too young or their nascent mental instabilities were too close to the surface. It was safer to retreat into the corner and licked my wounded pride until it was late enough that I could make my goodbyes to Zac.

Out of the corner of my eye, I caught a glance of someone who seemed familiar. Someone from work? I hoped not. One of the City types I had been on a *Déjeuner à Deux* date with? There seemed to be a lot of people milling around in that particular area. Perhaps I had been mistaken. Then I saw him. Oh, my God, it was Alex. What the hell was he doing here? The same thing as me, I presumed, but that wasn't the point. I didn't want to bump into him now, not after I had sent him that email only a couple of hours earlier. What was he going to think? We couldn't spend the rest of the evening making conversation with other people and just ignore one another. Perhaps he hadn't seen me. I was standing close to the entrance to the ladies.

'Excuse me, Zac,' I said, 'I just need to. . .' I slipped into the toilets. The problem was, I decided five minutes later, I couldn't stay in there all night. First, Zac would start wondering what I was doing. Second, I was already very bored. I'd just to go home and write the evening off as a loss. It wasn't as though any chance of me meeting anyone new and interesting anyway.

I left the ladies and had a good, hard look around the bar area. No sign of either Alex or Zac. Zac I could text later on. He might only be five feet one, but he was old enough to look after himself. If Alex was out of the way, I could skulk off to the cloakroom, grab my coat and be on my way. I turned to make for the exit.

'What the. . .' exclaimed a male voice, familiar from a recent meeting.

'What the. . .' I exclaimed as it dawned on me that (a) I had rammed into Alex at high speed; (b) from the wetness that was seeping through my dress and the large red stain on his grey suit I had managed to spill half of Alex's glass of wine all over him and the other half over my *agnès b* little black dress.

'Oh my God,' I said. 'I'm so sorry!' I said.

'No, no, it was my fault,' said Alex. I gave him full marks for gallantry, but given that I hadn't been looking where I was going it was my fault.

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‘Er... let me get something to mop ourselves up with.’ I popped backed into the ladies and grabbed a bunch of paper towels. I stopped for a second and looked in the mirror. I dabbed at my dress. Why hadn’t I looked where I was going? Why was he skulking outside the women’s toilets anyway? No time to ponder these questions now. Alex was outside dripping. I left the toilet, checking to make sure that I wasn’t going to run into anyone this time. Alex was standing there. *some*. I handed him some paper towels. If he thought I was going to start patting him on the second date, he was mistaken. Not that this was second date.

‘I’m so sorry, I really am,’ said Alex as did his best with the towels to try and soak up some of the wine. ‘Send me the bill for dry cleaning your dress. Please.’ More marks for gallantry.

I looked at his jacket. There was a large red stain across the righthand side. I patted myself with the towels. Alex seemed to have caught more wine than me. If it had been the other way round and that had been my dress I would have been fuming.

‘Let me pay for your bill,’ I said.

‘No, no,’ I said Alex. ‘I can’t do that.’

‘No, it was my fault.’ There was no way I could avoid saying it. ‘Look, let me at least buy you a replacement drink. It’s the least I can do.’

‘Well...’

‘Go on!’ Did I want him to say no or not? ‘You will.’

‘Oh, OK, yeah, thanks. That would be good.’

We walked over the bar. A gap appeared in the crowd as though by a miracle.

‘What would you like?’ I said.

‘A Gamay Noir, please.’ Good choice. I did like a decent Gamay. We’d been drinking beer last night, so we hadn’t had the chance to discuss our wine preferences yet.

‘Two Gamay Noirs, please,’ I said to the barman. ‘Large ones.’

‘Here’s hoping the red wine stains come out,’ I said when we picked up our drinks.

‘Indeed,’ said Alex.

We clinked glasses.

‘What brings you here then?’ I said.

‘Well. . .’ The same thing as you, I could hear him thinking. But then I was only here because of Zac. So who was Alex’s plus one? ‘I got your email.’

‘OK.’

‘It would be good to go out again,’ said Alex. ‘I’d like that. I mean. . . after this if you’d like to.’

‘We are sort of going out again now,’ I said.

Alex laughed. ‘I wasn’t quite expecting it to be like this.’

‘No.’ I took a sip of wine. ‘Neither was I. One guy came up to me and told me he had memorised my profile from the website. He said he had memorised the details of all the women.’

‘He told you he had memorised other women’s details too?’

‘Yes. Had it just been me I might have been flattered that he’d been struck by some particular detail in my profile and remembered it. Memorising everyone’s? He gets extra credit for doing his homework.’

‘But loses the credit and gets a demerit,’ said Alex. ‘It’s a bit of a potential psychostalker thing to do. I wouldn’t do that. Or I wouldn’t use it as part of a chat-up line.’ He looked at me. ‘Er. . . I hasten to add that I haven’t memorised your profile. Or anyone else’s. I don’t have chat-up lines anyway.’

I touched his arm. ‘I didn’t think you had.’

I spotted Zac coming towards us. At least there were two sane men here. At least Zac didn’t know anything about last night. Alex and Zac exchanged weary nods.

‘Zac’s an old friend of mine.’ I saw relief write itself across Alex’s face. Zac though was still defensive. Hundreds of millions of years of mammalian evolution is a wonderful thing. He stared at Alex’s badge.

‘Why is your username “Fluorine”?’

‘Because it’s my favorite element,’ said Alex. It seemed like a sensible answer to me.

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'You have a favourite element?' said Zac.

'Doesn't everyone?' said Alex.

'No,' said Zac.

'Well, it was more my favourite element when I was younger, I'll admit. I did chemistry and computing at university, so I was very into the different elements at the time.'

'I didn't had a favourite element at school,' I said, 'but I did have a favourite number: 1973. It was the year I was born in and it's prime. In fact, I was born on the 31st of May: 31/5/1973. They're all prime numbers. How could I not have turned out to be a mathematician after that?'

'How cool is that?' said Alex. 'Prime numbers are the chemical elements of mathematics.'

Zac didn't look convinced, but then he'd done English Literature. How could be understand those of us who love science and mathematics? I'd once tried to explain to Miles about 31/5/1973. He hadn't understood or seemed to understand that there was something to understand. Alex might not be as tall, dark or handsome as Miles, but he understood.

'I'm just going to the. . .' said Zac. I drained my glass.

'Would you like another one?' said Alex when Zac was out of earshot. I looked around me. I had mentioned prime numbers on my profile, but the memory guy hadn't picked up on it. Was I going to meet another man who understood here tonight? I only needed one and he was offering to buy me a drink.

'You know,' I said, 'we don't have to stay here. The Marquis of Granby is just round the corner.'

'What about Zac?'

'He can look after himself. How did you come with?'

'My best gal pal, Andrea. She's over there.' He gestured towards a group of people on the other side of the bar. I assumed Andrea was the tall woman.

'You can text her from the pub.'

‘I can,’ said Alex and drained his glass. ‘We’re out of here.’

Five minutes later we were in the pub.

‘What sort of day did you have?’ said Alex.

I wanted to say: ‘The sort of day in which I wake up feeling aroused from dreaming about a man I thought I never wanted to see again, a day in which my best friend persuades me through judicious application of guilt to track the man down, a day in which I manage to summon up the courage to send an email to the man I had batted away a few hours earlier, a day in which I then bumped into the man — in a literal sense — and spilt red wine all over his suit. All in all, not a normal day at all to be honest.’ Instead I said: ‘Oh, you know, the usual.’

Alex looked at me with an expression that said ‘What the hell does that mean?’ In a caring way though.

‘I solved an equation that’s been bugging me for a while,’ I said.

‘Using an innovative and exciting new analytical approach?’

‘No, brute force. We have to solve most of the equations using numerical methods. I’ve got to make sure that the new solution does always converges. I think it does.’

‘Subtlety was never my strong point in maths.’ Alex took a sip of his pint of cider. ‘That’s why I did chemistry and computing. You can always use a computational sledgehammer to crack a mathematical walnut, which is what most computational chemistry requires. I started a PhD in it, but, well, it didn’t work out. I’m still using large amounts of raw computing though, even if the chemistry has pretty much gone by the wayside.’

‘I’m not a mathematician any more either,’ I said. ‘I’m a physicist now. Theorems are very beautiful, but I need something real.’

Later, we walked back to the tube station. It felt odd that it was only twenty four hours since we had first done that. It seemed that it had happened in another world to another Zoë.

I couldn’t help myself. On the tube platform I kissed Alex. Alex seemed like the kind of guy who might not be a good kisser. Perhaps I was trying that out to see if there was a reason to tell Nicola. As we were

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kissing, I wondered if men discuss whether women are good kissers or not with their male friends. I doubted it. I would like to have asked Alex if they did, but somehow it wasn't the right time or place, so I kissed him again instead. I pushed my tongue into his mouth and felt him push his into mine. A good kisser. I ran my hand along his back and pushed my body against his.

Snogging in public: you know you shouldn't do it and when you see other people doing it, you think to yourself 'Look at them! Where the hell do they think they are? Can't they go somewhere more private? Don't they realise what a risible spectacle they are making of themselves?' You have to make the spectacle of yourselves. At that moment, you can't go somewhere more private. That's the whole problem. If it's a choice between either snogging in public or nothing at all, snogging in public wins out every time for me. I'd care what the Thursday night crowd thought of me.

We broke our clinch.

'Would you still like to go out again?' said Alex.

'Yes,' I said, 'yes, I would. I'd like that very much.'

CHAPTER THREE

PARALLEL 03333 ↑ 3 ↑ 3

8600 WORDS — MARCH 2026

‘We ought to,’ said Andrea, ‘at least try to do some mingling.’

I wanted to say ‘Do we have to? Can’t we just stay here in the corner of the bar all night and get drunk?’ But instead I said ‘Well, it is what we came for.’ The prospect of mingling filled me with dread. This was partly because the idea of mingling always filled me with dread and partly because there didn’t appear to be anyone in the bar that I particularly wanted to mingle with. Apart from Andrea, of course, but, in the circumstances, she didn’t count.

I looked around the room. We were in the rather dingy basement bar of a fashionable restaurant in Soho. The restaurant might have been doing OK for itself, but the bar obviously wasn’t, which was why they were hiring it out to the Singles Salon on a Friday night. There were various knots of mostly female people dotted around. Not that much competition then. Humh. I selected what looked like the most promising group of women. ‘OK,’ I said to Andrea. ‘I’m going in. Wish me luck.’

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‘You’ll need it,’ said Andrea, which was certainly true, but not necessarily what I wanted to hear.

I walked over to the cluster of three women I had identified. Well, when I say “walked”, I mean “moved”. In these kinds of circumstances, I find it surpassingly hard to simply *walk*. I suddenly become acutely conscious of the exact characteristics of my gait. And the more conscious I am of it, the more I feel that as though I am walking rather in the manner of a constipated crab. Which, I am told, is not typically perceived as a particularly attractive way to walk.

The three women turned and looked at me as I approached them. God knows what they must have thought seeing me shuffling across the floor towards them. There was a tall one, a small one and an in-between one.

‘Hi,’ I said, ‘I’m Alex.’

‘Hi,’ said the tall one. She wasn’t bad-looking, but I don’t go for tall women, not being particularly tall myself, which is one of the reasons why I had never gone out with Andrea. The main reason was that she didn’t want to go out with me. But it was useful for me to have a plausible excuse at my fingertips in order to try and preserve some self-respect. ‘I’m Amanda. And this is my friend, Jane,’ she indicated the short one. ‘And this is Heidi,’ by a process of elimination the in-between one, ‘who we’ve just met.’

‘Hi,’ I said.

‘Hi,’ said Jane and Heidi.

‘Is this your first Singles Salon event?’ said Amanda.

Which is a surprising difficult question to answer. The truth was that I had been to many Singles Salon events before. But if I said that it would imply that I was a sad, pathetic individual who spent much or all of his out-of-work hours skulking around singles events. The truth was that I *was* a sad, pathetic individual who spent his out-of-work hours skulking around singles events, but I didn’t want to admit that to a group of complete strangers, much less a group of reasonably attractive complete strangers, a group of reasonably attractive strangers, one

or more of whom might be single (it was never a given that a woman at this type of event was single; she might have come along to give mutual support to her friend), one or more of whom might be persuaded to go on a date with me, one of whom might (hope springs eternal and all that) be my Future Life Partner.

‘No,’ I said, ‘no, it’s not my first event. I’ve been to. . . one or two before. And how about you? Is this your first?’

‘Yes, yes, it’s my first,’ said Amanda. ‘I’ve wanted to go one for ages and I finally managed to persuade Jane to come with me. So, here we are.’

Yes, you are, I thought. I looked at Jane. She was certainly more than passably attractive. But from the look on her face though, she didn’t look particularly happy to be here. And she was wearing an. . . engagement ring. One of the problems with dating events was that women tended to go in pairs with one keen one, who was, (presumably) single, and one less keen one, who might well not be or, if she was, has a rather more negative attitude towards the whole project than her friend. The women-tend-to-go-in-pairs situation was a real issue for single men. I went to dating events to meet single women who might actually want to go on dates with me or, at the very least, *a* date. I didn’t really want to meet the friends of these women who turn out to be either not single at all or, if they were single, didn’t really want to be there, weren’t interested in meeting men and wouldn’t go out with a bloke they met at one of these events because by definition he must be a social inadequate. I understood why women often preferred to go to these events with a friend, for God’s sake, *I* went with a friend, some of the time anyway, but Andrea was at least single and we did hunt separately. Dating events were stressful enough as it was without sending time talking to women with whom there was no chance *at all* of anything interesting happening. Having non-participants present just lead to upset, frustration and bad feeling all round. Especially as the non-participants were usually the ones I fancied. Such as Jane.

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‘What. . .’ said Heidi. I turned to examine her. She was a couple of inches shorter than me, so no problem with the height. And by the general standards of the available women here tonight, she was good-looking. But ‘Heidi’? What kind of name was ‘Heidi’? And what kind of parents called their daughter ‘Heidi’? How could I possibly take seriously someone called ‘Heidi’? What self-respecting woman as soon as she got the chance wouldn’t drop the Heidi in favour of her middle name, or, if she didn’t have a middle name or her middle name was something equally unfortunate (quite possible if her parents had already shown such a lamentable lapse in taste in giving her ‘Heidi’ as her first name), wouldn’t decide upon a completely new set of names? There was just no way I could bring myself to go out with someone called ‘Heidi’. Was there?

It suddenly dawned on me that nobody was saying anything. And then it dawned on me that Heidi had asked me a question. I felt my bowels clench. I had absolutely no idea what she had just asked me.

‘Sorry?’ I said.

‘I was just asking, Alex,’ said Heidi, ‘what do you do.’

‘Do?’ Ah, that old chestnut. Yes, it was important. Yes, we all did want to know what someone did do. But it does start to become dull when you’ve been asked and answered the same question a dozen times in the same night. It was like freshers week at university. Everyone was dying to know what A-levels everyone had done and what grades they had got, but after a while I started yearning just to ask or be asked a different question. For a second, I was tempted to make something up: professional gambler, big game hunter, chicken sexer, beekeeper. ‘What do I do? I work in computers.’ That was usually more than enough for most people.

‘And what do you do in computers?’

Well, she was certainly persistent, I had to give her extra marks for that. Or it might just be her being polite. Or it might be her refusing to be stonewalled by my closed answer. Which was fair enough. Or it might be that she was interested in me. Surely not. Why would she be

interested in me? Well, I suppose there wasn't any particular reason why she *shouldn't* be (leaving aside for the time being, of course, my crab-like shuffle across the floor of the bar). I was reasonably intelligent, had a reasonably good job, could be reasonably personable when I wanted to be and wasn't pathologically ugly (at least I didn't think I was and if I was I would have hoped that if I was that Andrea might have dropped a hint by now and anyway, none of the women that I had gone out with had been pathologically ugly, which, given that people tend to go with people of more or less commensurate with their level of attractiveness suggested either that I wasn't *that* ugly or at the very least I could summon up enough superficial charm to occasionally — sadly, all too occasionally — persuade someone to go out with me and even sometimes to go to bed with me). It was just a question of whether I wanted someone called 'Heidi' to be interested in me. Oh, why couldn't she have a proper name like Andrea or Jane or Margaret? And she was probably at least a couple of years older than me. I was never very good at estimating ages and the lighting level in here hardly helped, but did I really want to go out with another older woman? And she had short hair and did I really want to go out with another woman who had short hair? I mean I had been out with lots of older women with short hair (well, OK, "lots" as in more than one). I'd quite like to go out with a younger woman with long hair for a change. But on an attractiveness scale of 0–10, Heidi was probably about a 6, maybe a 6.25 on a good day or in different lighting conditions. That wasn't really too bad, I suppose. Now, I typically made it a rule never to date anyone lower than a 7, a 6.75 at a pinch. But could I really afford to be so fussy anymore? Looks were important, sure, but it doesn't matter how good-looking a woman is if she hasn't got the personality. Did Heidi have the personality? Too early to say, so best not to rule her out yet on what were essentially technicalities like her name and age. I could go for a Classy Older Woman. I could do. I had done in the past, so there were precedents.

Now, I had a choice. I could either give her the cocktail party answer as to what I did in computers or I could give her the real answer. I

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took a long sip of my drink, an Agra described as ‘A refreshing blend of Bombay Sapphire Gin, lemon and lime juices, fresh Pomegranate and fresh mint charged with ginger beer. Well, this was a cocktail party of sorts. I was after all drinking one and most refreshing it was. But did I want to give the cocktail party answer? Sink or swim. If she didn’t like the real answer, she wasn’t going to like the real me anyway.

‘It’s actually very interesting,’ I said. Well, it was. Or least I thought that it was. I smiled at Heidi and made subtle, and, I hoped, suggestive eye contact. This was a dating event and thus probably OK to try and practice eye contact flirting. ‘I’m a software engineer.’ Strictly, speaking, I didn’t cut as much code as I would have liked to these days, but there was no need to confuse matters further with the fact that I was really more of a project manager. Keep looking at her. That’s it. Nothing at all wrong with making an effort. This is what most of us are here for. And she is getting the real you after all. ‘I write software for a large agent-based simulation of the behaviour of consumers that’s used to predict the rates of diffusion of innovations in different market segments. We’ve developed a framework and set of interfaces for modelling the interaction between the agents that allows us to estimate how quickly new products or ideas get taken up.’

‘Do you use any elements of Monte Carlo stimulations in your work?’

It took me a while to realise exactly what was wrong. Heidi had uttered that question without moving her lips. And in further testimony to her ventriloquy skills, she had managed to say it in a completely different accent and to project her voice over my right shoulder all the time while maintaining her face in a rictus of complete boredom. Absolutely amazing! This woman should be on the stage. Or. . .

I turned to my right. And started. Jesus fucking Christ! Where had *she* come from?

‘Yes, yes,’ I said, ‘yes, it does. It is a Monte Carlo stimulation.’

‘Which random number generator do you use?’

‘Blum Blum Shub.’

‘Blum Blum Shub? That would be too slow unless you. . .’

‘Yes, yes, we have a lookup table. Then we know that each run is completely reproducible. Took us ages to generate the table.’

‘I imagine it did, but you now don’t have to worry non-stochastic effects in your simulations.’

Amanda, Harriet and Jane had resumed their conversation. It would seem that Monte Carlo stimulations weren’t among their favoured topics of conversation. Which, to be fair, was a not uncommon attitude among the people I met at these kinds of events. It was apparent that I was now in conversation with this interloper. For whom Monte Carlo simulations *were* a favoured topic of conversation. This. . . rather attractive, no, I took as good as look at her as I dared in the circumstances, frankly *very* attractive interloper.

‘Hi,’ I said, ‘I’m Alex.’ God, how I hated having to tell people my name over and over again. But it would be even worse to have to wear name badges. And for once, I didn’t actually mind saying it. At least, I’d find what this. . . this *vision* as I now saw her revealed to be as I turned to face her and had thus been able to obtain a proper look, was called.

‘Hi, I’m Zoë.’ Zoë! Zoë. Thank God for that. She had a proper name, not something ridiculous like frigging Heidi. Zoë. Zoë! A name I could do business with. And a body that I could do business with. And, if her interest in Monte Carlo simulations was anything to go by, a mind I could do business with as well.

‘So, then, Zoë,’ I rolled the “Zoë” around my mouth and it tasted good, ‘you’re interested in Monte Carlo simulations?’

‘I am. I use them in my research. I’m a cosmologist. I develop models of the early universe.’

‘A bit different from the kind of thing I do.’ I could say that again. A cosmologist. Jesus Christ! That was good, *very* good. In certain ways. We definitely weren’t going to run of things to say. But in other ways. . . a cosmologist! I was interested in cosmology. I’d read my Steven Weinberg and my Brian Greene as much as my Stephen Hawking. But she was a real, live cosmologist. How could I compete with that? She

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probably deprecated the kinds of popularisations of cosmological research that I had read. What on this Earth or any other planet could I say to a professional cosmologist that wouldn't make me sound like a complete idiot? 'So how do you use the Monte Carlo method in your models of the early universe?' Well, at least it was an open-ended question. A bit pompous perhaps, but at least I didn't *think* it made me sound like a complete idiot. And anyway, I was a bit pompous, so she was getting to see the real me. And wasn't that what I had decided dating was all about? Letting the real me shine through? No, no, it wasn't. With someone like Heidi, perhaps. But with this Zoë? In her case, it was best to keep the real on as short a leash as possible. I just hoped I hadn't already said too much. Letting the real me out explained why I never got to date women who looked like Zoë. Or who were cosmologists who used Monte Carlo stimulations in their models of the early universe.

'The model we have involves ensembles of universes. In a technical sense, they are not separate universes because they do interact with one another. We call them miniverses.'

'Miniverses?' I'd actually heard of them. 'I seem to recall reading an article in *Scientific American* a few months ago.'

'That's right. I did my post-doc at Stanford with the chap who wrote that article. I get a mention in the article, although it is only a brief one.' Jesus! I was talking to a woman who got mentioned in *Scientific American* articles, *Scientific American* articles I had actually read. What were the chances of that? And the best I had ever managed was a couple of references to our simulations in trade magazines. Not quite the same thing. And the articles didn't even mention me. 'We select miniverses with different properties at random from the ensemble and then sum the effect of the all the miniverses on the evolution of the early universe.'

'I see.' Well, I sort of saw. To be honest, what I just realised I was mainly seeing were her breasts. I'd never really thought of myself as a

breast man, at least not compared to a lot of men I knew, until Andrea pointed out that almost all the women I went out with or were attracted to had large breasts (Andrea herself didn't, which was one of the reasons, I suppose, why I didn't fancy her). I then realised that I did in fact spend a great deal of time staring at women's breasts. And Zoë did have. . . well, quite large breasts that were definitely worth staring at. OK, OK, Alex, look at her face. And try not to think *too* much about what kind of underwear she's wearing. 'And does it give the right answer?'

'We get some of the right answers. We're working on getting on getting some more of them.'

I racked my brain to try and dredge up something from the article. Come on though, how many new people must she randomly bump into on any given day that have actually read the article that mentions her? That alone must be worth *something*. Probably not. The world didn't really seem to work like that.

'If I remember correctly', I said 'the miniverse idea is some kind of alternative to string theory.'

Zoë smiled at me. Good Lord! Had I managed to say something intelligent by accident?

'Yes, that's right. In some ways string theory is very elegant and very powerful in some ways. It doesn't predict anything empirical that can be measured about the universe though.'

'So it can never be falsified,' I said, 'and therefore in a sense, it's not really science.'

Zoë smiled at me again. 'String theory might be true. We might never be able to prove that it's true. There's no reason to assume that the universe will provide us with easy answers to our questions or even any answers at all. There's no need yet to turn cosmology into theology. I prefer to keep it as a branch of physics.'

What could I say to that? I drained my cocktail. What indeed.

'Would you like a drink?' said Zoë.

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‘Er. . .’ Well, yes, of course. But I was the bloke and I was supposed to be the provider. I might not be a cosmologist, but I could at least buy her a drink. ‘No, no, let me get you one.’ Please say yes.

‘If you’re sure. I’ll have a glass of gamay noir, please. I’ll get the next round.’

The next round? ‘I won’t be a minute,’ I said.

Of course, it took frigging ages at the bar and by the time I had obtained two glasses of somewhat overpriced gamay noir, Zoë was talking to someone else! You bastard, you absolute bastard! That’s *my* woman you are talking to. That’s *my* woman who is laughing at your joke.

‘Thanks, Alex’ said Zoë as I handed her the drink. ‘This is Alistair. Alistair, this is Alex.’

‘Hi,’ said Alistair.

‘Hi,’ I said. Try and make it less obvious that you are beaming hatred at him. Alistair was taller than me, younger than me, and frankly, better looking than me. How could I compete with that? Bet he’d never read the *Scientific American* article on miniverses. Actually, knowing my luck, he’d probably turn out to be a frigging cosmologist.

‘So, Alistair,’ I found myself saying, ‘What to do you?’

‘I’m a rocket scientist in the City.’ Shit, that meant that he probably did have a fucking PhD in physics. ‘My job doesn’t have anything to do with rockets.’ He laughed. ‘I’m a quant, I do statistical analysis of the movement of the prices of shares, currencies, commodities, those kind of things.’ I know what rocket scientist and quants are, you patronising imbecile.

I looked at Zoë. Her expression seemed inscrutable. Was this the kind of man that she had come here to meet? But why wouldn’t it be? I turned and smiled at Alistair. ‘That must be very interesting.’

‘You’re right, it is very interesting. I can’t believe they pay me to do it. Well, actually, I can.’ He laughed again. ‘Only this morning, I’d run some jobs and then suggested that there was a double top that was about to breakdown on the Indian roupee versus the Pakistani roupee.

So I rang my client and he went short half a million sterling on Indian-Pakistani roupee futures, but the price went up this afternoon, so he got wiped out, but I'd hedged, of course, so I made a little something on the commission on the short *and* a profit from the hedge, so a pretty good day all round.'

Not for the client it wasn't. '“A double top that was about to break-down”? Are you a chartist?'

'I said I'm a quant.'

'But do you use charting methods?' I could detect something very like irritation under the mask of fixed good humour on Alistair's visage.

'The use of charting methods is well-established in the financial community and are among a number of techniques that our firm uses in order to provide guidance to our clients.' You'd certainly make a good actor, Alistair. You wouldn't have any problems learning your lines. I felt like asking him the name of his firm so that I could tell him that it was one company that I would never want to do business with. Besides there was no reason to assume that Zoë was impressed with my (intended) putdown of Alistair. For all I knew she might spend her spare time studying Japanese candlestick methods. I'd known stranger things. And whichever way, Alistair probably earned a many times my salary and that could compensate for a multitude of sins in the eyes of some women. I looked at Zoë again and her face was still inscrutable. To be honest, if Zoë did prefer Alistair to me then she probably deserved him.

'Tell me, Alistair,' said Zoë, 'do you prefer white wine or red wine?' Good that she had skillfully changed the subject, bad that that she had asked Alistair first.

'Well, to tell you the truth,' said Alistair, 'I'm more of a beer man than a wine man.' He brandished his bottle of Indian lager. 'I don't the odd glass of Chardonnay every now and then.' Given that Zoë was drinking a glass of red, it seemed to me that Alistair might have committed a schoolboy error.

'Which do you prefer, Alex?'

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Here was my chance to gain some major brownie points. ‘Well, I definitely prefer red as a rule, but it does depend on whether I’m eating something with the wine. And, of course, there is champagne.’

‘Ah, champagne,’ said Zoë, ‘there is indeed.’

‘I like champagne too,’ said Alistair. Yes, I’m sure you’ve swilled a few bottles of Salon on bonus day, but I think that round went to me. The three of us stood there in silence. What I wanted to say was ‘Fuck off, laughing boy’ and then ask Zoë if she’d care to repair to somewhere more intimate so that we might have the chance to get to know one another better, but there were two problems with that. Firstly, it was the kind of thing that I only said in my daydreams. And secondly, even in my daydreams, it never worked. Alistair probably did say things like that and it probably worked for him. It would probably work now if he said to me. I mean I wouldn’t just fuck off, but it would end my chances with Zoë. Time passed. We couldn’t stand here all night. I took a sip of wine. I could drain my glass. But then I’d either have to offer to buy Zoë another drink, and she might say ‘No’ or I’d have to make an excuse about going to the toilet, but that would leave the field open for bloody Alistair and given that I had bested him in conversation, there was no way on the planet I was going to give him a chance. I could do stubborn. Of course, stubborn was unlikely to get me the girl.

Out of the corner of my eye, I caught sight of Andrea. Was she bearing down on us? She couldn’t fail to help to break the ice that seemed to have formed around our little group.

‘Ah, this is my friend, Andrea, this is Alistair and Zoë’

‘Hi.’

‘Hi.’

‘Hi.’

So many bloody ‘hi’s. How quickly one became tired of all this awkwardness. Well, I did. Couldn’t we just take the ‘hi’s as read?

‘Andrea,’ I said. ‘Alistair works in the City. You used to work in the City didn’t you?’ Not subtle, but subtlety has never been my strongest

point. And if they were talking, we wouldn't need to talk to them. I saw that Zoë had finished her drink.

'I just need,' she said, 'to nip to the. . . ' Not subtle either. Perhaps subtlety wasn't her strong point either. Andrea and Alistair appeared to be having some kind of stilted conversation. I drifted off to the bar.

The problem now was that I couldn't approach Zoë for the rest of the evening, which meant I had to spend the next hour and a half avoiding her. Given that the bar wasn't that large and she was the only person I had any interest in talking, it wasn't easy, especially as I could see Zoë talking to other men. This was particularly annoying as Zoë had promised to buy me a drink. I didn't care about her not reciprocating the one I bought her — I'd have happily bought her another one — but I felt miffed about having lost out on the promise of more time talking to her. I passed much of the evening in stilted conversation with Amanda, Jane, and of course, Heidi for whom I had lost any interest I might have had.

I was at the bar getting my last drink of the evening when Andrea came over.

'You bastard!' she said

'What?'

'You know perfectly well what, Alex Blackwell. Abandoning me with that git?'

'Alistair? Didn't you have fun swapping City stories?'

'No. I did not. All he wanted to talk about was how much money he has made from fleecing clients and the new car he had just bought with his bonus.'

'Just your kind of guy. I'm sorry, Andrea, I had to get out.'

'You looked like you were getting on well with that red-headed woman.'

'Oh, I was.' I looked around the bar. Zoë was over in the corner. Talking to some guy with a bald head and a pot belly. Well, at least, it wasn't Alistair. Nevertheless, I felt a stab of jealousy in my guts. I hadn't spotted talking to the egregious Alistair, but that didn't mean

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that she hadn't. I couldn't stare at her all evening, much as I might have liked to, at least not without having a court injunction slapped on, which would probably limit my chances of getting a date. 'Until frigging Alistair turned up. Rather put a damper on things.'

'Well, don't do look to me for your out next time.'

'Any talent?' I said

'Talent?' said Andrea. 'Compared to most of the men here, Alistair was one of the good ones. Please don't make me come to these things again.'

'Me make *you*!. It was your idea to come tonight.'

'Yeah, well, you don't have to agree with my brilliant ideas. Anyway, I'm off. Later, dude.'

I looked my glass of gamay noir. I was quite drunk. And I looked at the crowd of people in the bar. And the only person who looked appetising was Zoë. There really was no point prolonging this torture any longer. I downed my glass of wine with three large gulps and made to catch up with Andrea.

I woke up the next morning with a roaring hangover (that last glass of wine had definitely been a mistake), an enormous erection and the image of Zoë's face floating in my mind. The question uppermost in my mind after dragged myself out of my fetid pit (no wank, too headache-y for *that*) was what, if anything, to do about her. I didn't have her phone number or email address, but what I could do was send Zoë a message on the Singles Salon website. I didn't even know her username (good one, Alex, you managed to get just so much information out of her, didn't you?), but that ought not to be a major problem as the occupation of the participants at the event were listed on the website and sure enough there was only women with occupation "university lecturer": "FortyTwo". That's my baby (not yet, but you will be — I hope).

One Interesting Thing About FortyTwo: I am searching for the answer to life, the universe and everything

One Boring Thing About FortyTwo: I have read too many Douglas Adams books

PAUL M. CRAY

Well, yes. Zoë was a cosmologist, so it was hardly a surprise that she was a Douglas Adams fan. I remembered listening the radio series underneath the bedclothes when I was a kid. Of course, now I had to make one or more *Hitch-Hiker* references in my message, which rather upped the ante. I had to try and be witty: witty in a particular way, witty in the same way as our greatest living humorist. But I didn't exactly have any choice other than to give it a stab if I was to have any hope of ever to see her again in the flesh and not just in my imagination.

Zoe,

the venue wasn't quite the
Restaurant at the End of The
Universe last night, which was
probably not a bad thing has the
universe would presumably have
ended by this morning if it had
been. At least, these Singles
Salon events are mostly
harmless. Anyway, it was great
to meet you. Hope you've a fun
weekend planned and that you
don't mislay your towel.

So long and thanks for all the
fish!

Alex

I was probably overdoing it, but I had made the effort. Whether I'd get any credit was entirely another matter. Anyway, it would have to do. I clicked on the SEND button. Would she respond? In my extensive experience of these matters, the answer was 'no' about four times out of five. Of course, four times out of five, it didn't matter, not really. But

Zoë, she was different. It's wasn't everyday that you met someone who got mentioned in *Scientific American* articles on miniverses. Perhaps I shouldn't have gone so overboard on the *Hitch-Hiker* references. She might think that I was some kind of creepy fanboy. As opposed to what I really was: some kind of creepy non-fanboy. (Was I really creepy? I'd always feared I was, just had I had always feared that I was so pathologically ugly that no women would ever agree to have sex with me, much less actually *want* to have sex with me. I'd managed eventually to more or less get over the ugliness issue. But the creepiness issue was more persistent. Friends had assured me that I wasn't creepy. But was that just because they were creepy themselves and so couldn't see my fundamental creepiness? And would someone definitely non-creepy like Zoë detect creepiness in my behaviour last night or in the message I had sent her?)

Time passed. I was hoping that Zoë would wake up on Saturday morning with the image of that rather attractive and witty software engineer that she had met the night before floating in her mind and decide that it would be best if she dropped him a message. Or she would check her emails, see that there was a message waiting for her on the Singles Salon website, get over to the site, see it was from that software engineer and reply immediately. In this kind of thing, no news was not good news. If someone was going to reply, they typically replied within a day or two. By Wednesday, I had pretty much given up hope.

That afternoon, I checked my emails and there it was! A message notification from the Singles Salon. Jesus Christ. It couldn't be true. She'd replied. The problem was, I was at work. Accessing email sites from work, well, everyone did that, but dating sites from weren't really approved. I should wait until I got home tonight. That was fucking five hours off! But I ought to be professional. Oh, fuck it. I clicked on the link and was connected to the site (not blocked, thank God for both reasons). Within a few seconds, I was logged in and looking at my inbox. And, yes, there it was. A message from Forty-Two.

With my heart in my mouth, I clicked on the message

PAUL M. CRAY

Al,

good to meet you the other night. The thing is that I am sort of kind of seeing someone at the moment, so I'm not looking really for dates at right now.

Good luck!

Zoe

I felt like I had been kicked in the nads. Frankly, I was in shock. I went for a shit. I couldn't think of anything else to do.

Fuck, I mean fuck, I thought as I sat on the can and tried to squeeze something out of my bowels. Fuckedty fuck McFuck from Fuckinghamshire: 'sort of kind of seeing someone'. What the fuck did that mean. Today was Wednesday. The event had been on Friday and I had sent my email on Saturday. How could you go from being single to 'sort of kind of seeing someone' in five fucking days? It was impossible. Well, pretty much. Surely, you'd have to have gone on more than one date in order to be 'sort of kind of seeing someone'. Lunch on Sunday, second date on Tuesday, sent the message knocking me back on Wednesday morning still high on endorphins. It was fast, not impossibly fast though. She might have been going out with someone before the event. Again, that was hardly impossible. Often one signed up weeks in advance and it wouldn't be hard to meet someone in the mean time. A woman like Zoë: she wasn't exactly going to struggle to get dates. And having signed up for the event she might feel like she should go having paid already for the damned thing. But she hadn't looked like someone who was going out with someone on Friday. But then what would she have looked like if she had? She had been been projecting an 'I'm not interested' vibe, but perhaps she was just being friendly. Being friendly! Being fucking friendly: what was the point of that? Where the hell did

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that get *me*? But at least — *at least* — if she had been going out with someone before Friday, it wouldn't be Alistair that she was 'sort of kind of seeing' at the moment. And, frankly, the idea that it could be, that there might be even the smallest probability that it was Alistair that she was 'sort of kind of seeing' turned my stomach.

I could see Zoë face in front of me. I could almost smell her red hair. I could almost feel her smooth skin. I could taste her red lips. Almost. Almost. But the thought that it might be that asshole Alistair who was getting to smell, feel and taste Zoë that was too much for me. I didn't just feel depressed, I felt as mad as hell. I just wished I didn't have to take it anymore. But there was nothing, fucking nothing at all, that I could do in order not to have to take it anymore. And to be honest, as I sat there straining away, I even felt rather faint. . .

. . . ah that's better. I felt the tectonic shift in my nether regions as the turd was the finally, slowly, extruded from my arse. There was a plop as it dropped in the bowl. I took as deep as breath as dared given that I had just shat a massive shit. OK, OK, I didn't feel quite as faint as I had done. Phew. But I could still see the image of Zoë. What was the use of that? It wasn't as though I hadn't known all along that there was no chance of anything happening between us. But that wasn't the point. It was the cosmos taunting me. Here is Zoë, the brightest and best, far too good for the likes of *you*. And what response could I give? The world wasn't a fair place. There were a few people at the top of the pyramid, people like Zoë. And, yes, the rest of us, somewhere further down the pile, inevitably looked up at them and thought "if only". It was just human nature to be attracted to the most attractive people. But we might be attracted to them, but they weren't going to be attracted to us. Again, that was just human nature. There was no point whinging about it. You just had to do what people always have done and try and find your own level and make the most of it.

I went back to my desk. I didn't feel like doing any work. In fact, I felt like throwing up, but I made desultory effort to at least look as though it I was doing something. After half an hour, out of routine, I

checked my Gmail account again. There was a notification of another message from the Singles Salon. What the fuck? Heidi? More likely just some foul-up in their system and it was another notification for the message I had already received. I was too depressed to worry about visiting the site from work and clicked on the link. Jesus, it was a message from Forty-Two. The same one surely...

Alex,

please ignore my last message!

I sent it in error. I realised as soon as I sent it that I had sent you the wrong message, so I'm spending this message in the hope that you read it first and don't feel *too* insulted. I confused you with Alistair - or rather I got your usernames confused (I wouldn't confuse you with him in any other way). Do you remember him - the City bloke who was going on about how he had ripped off his client?

I can't express how sorry and upset I feel about this. You also now know my dirty secret that I brush men off by telling them I am "sort of kind of seeing someone". It's only a lie if I haven't got a date in the pipeline and I do terrible about being caught lying by a guy I

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wouldn't want to lie to. (I
don't care about lying to
Alistair.)

I'd feel much better if I did
have a date in the pipeline.
Would you like to meet up some
time for a drink (I owe you one)
and something to eat and we can
continue our discussion of the
relevance of research into
miniverses to the "Hitch-Hikers
Guide to the Galaxy"?

Sorry about this again!

Looking forward to seeing you
soon (if you can still bring
yourself to do that). My real
email address is
z.e.heriot-shaw@imperial.ac.uk.

Zoe

Reading that made my depression dissipate in a heartbeat. It is
amazing the effect that a few characters on a glowing screen can have
on the human heart.

Here I was then, two days later, sitting in the Punjab, my favourite
Indian restaurant on a date with Zoë. Yes, *me* on a date with not only
one of the country's, nay, one of the *world's* leading young cosmolo-
gists, but also a very beautiful woman. Me, *me*, not bloody, fucking
Alistair. Ha, ha! Stick that up your jacksie, you arsehole! Steady, Alex,
steady. Premature gloating won't get me where I want to be. The truth
was that my chances of getting where I wanted to be were still pretty

slim. But pretty slim is not zero. You had to be in the game to win. As one of that instant, I was definitely still in the game.

‘So miniverses aren’t real universes?’ I asked as I tucked into my rogan josh.

‘It depends what you mean by real,’ said Zoë. She looked amazingly fetching with her hair up, ‘

‘Well, I’m not absolutely sure what *I* mean by real, at least in this case,’ one thing that I was absolutely sure was that she had the most amazing brown eyes, ‘but what do *you* mean by real? In this case?’

‘It’s difficult to explain without the maths,’ said Zoë.

‘I’m sorry I’m only did eighteen months of a PhD in computational chemistry!’

‘That’s all right,’ Zoë leant across the table and touched the back of my hand with her hand. She had made the first move. Well, OK, it was just a minor piece of sexual body language, but it was a start. ‘I’ll let you off.’ She could. . . No, no. Well, yes. No. Sorry, sorry. For God’s sake, *try* and concentrate on what she is saying. ‘We are sitting in a miniverse now. The properties of the universe that we observe are an average of all the universes. In a sense, each miniverse is a complete universe in its own right, but the properties of each miniverse affect the properties of all the other miniverses. It’s hard to say if they are real. They’re real in the sense that their presence affects us. They’re not real in the sense that you couldn’t go there, not even in principle, not even if you can some kind of magic technology such as a faster than light drive.’

‘But are there people, other, oh, I don’t know, Alexs and Zoës, sitting in Indian restaurants in these miniverses.’

‘Oh, Alex, Alex, there are always other Alexs and Zoës sitting in Indian restaurants or restaurants of every other kind in cities of every kind in countries of every kind on planets of every kind. We can never get away from all the Alexs and Zoës in all the restaurants in all the miniverses.’ That was something I definitely didn’t want to get away from.

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‘That’s the thing, isn’t it?’ I gestured with my hand to indicate the other dinners in the restaurant. ‘The random forces of happenstance drove *us* to *this* restaurant on *this* day. But it also drove all of *these* people to this resaturant on this day. Those random forces have brought us all us together.’

‘And they’ll drive us all apart again in an hour or two.’ My heart jumped. Was she signalling something to me, gently guiding my expectations? ‘Unless the intelligent agents cooperate.’

I smiled. Had Zoë checked out my company’s website. I would expect nothing less of her. ‘Well, yes, that’s one of the things our stimulations do. The agents randomly interact with other agents, but form networks of relationships based on their preferences that affect the outcomes of the simulations. It’s not all happenstance.’

‘Preferences,’ said Zoë. ‘We all have our preferences.’

Well, I knew what my preferences were. If only I knew what Zoë’s were. Then again at least I had hope at that moment and I did not want that hope taken from me.

‘What are your preferences, Zoë?’

‘In dating terms?’ she said. ‘I’m an academic. I meet a great many academics. I like academics. I meet a great many people who know a great deal about miniverses and I want a person who knows about miniverses. There’s more to it than that though. I’ve dated academics and I’ve dated non-academics. Academics can be too focussed on their area of research. Too many of them are among the duller people in the universe even when they shouldn’t be. Non-academics though often don’t see what I do as interesting or important or relevant. So, my preferences are for. . . a non-focussed academic. . . or a non-academic who can see the interest and importance and relevance.’ She laughed. ‘I don’t want much, do I? What about you, Alex?’

Oh, Jesus! What could I say. I couldn’t tell her the truth. I couldn’t say my preferences were for petite, curvy, red-headed cosmologists.

‘In our stimulations, our agents make connections with other agents. That’s the thing. It’s E.M. Forster: only connect. Well, not *only*

connect, but connection at all the different levels is what I am looking for.’ No wonder I was single. And no wonder Zoë was to. We were both bloody choosy. But then Zoë could afford to be.

Zoë leaned back in her chair and took a sip of her beer. ‘Life would be simpler if we all weren’t all so fussy, if we’d be prepared to just make do if who is blown our way. But it would also be easier if we could search through all the universes and find the One, our Platonic soulmate. If only one of us physicists could invent a machine to do that, it would be the greatest contribution ever to human happiness.’ She smiled at me. And I felt something in that smile, if only for an instant, that I am not sure I had felt in a smile before. ‘Yes, Alex, if only one of us could.’

After dinner, we meandered down to Covent Garden tube station and the Piccadilly Line platforms, Zoë to go east, me to go west. I finally had no choice but to pop the question that I had been burning and dreading to ask since we had left the restaurant. ‘Will you marry me? Why should we bother to wait. It’s obvious that we are soulmates. Let’s elope to Vegas tonight and we can be married by a Captain Picard-lookalike on a mock-up of the bridge of the *New Generation* Starship *Enterprise*. I know a Captain Kirk-lookalike and Classic *Trek Enterprise* bridge would be more ideologically sound, but I can only offer what is available. And it’s not even as though I’m a *Star Trek* fan. Believe me, I never liked it that much, not even as a kid. I always thought it was bland compared to *Doctor Who*. And what’s *Hitch-Hiker*, if it’s not a cross between *Doctor Who* and *Monty Python*, I mean for God’s sake, Douglas Adams was the script editor of *Doctor Who* for a season and he co-wrote the greatest ever story and weren’t his episodes in the new *Doctor Who* series just absolutely bloody marvellous and so much better than any of RTD’s episode and if we could be married by Zaphod Beeblebrox on the bridge of the *Heart of Gold* or by a Tom Baker-lookalike in the control room of the TARDIS, I would, or even Kyrton (if would have to be Kyrton wouldn’t it, not Holly or Cat or Lister) on the bridge of *Red Dwarf* (did it have a bridge?) or even *Star Bug* (which definitely does have a bridge) and frankly I’m surprised that

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Robert Llewellyn and co. haven't done this in one of their gardens, it's not like they are in work that much these days, but as I said we have to work with the material at hand and it would be kind of cool to get married on the Starship *Enterprise* in an ironic and knowing way, so marry me, Doctor Zoë Elizabeth, marry me quick!

That was what I wanted to say. But I didn't for two reasons: (i) it would have taken quite a long time to say and Zoë's train might have come while I was saying it; (ii) it was arguably a *little* early in our relationship for it. Instead, I said:

'Would you like to go out again?'

'Yes,' said Zoë, 'yes, I'd like that very much.'

'What would you like to do?'

Zoë's train had pulled into the station and its doors had opened to take her away from me. 'Oh, I don't really mind,' as she stepped onto the train her lips brushed my cheek and then my lips were brushing her cheek and then our lips — only for a fraction of a second, but oh! blissful moment — our lips were together 'just so long as' the doors were closing,' this Alex and Zoë get a reservation at the restaurant of our miniverse.'

CHAPTER FOUR

PARALLEL 04444 ↑ 4 ↑ 4

6000 WORDS — MARCH 2026

‘When I heard the name,’ said Alex, ‘my first thought was that Dalston Kingsland was the name of a Vicwardian detective. I was very disappointed when I discovered that it was just the name of a district of London.’

I smiled. ‘It does rather sound like the name of a late nineteenth sleuth. Sherlock Holmes, Sexton Blake, Nelson Lee, Ferrers Locke, Dalston Kingsland. I’d like to read his *Memoirs* provided they were written by someone who could write like Sir Arthur Conan Doyle in his prime.’ Alex smiled back at me. I took a sip of my Gamay Noir and gave him a good going over. Not my physical type. He was cute enough, but he was too short. I went for Tall, Dark and Handsome. Since enough TD&H men had been prepared to go out with me in the past, I saw no reason to stop looking for one now. Alistair, on the other hand, was more my type, looks-wise. TD&H *ish*. Did something in the City that sounded as though it would be well-paid, which meant that he would at least be able to maintain an underpaid physics lecturer in the style to which she

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had become accustomed. It was clear though that he was more interested in Nicola, not that there was any chance in the circumstances of him getting anywhere with her.

‘But it did occur to me that Arnos Grove could be his Dr Watson,’ said Alex.

‘Arnos Grove?’ I said ‘It’s odd you should say Arnos Grove. I live there.’

‘Really?’ said Alex.

‘My flat’s just round the corner from the station,’ I said ‘Handy for the Piccadilly Line to South Kensington.’

‘I have to admit I’ve never been there,’ said Alex, ‘or ever met anyone who lives there. . . until you I mean. I live in Brentford and often find myself at Hammersmith. And one time I was looking at the poster of the destinations on the eastbound Piccadilly Line and I spotted the name and I knew at once what the name of Dalston Kingsland’s sidekick was: Arnos Grove.’

‘Arnos Grove?’ said Alistair ‘Who’s he?’

It was clear that conversation wasn’t Alistair’s strong point or at least witty banter wasn’t. I needed a man who could do witty banter as well as being TD&H. It hadn’t proven too much to ask for in the past. For all his faults, Miles had had witty banter. It was just that his conversation didn’t go much beyond witty banter.

‘Well,’ said Alex, ‘what brings us all to such an obscure part of East London on a cold, rainy night like this?’

The same things, I thought, that brought you here: being single and having a constant feeling of low level sexual agitation.

‘I live just down the road near Angel,’ said Alistair. ‘Bloody handy for the City. A friend of mine went to one of these before. Um. . . I. . . it sounded fun,’ .

‘We thought,’ Nicola indicated me with a slight movement of her glass, ‘that it would be interesting to learn a little bit more about wine.’

Did I detect a faint flicker of (understandable in the circumstances) sceptical eyebrow movement from Alex? After all, this wasn’t just any

ordinary wine-tasting event. It was one of Michael Schuster's famous wine-tasting for singles events as featured in the style section of the *Sunday Times*. It had been Nicola's idea to come. She did buy the *Sunday Times*, but, she claimed, only for the style section, although she was a journalist and could argue she had to read it for professional. The suggestion had surprised me, dating events were more my thing than Nicola's, but it made perfect sense given what I now realised. 'It would,' she had said, 'do me good to get out and meet some men.' That had been a sentence that deserved analysis. First, there was implication that I didn't get out that much. I didn't go out as much as I would like, but that was because Nicola was always busy at work these days. I could go out on my own and I *did* go out on my own, it just wasn't as much fun as going out with Nicola. Second point: 'Meet some men'. I met men all the time. Most of them weren't TD&H, and good conversationalists and those that were, weren't often single. I did still go on *dates* with men. Not always TD&H men who were good conversationalists, but actual men. All the time. Four in the last fortnight. This was the twenty-first century. There was no excuse for an attractive enough female (and I hope I am attractive enough given the amount of time, effort and money I put into making myself so) to want for male company in this age of internet dating and singles events. I was the first person to admit that it was a question of the quality of the male company rather than the quantity. I had been surprised to discover in this supposed age of the metrosexual how many men on the internet dating scene had yet to discover the benefits of a decent haircut or even of basic male grooming products. At least four as I had learnt from bitter personal experience over the last couple of weeks. On strict grounds of probability, I knew that men with decent haircuts, who were users of male grooming products, TD&H and good conversationalist must exist, but I wasn't meeting them at the moment.

The truth was that just having a decent haircut, using male grooming products, being TD&H and a good conversationalist weren't enough. I didn't want to meet *a* man. I was getting on. I could feel

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my fecundity declining by the minute. Even if children weren't my number one priority right now, keeping the option open was something I wanted to do. It would also be pleasant to get to wake up next to someone every now and then. What worried more than anything though was the fear that I had met *the* man already.

'Miles!' Nicola had said in the pub where we had been obtaining some Dutch courage before the wine tasting, 'Miles! The problem was that he wasn't *the* One. He wasn't even close to being *the* One. You've got to get over him, Zo.' That was easy for her to say. 'It's been nearly six months now. Besides, Miles was a complete bastard.'

Which was true, although a TD&H bastard with an expensive haircut and good grooming habits, even if his conversation sometimes faltered if the subject shifted to one that risked exposing his inner self. I stared into my glass of Gamay Noir. If Miles was that much of a complete bastard he'd have made a pass (or rather several passes) at Nicola (Miles wasn't the kind of man to leave things to happenstance). She had never said that he had made a pass at her and there wasn't be any reason for her not to tell me, not now, the opposite in fact. 'Zo, Miles *was* a complete bastard. When you were going out with him, he constantly made passes at me. It was all I could do to fend him off each time,' she might have said. Nicola *was* an attractive woman. She was tall, willowy brunette with a great mane of curly hair, whereas I was a pear-shaped ginger midget, something no number of visits to the gym was ever going to do anything about. Also she was a lifestyle journalist, which was if not quite the number one sexy job (architect, I was told, but perhaps that was only for men), was up there nothing more than being a theoretical cosmologist. To be fair, I thought being a theoretical cosmologist was pretty sexy, but it didn't seem that a lot of the men I met did. Miles would have unable to resist trying to seduce her. For God's sake, she fancied the arse off him anyway. She had told me that (not that she had needed to tell me) on the night we first met Miles. If Miles hadn't tried to shag Nicola, she would be the only woman in our social circle he hadn't tried to shag. In fact, she would be the only woman in our social

circle he hadn't shagged, excluding, of course, Eugenia, but including me. He'd have tried it on with her. She was, by any objective criteria, by far the best-looking of our group — she had been a literal model when she was a student — and Miles would have relished the challenge. You never could quite tell with Eugenia. I knew she had had sex with men, but Miles was a bit too obvious for her. She was a lawyer in a bank and brushed off men like Miles a dozen times a day by her account. Nicola was another matter. She had no *ideological* objections to sleeping with Miles.

'You're having an affair with Miles!' I had almost blurted out. It would explain a great deal: why Nicola hadn't had a boyfriend since before I dumped Miles, why she was always so *busy* at work these days. If I asked Nicola whether or not she was having an affair with Miles, she might come straight out and admit it. She might have decided that tonight was the night that she needed to get her dark secret out in the open at long last. It was much more probable than she would deny it. She might deny because it wasn't true. How could she prove it wasn't true though? She would still look shocked and anxious at my accusation. Whereas if it were true and she denied it, she would also look shocked and anxious, but I'd be able to cut straight through her web of lies and denials. There wasn't any point then asking Nicola if she was having an affair because whatever answer she gave would confirm that she was — or rather no answer that she gave could confirm that she *wasn't*, which amounted to the same thing. In that moment everything became clear to me: my best friend was shagging my ex-boyfriend.

Did I mind Nicola shagging Miles? Yes. First, she had been my best friend for fourteen years since we had met on our staircase at King's on that October afternoon in 1992. We'd gone through all of our emotional up and downs together since then. I didn't want Miles to hurt Nicola in the way that he had hurt me. That was what was bound to happen. Miles couldn't help it. It was what he did. Second, she was having an affair with him *behind my back*. The knowledge of my certain disapproval of the affair would be reason enough to conceal it from me,

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but there might be another reason. Had the affair begun while I was still seeing Miles?

Nicola had violated the established protocol involved in shagging your best friend's ex-boyfriend. The first part of the protocol was that you didn't start shagging him before your friend stopped shagging him. The second part was that you asked permission. Nicola had violated both parts of the protocol and, worse than that, she had lied to me. You don't tell your best friend that her ex-boyfriend was a complete bastard and that she was better off without him *when you are shagging the ex-boyfriend yourself!*

Nicola had betrayed me. I knew that Miles had betrayed me with many women, I knew that now. In most circumstances, it was understandable for a women to go to bed with Miles. He was the consummate seducer. It wasn't understandable for a women to go to bed with her best friend's boyfriend. Under any circumstances. I had gone to bed with him, but he hadn't been dating Nicola at the time. That's one of the things that best friends are for: not shagging each other's boyfriends. I'd never shagged any of Nicola's boyfriends (except for Pierre, who didn't count because he wasn't going out with Nicola any longer when I shagged him and because he was *Pierre*).

There was a third reason though why I minded and it was the most important one. I minded because Miles was the best lay I've ever had. If he had had a small, soft dick and been crap in bed, I would have known straightaway that it was impossible that he was the One. In fact not only was he a very well-endowed boy, he *knew* what he was doing with it. He was a bastard because he could be. What incentive did he have not to be? Miles was never going to want for female company and I had never detected any substantive evidence that he was looking for anything more than as much sex as he could get with as many attractive women as possible. I had told Nicola that Miles was the best lay that I had ever had. Nicola had told me about that about her several of her boyfriends, but then she was better at falling in love than I was — I'd never got the hang of doing that at all. Her judgment on matters of technical merit and

artistic impression in the sack was always clouded by strong, irrational positive emotions during the relationship and equally strong, irrational negative ones afterwards. Whereas my judgment, I felt, as a scientist and a rationalist, was more objective. I could say that, bastard though he was, Miles scored 9/10 for technical merit and 7/10 for artistic impression. I couldn't give him a perfect ten for technical merit because, good though Miles was, I just hadn't had sex with enough men to be sure that there weren't some who were better and he had on one or two occasions made what I deemed to be unforced errors (coming before I did, not quite getting his tongue in the correct position with respect to my clitoris when he was licking me, a failing I ascribed to a combination of lack of experience and lack of enthusiasm). In the case of artistic impression, Miles was just never going to be connected on an emotional level as a lover, although he was intelligent enough to be able to construct a passable imitation of it when he so desired, but he was an imaginative and energetic lover. Overall, 16/20 wasn't a bad effort, which was the problem. Nicola and I had spent many evenings discussing the great sex I was having with Miles and I knew she had wondered what she was missing (which was plenty). When Miles had made his move (as he must have done), it would have been impossible for her to resist.

I downed my glass of wine in two gulps.

'Bloody hell, Zo!' said Nicola.

'Let's go,' I said. I couldn't look her in the eye any more and I couldn't think of anything else to say. The sooner we got to the wine tasting, the sooner the evening would be over and I could think about what I wanted to do about the issue of my best friend and my ex-boyfriend having an affair.

An hour later at the wine tasting Alex was saying 'My ambition is to drink nothing but Mouton-Rothschild. Actually, no, it's not.

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Firstly because there is lots of wine worth drinking that isn't Mouton-Rothschild and secondly because my real ambition is just to drink some Mouton-Rothschild.'

'Mouton-Rothschild?' I said. 'I understand Michael saves that for his fine wines course. It would be good to be able to lay down a case of that in one's cellar though.'

'A cellar?' said Alex. 'A cellar? Who actually has a cellar? I live in a flat. Of course, I don't have a cellar. Where am I supposed to put a cellar? In the underground car park?'

Miles had a cellar. He lived in a house in Leytonstone, which he had chosen because it had a cellar. Not *such* a great area, but even Miles had to compromise sometimes: he wasn't a QC yet. You can never start laying down your cellar too early he had been told by his father who had given him fifty bottles to form the core of his collection. The problem with Miles was that he didn't like drinking it or rather he did, but only when he thought it would impress people who might be useful to him in advancing his career.

'I thought Michael Schuster's lecture,' said Alex, 'was very interesting. But he did tend to go on a bit. It's obvious that he's more interested in talking about wine than drinking it. I'd rather drink it. There are so many other interesting things to talk about.'

'I'll drink to that,' I said. We clinked our glasses together.

'Well,' said Alex. 'What would you like to talk about?'

I sucked my cheeks in. Something to get my mind off Miles and Nicola. She had drifted off with Alistair to get a refill, so at least I didn't have to avoid looking at her for the time being. 'Oh, I don't know. Time travel?' I had been reading a new paper on the subject by one of my old colleagues from my Stanford days in bed the previous evening. If only I had a time machine so I could go back in time and stop this whole Nicola and Miles affair before it had started.

'An excellent suggestion,' said Alex. 'You're the mathematical physicist,' he'd picked up on me saying what I did during the introductions then. 'Do you think it's possible?'

‘There are solutions to the equations of general relativity that appear to allow closed timelike loops to exist,’ I said.

‘Which is to say time machines?’

‘In effect, yes.’ I took a sip of my wine. This wasn’t the kind of conversation I had ever had with Miles and I doubted it was the kind of conversation I would have with Alistair. ‘The problem is that the solutions always seem so unphysical.’

‘Ah, unphysical solutions,’ said Alex. ‘Such as infinitely long lumps of exotic matter rotating at a large fractions of the speed of light?’

‘That’s the sort of thing.’ He knew his stuff. What had he said he did? ‘You can solve the equations in the case were the cylinder is only a few thousand kilometres long, but you still get naked singularities.’

‘Well, I couldn’t solve the equations in either case. The naked singularities indicate that the solutions are unphysical?’ I fingered by amber necklace and the image of me pumping away on top of a naked Alex floated before by mind’s eye. Pull yourself together, woman. You might not have had sex for almost seven months, but that’s no excuse for fantasising about having sex with random stranger just he’s heard of naked singularities and you’ve just realised that the reason why your best friend has been looking so radiant in recent months is because she is having the best sex of her life with your ex-boyfriend. Sex just isn’t that important and the contents of your goody drawer have never let you down in any of the ways that men have. What am I doing here tonight then if sex isn’t that important? Sex. . . does have its place in the context of a loving relationship. A loving relationship? Consider my relationship with Miles. I wasn’t in love with him and he wasn’t in love with me. What kept us together for ten of those thirteen months was sex. I just can’t bring myself to admit that to myself. Nice girls don’t want to have sex. Nice girls don’t want to have *dirty* sex. Well, I mustn’t be as nice a girl as I thought I was.

As for Alex, it was obvious he was no Miles from the physical perspective but he was a cute enough guy with an interested in relativistic physics and I didn’t meet that many men interested in relativistic physics

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with whom I could even imagine sleeping. He might not be Lucasian Professor of Mathematics at Cambridge, but Stephen Hawking was, so that was a positive advantage. (There was, of course, Michael, who was Plumian Professor of Astronomy and Natural Philosophy at Cambridge, but he was 50 and although he was as good-looking as Miles, had something of his Lothario reputation and, besides, even though it no longer violated the Half Plus Seven Rule, I just couldn't bring myself to date some one in his *fifties*. I doubted he would match Miles in terms of technical merit under the duvet, but then artistic impression carried the same weight.

'Most people. . . most *relativists* think the fact that you get naked singularities indicates that the solutions are unphysical,' I said.

'Most relativists meaning that you don't think that,' said Alex.

'My guess is that if we had a quantum theory of gravity the singularities would go away.'

'But would the closed timelike loops?'

'That would be the cleanest solution,' I said.

'I'm picking up that there's a "but",' said Alex.

'There's no reason why the universe should be a clean place. I don't think it's such a big deal that time machines might exist.'

'Oh, I don't know,' said Alex. 'What about causality and all that? Going back in time and shooting your grandmother?'

'You can't,' I said.

'But if you had a time machine?'

'You still couldn't.'

'Because you can't go back beyond the time the machine was created?' said Alex.

'No, you could always get hold of one aliens made earlier,' I said. 'You couldn't because we live in a block universe.'

'So you can go back in time and shoot your grandmother, but only after she has given birth to your mother?'

'Yes, you can't use a time machine to change history, but you can use one to make it.' Only a few minutes earlier, I had been wishing that

I had a time machine so that I could go back and stop the whole Nicola and Miles's affair. I ought to at least try and make by desires consistent with my metaphysical standpoints. 'If you knew that two people met or didn't meet, you could go back in time and ensure that they did or didn't meet. In fact, if you were the cause of them meeting or not meeting, you would have no choice but to go back in time to ensure that they did or did not meet.'

'If you had a time machine,' said Alex.

'My ex-colleague's paper suggests,' I said, 'that such a thing might not be beyond the technological capabilities of a supercivilisation.'

'We don't live in such a civilisation sadly.'

'We don't appear to be living in one at the moment.'

'But we could,' said Alex, 'be heading towards a technological singularity in the next few decades.'

'Time travel,' I said 'might well be within the technological capabilities of a post-Singularity supercivilisation.'

'For all we know this room could be full of time travellers manipulating events to ensure that the solutions to the quantum gravitational equations for the universe converge properly.'

I looked around the room. Nicola was still talking to Alastair. 'It would explain a great deal,' I said.

'But if that were the case,' said Alex, 'where does it leave free will?'

'The same place it is always left,' I said. 'In the dustbin of discarded ideas.'

'So whether I ask you whether or not you might possibly be interested in maybe meeting up for a drink some time and whether you say yes, no or maybe is predetermined?'

'Not necessarily predetermined from a strong Laplace-type demon perspective in that one couldn't calculate the question and response beforehand, but true in the weak sense that that there will be a question and there will be an answer.'

'The thing about free will though,' said Alex, 'is that it feels free.'

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‘It’s a very pervasive illusion,’ I said. I drained my glass. ‘Well, was there something you wanted to ask me?’

‘Er. . .’

I looked at Alex, he might not be TD&H, but he was a reasonable conversationalist and he had a reasonable haircut. He couldn’t be any worse than the four dates I had been on the in the last fortnight. ‘The answer is “Yes” if that is any help to you.’

My glass was empty, I’d managed to secure a date, which was the fundamental point of the evening, and I didn’t think I could look Nicola in the eye tonight, so having any further conversation with her just now was out of the question. I made my brief excuses to Nicola and Alistair (she and I were both adults; we were quite capable of getting to Arnos Grove without each other’s company and if she wanted to use him as a pathetic attempt at a decoy that was up to her) and slipped out into a dark, cold March night in Dalston Kingsland (I got a minicab to Angel).

On the Piccadilly Line back to Arnos Grove, I soon abandoned any attempt to read the my old Stanford colleague’s preprint in order to consider the question of Nicola and Miles. How could I find out for sure if she was having an affair with him? She lived just round the corner from me so I could pop round to her flat at an unexpected time. There were several problem with that approach. I could only pop round at an unexpected time once before Nicola would become suspicious that I was up to something and there would be no guarantee that Miles would be there. I could go round to Miles’s house, but that had a whole additional set of associated issues that I didn’t want to explore. I had no interest in who Miles was shagging — unless he were shagging my best friend. Doubtless Miles had shagged several women, including Nicola, since I had dumped him. He’d been shagging several, including, I now knew, Nicola, before I had dumped him. I was the dumper and he was the dumpee and it might be poetic justice for the dumper to be denied what she wants, while the dumpee falls into the arms of the love of his life, but even if I were the dumper I was also the wronged party. Where

was the love of *my* life (Miles saw his every morning in the shaving mirror) and why hadn't I been able to get a shag for more than six months?

I couldn't start behaving like some kind of psychostalker, which ruled out staking out either Nicola's flat or Miles's house. I would have to take a more subtle approach. The train was drawing into Arnos Grove station. I stood up. I couldn't face seeing Nicola for at least a few days. I would have to hope that some cunning plan would suggest itself to me in the near future before Nicola realised that I was avoiding her on purpose.

* * *

A week later after three dates with Alex (Thursday dinner at the Punjab on Neal Street, kiss on the lips; Sunday lunch at the Ealing Park Tavern (very handy for the Piccadilly Line at South Ealing), light snog; a quick dinner at Sunny Burger in Garrick Street, followed by drinks, heavy snog, but it was Tuesday, a school night and I wasn't in the right headspace to take things further right then, no matter how well things seemed to going with Alex, not with the Nicola/Miles situation unresolved), an idea occurred to me. I had a work from home day (the advantages of being an academic) arranged to meet Nicola for a quick mid-afternoon coffee near her office.

'So,' said Nicola, 'three dates with Alex. Things are going pretty well then?' I had used the dates as an explanation for my lack of availability over the last days. Nicola took a sip of her low fat decaff latte. It was still hard for me to look her in the eye, but I wanted to see if I could tell anything about Miles and her from her eyes.

'Pretty well,' I said. 'In fact, I'd say we were going out.'

'That's great! I mean that's quick too. After ten days? And you haven't... yet? Well, yes, it is great. When do I get to meet him again?' I had been hoping that Nicola would walk into that trap.

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‘What about Saturday night?’ If she were seeing Miles, she’d be seeing him on either or Friday and Saturday night or both.

‘Saturday’s good for me,’ said Nicola.

‘Great,’ I said. ‘Would you like bring someone?’

‘Bring someone? How do you mean?’

‘A date. Make it a foursome?’

‘Don’t you think that would be a little odd?’ Yes, it would it would. A foursome between my current boyfriend, my ex-boyfriend, my best friend and me. ‘Personally I wouldn’t like want to go on a first date in a as part of a foursome and I don’t suppose many blokes would either.’

I took a sip of my large americano with an extra shot of espresso. I had needed something a bit stronger than a decaff latte today. ‘On a first date, yes, but if you were seeing anyone, you could bring him along.’

‘Seeing anyone?’ said Nicola. ‘I don’t understand, Zo. I’m not seeing anyone.’

‘You might be,’ I said. ‘You just might not have told not me you were.’

‘Why on Earth would I do that?’

‘Oh, I don’t know,’ Yes, I did. ‘All sorts of reasons.’

‘Such as?’ said Nicola.

‘You’re having an affair with Miles,’ I said.

‘Are you clinically insane, Zo?’ As I had feared, she was going to go down the denial route.

‘Are you trying to deny that Miles made a pass at you?’

‘Of course, I’m not,’ said Nicola. ‘Miles makes a pass at every women he meets.’

‘Ah! you admit it, then’ I said, ‘and yet you’ve never said anything to me about it.’

‘I’m sorry, Zo. I probably should have said something about it to you at the time. But you were very keen on Miles. The pass wasn’t a big deal. Making a fuss about it would just have complicated things for everyone. And afterwards, when you had split up, it didn’t really matter anymore.’

“Didn’t really matter anymore”? How could it not really matter anymore? You could have said to me “Zo, I knew he was a bastard all along and he even made a pass, but I didn’t say anything to you at the time because I didn’t want to hurt your feelings.” That would have fair enough, but to say nothing at all to me about can only mean one thing. That when he made the pass at you, you didn’t turn him down and that you are still shagging him now.’ I had to try hard to keep the level of my voice under control.

‘Don’t be an idiot, Zo,’ said Nicola. ‘Nothing was ever going to happen between Miles and me. I’m immune to his charms.’

‘Immune to his charms?’ I said. ‘How can any heterosexual women be immune to Miles’s charms?’

‘The thing is, Zo, and don’t take this the wrong way, I’ve never fancied Miles that much.’

‘Never fancied him? You were pretty disappointed that night when we first met him in the bar that he was more interested in me not you.’

‘That was before I knew what a bastard he is,’ said Nicola. ‘OK, he’s good looking, charming, intelligent, rich and, according to you, good in bed, but there’s more to love than a good job and great sex.’

‘You haven’t slept with him then?’ I said ‘You’re not having an affair with Miles?’

‘Zo, I’ve already told I didn’t sleep with him. I can’t believe that you could possibly think that I would be having an affair with Miles. There was no way I would do that to you or to myself. It was obvious to me that he was a complete and utter bastard right from the second time I met him.’

‘Obvious? Why didn’t you tell me then?’

‘How could I tell you?’ said Nicola. ‘You were totally infatuated with him, Zo. There was no way you’d have listened to what I was saying.’

‘I always listen to what you’re saying!’ I said.

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‘Zo, you only ever listen to the advice you want to hear. It’s about time you stopped listening to your head all the time. Life isn’t a mathematical equation to be solved and it isn’t just about money and status. It’s about time you started listening to your heart for a change. Then you wouldn’t hurt the people who love you all the time and you might have a chance of finding love with some halfway decent man.’

I felt my eyes stinging with tears. I couldn’t burst into tears, not here in the coffee shop, not now in front of Nicola.

‘Can you ever forgive me?’

‘I don’t know,’ said Nicola. She stood up. ‘Look, Zo. I’m going to go. I need time to get my head straight. You’re my best friend. We’ve been through so much together since we were nineteen. I thought I knew you better than anyone and I thought you knew me better than anyone. But that can’t be true, can it?’

I couldn’t think of anything to say. Had I lost one boyfriend (complete bastard), gained another (halfway decent maybe), but lost my best friend? Was I in truth as bad a person as I felt I was? I watched Nicola zigzagging her way through the obstacle course of chairs and tables to the door and felt the tears freeze in my eyes.

That evening I was in bed, re-reading the time travel paper when my mobile vibrated. A text. My heart skipped. Please be from Alex! If only texts were like emails and you could see who they were from straight away. I opened the message and my eye caught the name of the sender. It was from Nicola. My heart skipped again.

Zoe, I can’t forget what you
said and I can’t forgive it. I’m
not enough of a schmuck to stand
you up by text. Not after all
this time. In fact, I’m going to

PAUL M. CRAY

do the opposite. I'm going to
sit you down. Our friendship
means too much to me. We can go
on. We must must go on. See you
(and Alex!) Saturday. Love,
Nicola xx

Then I did cry.

CHAPTER FIVE

PARALLEL 05555 ↑ 5 ↑ 55

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‘What on Earth,’ I said, ‘is a woman like her doing with a jerk like him? Surely she must be able to see what an arsehole he is? She could be going out with someone half-way decent. Me, for instance.’

‘A lot of arseholes are bastards and a lot of women are attracted to bastards,’ said Andrea. As so often at parties, we had found that we had mutually gravitated together in a corner.

‘But why?’ I took a large swig of my wine. Did I really want her to tell me? I was many things, but I knew I wasn’t a bastard, at least not that kind of bastard. Which made the fact that it was that kind of bastard who got the women hard to take.

‘They’re more exciting. More fun.’

‘But Zoë’s a cosmologist!’ I said.

‘All the more reason why she needs some fun,’ said Andrea. Being a cosmologist sounded fun to me. ‘And, well, Miles is a hell of a good looking guy.’

‘I thought you women were above making judgments based on that kind of shallow, physically-orientated criteria.’

‘Oh, no, it’s just that it’s useful for us to pretend that we are in order to keep you men in line. You’ve also got to remember that Zoë will earn next to nothing as a cosmologist whereas Miles as an upcoming commercial barrister on the fast track to becoming a QC probably earns about 150k a year. That means he can pay for them to do lots of fun things.’

‘And there was me believing that romance was all about a certain undefinable, ineffable chemistry between two people,’ I said. That had always been my hope anyway. That way, I might stand a chance of actually getting some.

‘Well, it is,’ said Andrea. ‘But if you are a woman, it’s also about how many bunches of roses the bloke buys you, where he takes you out to dinner, how often he whisks you off on weekend mini-breaks to exotic European and, these days, North African and Middle Eastern destinations and whether or not he *always* picks up the tab. It’s behaviour hewn into us by million of years of hominid evolution. A female has to ensure that her prospective mate has the resources to sustain her and her children.’

‘Good God,’ I took another large swig of wine. Frankly I needed it. ‘I never quite realised just how mercenary you women are.’

‘Don’t get me wrong. Miles is tall, dark, handsome, witty and intelligent. He’s got a lot going for him apart from just his net present value. I also hear on the grapevine that he is hung like a stallion *and* that he knows how to use it.’

‘Is that the kind of thing that women actually discuss?’ I said. It was something I’d always wanted to know.

‘Oh yes,’ said Andrea. ‘We tell each other *everything* about men.’ Which was what I had always feared.

‘And does size matter?’

‘It would be breaking the unbreakable oath of the sisterhood if I told you that.’

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I thought of my nether regions. I could feel a distinct shrivelling there. This really wasn't turning out to be that great an evening. I drained my glass.

The party was being given by a friend of Andrea's (engaged) who, it turned out, was also a friend of Zoë's. Andreaa had dragged me along because she hated going to parties on her own. I hated going to parties where I didn't know anyone. Which helped to explain what we were doing in the corner together.

Now, I might be single, but I do have my standards. My God, do I have standards. I refuse to settle for second best in a relationship. Which goes a long way to explaining why I'm single. I have a list of very specific, non-negotiable requirements. Blackwell's Ten Commandments, I like to think of them. Commandments to me about what to look for in a girlfriend. Break one of these commandments and I know it will end in tears. Mine. This I have learnt this from bitter personal experience. Not that it stops me breaking them. Time and again.

1. Brunette or redhead. I could probably do a strawberry blonde. And as natural a shade as

possible

2. Bob or longer. Only relatively few women have the right shape of

face and head to really suit short hair

3. Petite. Well, 5'6" or under. I'm not an especially tall man

4. 34C or bigger. And a particular penchant for Agent Provocateur and

Myla lingerie

5. Makes at least as effort in terms of fashion as me. I do have a Margaret Howell shirt

6. A liking for a medium rare steak with triple cooked chips. And curry

7. Prefers red wine to white. Makes an exception for champagne. Of course.

8. Left of Gordon Brown. Not hard I know

9. An upper second class degree or better. In a proper subject from
a

real university

10. No pets larger than a goldfish. I like cats, but I don't want my
life to revolve around one. Much less two

OK, OK. And Zoë seemed to fit pretty much all of them as I far as I could determine. She was about five feet three, had what must be at least shoulder red hair (it was piled rather fetchingly on top of her head tonight), was wearing a short agnès b dress (according to Andrea), had no shortage at all of curves, had been happily tucking into a foie gras canapé along with any number of cocktail sausages on sticks earlier in the evening and was now demolishing a large glass of Gamay Noir. Unfortunately, I couldn't comment directly on her underwear as her dress was definitely non-see-through, but I could all too easily imagine what she would look like in AP underwear. Best not to dwell too much on that particular image in the current circumstances. I had overheard her making a critical remark about George W. Bush's policy on Iran. And I had been told that she had appeared in a *Sunday Telegraph* magazine spread on Britain's top ten young female scientists, so it seemed reasonable to assume that she met and exceeded the educational criterion.

The thing is I had never believed in love at first sight. I wasn't even sure that I believed in love. Until this evening. When I saw Zoë's face for the first time. And, yes, I did have to try and get that bloody Monkees song out of my head. I had to do something about the way I felt. But leaving aside the fact that she had no reason on Earth to be interested in me, what could I do about Miles?

'Hire a hitman,' said Andrea. 'I believe you can get one for about 250 quid in Moss-side.'

'Too risky,' I said. 'She'd be in shock for months afterwards, so I'd have to wait for ages before I could make my move and it's also quite likely that she'd idealise Miles after his death and be subconsciously

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looking for someone who resembles him in both physical and personality terms which, as you can observe, I don't. In either department. No, I need something more subtle.'

'You could just go and talk to her now.'

'I can't do that. She's sitting next to her boyfriend. What the hell am I supposed to say? "Excuse me, Miles, but I've just fallen in love at first sight with your girlfriend. Now, can you please just fuck off out of our lives forever?" Correct me if you think I'm wrong, but somehow I don't think he looks like the kind of bloke who would wear me doing that.'

'I hear he was in the first eight at his college,' said Andrea. 'Look, Miles has nearly finished his drink. Go and offer him a refill. That will give you an opportunity to introduce yourself.' Before I could object, Andrea had thrust a bottle of Gamay Noir into my hands and pushed me towards the couple.

'You seem be running pretty low?' I said to Miles.

'Oh, yes. Thanks,' said Miles as I poured him some wine.

'I'm Alex Blackwell,' I said. 'I . . . I don't think we've met.'

'Uh, no, I don't think we have. I'm Miles Bradley. This is my girlfriend, Zoë Heriot-Shaw.' I shook hands with Miles and then turned to Zoë. I smiled broadly, but, not, I hoped, too cheesily, and took her hand. Of course, I wanted to fall to my knees and kiss it. But that was probably a bit over the top, especially given that Miles, the former first eight rower and a guy who looked like he still but in more than the occasional appearance for Leander was sitting next to her. But I could have sworn that when we shook hands a spark of sexual electricity passed between us. Well, I felt something.

'So, Miles' I said, 'I know it's a bit of boring question, but what do you do?'

'I'm a barrister.'

'That must be so interesting,' I said. I topped up my glass and took a sip of wine. 'And, Zoë, what do you do?'

'I'm a scientist,' she said.

I wanted to say ‘That’s amazing, so am I!’ The truth is that I did half a science degree nearly twenty years ago. (I don’t count the computing bit as science, more a combination of fun and a living.) And that didn’t make me a scientist. Certainly not compared to one of the *Sunday Telegraph*’s Top Ten Young Female Scientists.

‘Really? What particular area?’

‘Cosmology.’

‘Observational or theoretical?’ Well, I might not be a scientist, but I did read *New Scientist*.

Zoë smiled. I emptied the bottle of wine into her glass. ‘Theoretical. Spending long, cold nights up mountains isn’t my scene.’

That much was evident from looking at her. Spending nights in swapping Wildean bons mots with her equally sophisticated friends in swish cocktail bars seemed to me much more Zoë’s scene.

‘Did you start out as a physicist?’ I said.

‘No. I did maths at Cambridge. I’m slumming it these days in the physics department at Imperial. What do you do, Alex?’

‘Me?’ I said. ‘I work in computers. Monte Carlo simulations of the diffusion of innovations. Very dull.’

‘Yes,’ said Miles. ‘I’m sure it is.’ What did he know about it?

‘Oh, I don’t know,’ said Zoë. ‘What kind of stimulations are you involved in?’

This was neither the time nor place I knew to launch into a long technical discussion of what I actually did do. I could already see Miles’s eyes starting to glaze over. I suspected there wasn’t a lot of post-coital cosmological pillow talk in their relationship. Best though not to think too much about Miles and Zoë post-coital. ‘You know the game *The Sims*? Well, it’s a tiny little bit like that except not a game obviously. We have a large virtual world and feed in various demographic data and we let it run and see what pops out. Marketing forecasts mainly. We use it to predict take-up of new products.’

‘That does sound interesting. Does your company have a website?’

‘Of course,’ I said. I produced a business card out of my pocket and gave it to Zoë. ‘There you go.’ The empty bottle of wine suddenly seemed terribly heavy. I realised it was time to make a strategic withdrawal. ‘Well, I better get some more wine. Maybe see you around later?’

Miles didn’t say anything. Zoë smiled. ‘Yes,’ she said, ‘that’d be good.’

‘I thought that went pretty well,’ Andrea said when I returned to our corner.

‘Thanks.’ I did feel quite pleased with myself. ‘But what am I going to do now?’

‘Well, there’s not a lot you can do. You’ve given her your card. The ball’s in her court now.’ Andrea touched my arm. I could feel the glow that my quasi-success with Zoë had generated dissipating as she spoke. ‘You did well over there, Alex, really, you did. I’m proud of you. OK, you’ll probably never see her again,’ yes, that was the whole problem, ‘but at least you did make the effort.’ An effort that couldn’t lead anywhere. ‘That’s all you can do. After all, she has got a boyfriend. Anything more and you’d not only be in danger of turning into a stalker, but in danger of being at the receiving end of a thrashing from Miles’s rather finely honed body.’ All of which was true, but didn’t help me know what to do with the useless desire I felt for Zoë.

When I woke up the next morning, despite my hangover I was able to have a wank thinking about Zoë, but I could feel the image of her in my mind fading as I masturbated. The truth was that in all probability I was unlikely ever to see her again. I could hardly ask Andrea to ask her friend to ask Zoë if she and Miles would like to meet up. As I lay in my fetid pit, my detumescence slowly running its course, I realised it would be easier to bear the loneliness if I didn’t know that such beauty existed.

A couple of days later, I got an email at work:

PAUL M. CRAY

Alex,

great to meet you on Saturday. I had a look at your website and your company is doing interesting work, different from what I do, but fun. Would you be interested in meeting up some time for a glass of Gamay Noir and chat about it?

See you soon,

Zoe

If I hadn't been sitting down I think I would have fallen over. But what the hell did it mean? Was I interested in meeting up for a chat about it. What about it? The email read as though she was asking me out on a date, but she couldn't be doing that. Women don't ask men out of dates. Well, they don't ask me out on dates very often, and they especially don't when they have a boyfriend, much less a boyfriend like Miles. So, she couldn't be asking me out on a date. Could she? But I knew what I had to do.

Zoe,

yes, I would be interested in meeting up some time for a glass of Gamay Noir and chat about the work my company does. I only did chemistry and computing at university, but I'd also be interested in having about cosmology. When might be a good time for you for us to meet?

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See you soon,

Alex

Which was how I came to find myself a few days later sitting opposite Zoë in the Punjab restaurant in Neal Street.

It's not a *date*, I told myself, it's a *friendship* date. This is the twenty-first century. It's perfectly normal and perfectly acceptable for a single man to meet up with an attractive woman with a boyfriend for dinner. She's attached so no sexual pressure. If I just kept telling myself it was a friendship date for long enough, I might start to believe it.

'So,' I said 'how's... Miles?' I needed to get that out of the way as quickly as possible. As far as I was concerned at that moment, there were definitely three people around the dinner table.

'Miles?' She sounded for a moment almost as though she was about to say "Who's he?". 'Oh, he's... he's fine. He's got some sort of work function on tonight. You know barristers. Worse than the Masons for that kind of thing.' Well, actually, no, I didn't know barristers. I didn't get to go out with women that far up the social ladder as a general rule. But I felt that fact better left unsaid.

'Does he like it?' I said. 'Law, I mean.'

'He loves it. He's got his entire career mapped out. When he will make silk, when he will become a judge,' said Zoë. 'Enough of law though. It's all Miles ever talks about and it's not what I came here to talk about tonight. Science. Let's talk about science.'

'Any specific aspect?' I said. 'It's a big subject.'

'What about your work?' She lent forward. 'Tell me everything about it.'

'It's not really artificial intelligence as such,' I said. 'The representations of the people in the stimulation, software agents, just follow a few simple rules. But it's interesting to see what they get up to.'

'Do they evolve?'

‘We’re working on that. It’s one of the projects I’m involved in. We’re always trying to make the stimulations more realistic, the software agents more dynamic in their behaviour. Getting them evolve is one of way of doing that.’

‘But might they evolve actual intelligence?’ I could tell from the twinkle in her eye that she was teasing me.

‘It would be fun if they did, well, probably, but think how much processing power and memory the human brain has. Our server only has the most minute fraction of a minute fraction of that and each agent only a minute fraction of the processing power and memory of the server available to it. They’re not very intelligent agents.’

‘Perhaps our brain isn’t efficient and you don’t need all that raw computing power for intelligence.’

‘Perhaps, but I don’t think we have any evidence that it is. And we could always just turn off the stimulation if the software agents started getting out of order.’

‘Wouldn’t that be murder? Couldn’t they escape on to the internet?’

‘The server’s not connected to the internet. Not for that reason I hasten to add. It’s a commercial sensitive system. Of course, if the sims were intelligent or rather sentient, it would be murder, but it’s not been an issue for us up to now.’ I spooned some rogan josh into my mouth.

‘In the future though. Given Moore’s Law.’

‘Well, yes, maybe in the future. But we’re probably a factor of a million off having the kind of computing power to stimulate human level intelligence.’

‘That’s only 20 Moore’s Law generations. 30–40 years,’ said Zoë. Not that long and of 30–40 years after that, the artificial intelligence would be a million times more powerful than human level intelligence.’

‘But it wouldn’t take 30–40 years for an artificial superintelligence to advance 20 Moore’s Law generation.’

‘You’re right,’ said Zoë. ‘It would be able to redesign its own hardware and software to run faster.’

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‘And each time it did that, it would be able to design the next generation of hardware and software even more quickly.’

‘That means that instead of taking 30–40 years for a millionfold increase in computing power, it would take about 3 or 4 years.’

‘But the next millionfold increase would take hardly any time at all because the doubling time would be a tiny fraction of the original doubling time.’

‘A millionth to be approximate.’

‘The speed and power would go to infinity,’ said Zoë, ‘after two doubling periods.’

‘You got a first in maths, didn’t you?’

‘I was a wrangler, yes. You would hit hard limits on the speed and power of computers, so this is only a first order approximation.’

‘Well, there are various theoretical limits. But a superintelligence should be able to find workarounds for the practical limits, although, at first at least, it’s going to take time to fabricate the new hardware. So, it should easily be able to approach the fundamental limits placed on classical computation by thermodynamics. But if quantum computers are possible, not only would certain classes of problem become tractable, it might be possible to solve some of them almost arbitrarily quickly, especially if Landauer’s principle is not actually valid.’

‘But does the idea of a superintelligence even make sense?’

‘Well, the idea of being to think faster makes sense, I think. In terms of the human brain, we’ve been stuck at the present releases of hardware and software for something like two or three hundred thousand years. There’s no reason to think that the human brain has reached a theoretical limit for the speed of ratiocination.’

‘It’s a sobering thought,’ said Zoë staring into now empty glass of Cobra. ‘Shall we get the bill?’

We found ourselves standing outside Covent Garden tube station. Now, goodbyes on first dates are always awkward. But this wasn’t a date. It was a friendship date. Just two friends meeting up for a meal and saying goodbye at the end of the evening. There was no need for

awkwardness on parting. A firm dry handshake. Well, perhaps not. So what the hell was I going to do? Should I give Zoë a chaste little non-sexual peck on the cheek? I'd never been very good at the etiquette of knowing when to kiss and when not to kiss. We'd only met twice. We hardly knew one another. But this was the twenty-first century. Would she think it odd if I didn't kiss her? Or would she be secretly relieved? I had better give her a peck. I *wanted* to give her a peck. I wanted to feel the skin of her face under my lips. I wanted to take in the smell of her skin. I wanted to taste her skin. I closed my eyes and moved my head towards her cheek. I connected with something. But it didn't feel like what I expected Zoë's cheek to feel like. Oh my God! I instinctively tried to pull away, only to discover that she had her arms around my neck and shoulders.

'For God's sake, Alex,' she said, 'will you just kiss me?' I suddenly discovered that Zoë's tongue was inside my mouth. I'll admit that I didn't have much time for ratiocination, but I did have to confess to myself that this was a turn up for the books.

'So,' I asked when the clinch finally ended, 'would you like to go out again sometime?'

'I thought you never ask,' said Zoë. 'I'll have to sort out something with Miles, but Saturday should be good for me.'

She was going to sort out something with Miles? Well, that was a relief.

'Saturday?' I said, 'Saturday's good for me too.'

Saturday whizzed around. Which was good in the sense that I got to see Zoë again more quickly. But was odd in that the universe had always previously conspired to ensure that events that I was looking forward to took an age to arrive. It was even more strange when you took into account the fact that I couldn't sleep. Well, perhaps not so strange if you figured in the reason why I couldn't sleep. It wasn't that was lying awake all night thinking about Zoë. No, I was lying awake all night thinking about Miles. And what he was going to do to me when he found out that I was cuckolding him. I knew that Miles had been in his

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college's first eight and Zoë had let slip at the Punjab that he currently went to boxercise class three times a week. Now, Miles was a barrister. Who hoped one day to be a QC and eventually a high court judge. A pillar of society. Clearly, there was a great deal of testosterone circulating in his system. And even though he had the good taste to go out with Zoë, there was no guarantee that the kind of arsehole that he was, wouldn't decide to get physical when he discovered that his girlfriend, no, correction, his incredibly sexy, intelligent, drop-dead gorgeous girlfriend had decided to dump him for *me*. Now, in the real world, actual violence was a non-starter. It was something that just didn't happen. But equally in the real world, women like Zoë didn't leave their boyfriends for men like me. So, given that I seemed to have slipped from the real world into an alternative universe where the ordinary rules of life no longer applied, who knew what Miles might do (even if presumably an ABH conviction would hamper his legal career)?

We arranged by email to meet at the Sunny Burger in Garrick Street. It turned out that Zoë shared my liking for a medium classic Sunny, fries, lashings of red wine and good conversation. However, there was a still a rather large problem hanging over us.

'You've got a boyfriend,' I said.

'Don't say it like that,' said Zoë. 'It isn't a terminal disease.'

'Well, no,' I said, 'but it creates certain . . . difficulties for us.' And, more particularly, for me.

'Such as?'

'Miles might not exactly be happy about us going out when you are still his official girlfriend.'

'"Official girlfriend"? ' said Zoë. 'It's not some office bestowed upon me by the government.'

'Well, no,' I said.

'Alex, I like you. I've enjoyed the two, well, yes, meet-ups we've had and I would like to go on more of them. There's chemistry between us. Miles is an attractive man on paper at least, He's an attractive man in real life in many ways, but I don't want a trophy boyfriend. We don't

talk, not about the things you and I talk about. Some people might think they are boring, but I don't. The truth is that, as far as I am concerned, Miles is dull and you're not.'

This was salve to my ego. An, in my opinion, incredibly good looking and, in the opinion of the global cosmological community, incredibly bright (so, on one of the characteristics, there could be no dispute) woman thought that I was at least not "dull". At least as far as she was concerned. Which was good enough for me.

'Miles is my problem,' said Zoë. But he's also my problem if he decides to beat the living shit out of me for having an affair with his girlfriend.

That night as lay alone in bed (yes, I'll admit that I wished that Zoë was lying next to me, but one thing at a time, I thought, was definitely best especially given the circumstances) I felt uneasy about how matters were progressing. That was hardly surprising. I was poaching someone's girlfriend. I'd never done that before. OK, Zoë had done most of the running. But that was hardly the point. Yes, it was a genuine novelty to have a woman pursuing me. Pretty much a first. Definitely a first when you took into account the kind of woman that Zoë was. But surely the whole situation was going to end in tears. Mine. Quite possibly literal ones given Miles. Was it worth it? Our dates (I supposed now that that was they had been) had been enormous fun. But what was the end of it all to be? Love? Well, love was never exactly an easy thing for me. Sex? Well, it was a very concrete physical possibility. But like love, sex was never exactly easy for me. The idea of sex was so much more intense than the reality of sex. That was perhaps inevitable. Ideas lacked the baggage of reality. And the idea of sex with Zoë was particularly intense. But I had always suffered egregiously from the *petit mort*. Oh, yes. So was it worth running the risk of unleashing the wrath of Miles for what might only a few moments of momentary and fleeting and ultimately unsatisfactory pleasure? But then things might be different with Zoë. Perhaps. I mean they could be. And there was absolutely no guarantee that the opportunity was even ever going to arise.

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'Are you clinically insane?' said Andrea to me over the telephone. This wasn't the kind of conversation one wanted to have face to face. "

'It's wasn't my idea,' I said.

'That makes it worse. Voluntarily going along with an insane idea makes you madder than the mad person who came up with it.'

'I thought you fancied Miles?' I said.

'I never said I fancied him. I said he was tall, dark, handsome, witty and intelligent.'

'There you go,' I said. 'You *do* fancy him.'

'Look, Alex, there is no way I am going along with this hare-brained scheme. I thought Zoë was supposed to have a first in maths from Cambridge.'

'She does, Look, the plan is foolproof.'

'Foolproof?' said Andrea. 'What if Miles doesn't fancy me?'

'Of course, he's going to fancy you,' I said. 'You're a good-looking woman, Andrea. Exactly his type.'

'But I don't look anything like Zoë,' said Andrea. 'I'm tall, slim and dark. And I work in finance.'

'To be honest,' I said, 'I wouldn't worry about that. According to Zoë, Miles pretty tries it on with any woman.'

'Thanks for the compliment,' said Andrea. 'But if he does that, why does she need him to try it on with me?'

'Because she hasn't caught him in the act yet,' I said.

'The act? What the hell do you expect me to do with him?'

'Aren't you a bit curious to see if they say is true?'

'Alex, no way am I doing this, no way at all. Why don't just hire an escort to pretend to be your girlfriend.'

'Oh, God, no,' I said 'that would be really icky, Andrea. Besides it would cost me a lot of money.'

'I thought you were keen on Zoë.'

'I am,' I said. 'But I'm not made of money and I don't want to indulge in borderline illegal activities. Come on, Andrea. Please. We've

known one another for years. It'll be easy for us to pass as boyfriend and girlfriend.'

'But Miles knows we're not boyfriend and girlfriend. It must have been obvious to him at the party.'

'Not necessarily,' I said. 'You didn't speak to him. I never said I wasn't going out with you. Zoë was with Miles almost all night and she doesn't think anyone mentioned anything to him about you. He's a bloke. We don't take much notice of these things in the ordinary course of events. In fact, from a strictly Bayesian perspective, it would have seemed far more likely from the way that we were behaving that we had been going out for years and just weren't that much into each other anymore.'

'Don't try and blind me with science. You were flirting with his girlfriend. That might have given him a clue that you were single.'

'You can hardly call what I was doing "flirting". You know I don't flirt. Anyway, lots of people who have partners flirt with other people. Like Zoë glance.''

'Isn't he going to think that we are a rather incongruous couple. After all, I'm two or three inches taller than you.'

'Lots of men go out with women taller than them.'

'No, they don't and not men your height. Alex, as I said, this is absolutely insane. If Zoë wants to dump Miles, for God's sake, she's an adult and this is twenty-first century, she should just dump Miles.'

'Look, I know that. But what I can do?'

'Tell her it's insane.'

'I can't do that.' I said. 'She might dump me.'

'Alex, she can't dump you. You're not even going out. Besides she is obviously insane. You should be dumping her.'

'Dump her?' I said. 'She's the woman of my dreams.'

'Dreams?' said Andrea. 'Nightmares, more likely. She might have a first in maths from Cambridge, but if she thinks that harebrained scheme has a ghost of a chance of working, she's got just about the most

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worst judgement of anyone I've ever come across. You just don't need her.'

'Andrea, I'm in love in Zoë. At least, I think I am.'

'Love?' said Andrea. 'No, Alex, no, you can't be in love with her. You barely know her. You're might be in lust with her because she meets some of the criteria for your ideal fantasy women.'

'And what's wrong with being in lust with someone? Especially with someone who meets pretty much all of my criteria for a fantasy women.'

'It's clouding your judgement. OK, she says she prefers you to the bastard she's going out with at the moment. That's great news. An attractive woman prefers you to her current boyfriend. Now use that ego boost and move on to someone who has the guts to tell her bastard boyfriend that she doesn't want to go out with him anymore. Or better still one who hasn't got a boyfriend at the moment.'

'Look, Andrea, you owe me. If it hadn't been for you, I'd never have spoken to Zoë and I wouldn't be in this mess now.'

'Don't try and blame me, Alex. All I did was tell you to go and refill Zoë's glass. It's up to you to sort things. This is real life. There is no way I am letting myself sucked into a bad Whitehall farce.'

'Alex,' whispered Zoë to me in the kitchen of her flat, 'are you insane? I thought you were bringing your friend from the party. That's who I told Miles was coming with you.'

'She wouldn't come,' I said. 'But surely he didn't remember Andrea from the party.'

'Of course, he remembered her. He's got an almost eidetic memory. I could tell he fancied your friend. That was the whole point in you bringing her. Who the hell is this other women?'

I thought of saying she was a friend. But then I thought better of it. If we were going to have some sort of ongoing relationship, it had to be based on a foundation of complete honesty.

'She. . . she works for an escort agency.'

'An escort agency? You mean she's a call girl?'

‘No, no, she’s an escort,’ I said. ‘It’s completely different from being a call girl. She’s a university-educated woman who offers conversation and discreet companionship to discerning gentlemen in social situations in which it a female partner is considered appropriate.’

Zoë gave me a look that told me that she didn’t consider it appropriate in this social situation. It was too late to do anything about it. I decided not mention how much Michèle’s conversation and companionship for the evening was costing me. It was the part of price I was paying for, I hoped, love.

‘No wonder Miles said that you made an incongruous couple. Not many men go out with women taller than them. Why didn’t you choose someone shorter?’

‘Because I choose someone who looked like Andrea because I thought he’d think she was Andrea.’

Zoë gave me a hard stare. ‘But she’s about three inches taller than her and she’s wearing high heels!’

‘Well, she seems to getting on all right with Miles.’ We looked through into the living. I wanted to add ‘And she is a professional.’ ‘He’s seems to have got over his disappointment that it’s not Andrea.’

Zoë thrust a bottle of wine into my hands. ‘Go and give them something to drink. Bloody Miles brought a bottle. He never normally does that, so we’ve got to get through two bottles.’

I went into the living room with the bottle and three glasses.

‘So,’ said Miles, ‘how long have you two been going out?’

Now, forward planning is the secret of success. Before coming to Zoë’s, I had taken Michèle for a drink in order to brief her on her mission and to agree on a few fictional details to provide verisimilitude to our supposed relationship. I had decided that we had been going out for four months. Long enough that the initial bloom of attraction had started to fade, but not long enough that there was any large amount of relationship history to fake. We had met through the internet (true enough) and Michèle was an artist (also true enough).

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I'd been worried that she might refuse to go along with the situation, but she seemed amenable enough. She was after all a solicitor of a sort. In the world of escorts, I was a virgin and for all I knew this kind of request might be boringly mundane compared to some she had come across. All she had to do was spend the evening flirting with Miles. Flirting, after all, was one of her core competencies. And if Miles fancied a little of tongue action while Zoë and I were out of the room, that shouldn't be too much to ask. In the circumstances, there was hardly going to be the chance for anything more.

'Four years,' said Michèle.

No! no! Not four years, you idiot, four *months*! How the hell could you confuse months with years? We'd gone through that at the pub only half an hour ago.

Zoë came through from the kitchen carrying a large casserole dish. 'Dinner is served.'

'Um. . . smells wonderful,' said Michèle, which it did. 'What is it?'

'Coq au vin,' said Zoë.

'Coq au vin?' said Michèle. I had a horrible premonition she was going to make some kind of puerile joke.

'Chicken in red wine,' said Zoë. I had a horrible premonition Michèle was going to say he was a vegetarian.

'Oh, I like chicken,' she said. Thank God for that at least. We sat down at the dinner table.

In ordinary circumstances, visiting my girlfriend's flat for the would be exciting experience. Zoë's apartment was small with a clean, contemporary look, offset by the crowded bookshelves, stuffed with physics textbooks, works of philosophy, well-thumbed Penguin Classics and novels by the most interesting of modern writers. I would have fallen in love with her bookshelves even if Zoë hadn't looked extremely cute in an *agnès b* dress with her red hair piled up.

But these were hardly ordinary circumstances. I was at my first dinner party at my new girlfriend's house with her boyfriend and an escort who was pretending to be my girlfriend and whose job it was to lure

my girlfriend's boyfriend into some kind of compromising position. Even the particular part of me was finding it difficult to focus on what I would like to do with Zoë's pert little body.

I looked at Zoë ladling out *coq au vin*. I looked at Michèle. I looked at Miles. Jesus, he was a powerful-looking chap. It might have been fifteen years since he left Cambridge, but those boxercise classes had ensured that he had lost little of the physique that had found a place as stroke in the King's College first eight. Boxercise involved knocking seven shades of crap not just out of punch-bags, but also out of humanoid mannequins. It was just a great overall workout, I was sure.

Andrea had been right. This was insane. Absolutely fucking, bat shit mad. I could feel beads of sweat breaking out on my forehead and my heart starting to race. Jesus Christ, was I going to throw up? I gulped down some water and sucked in a deep breath.

I could have just dashed out of the flat. I could have said 'Look this is ridiculous. Miles, as must be obvious by now to a chap of your intelligence with your first class degree in Anglo-Saxon, Celtic and Norse from the University of Cambridge, Michèle is not my girlfriend. And, yes, you're right that does mean I am having an affair with Zoë. Well, we've been on a couple of dates and had a snog, but we haven't had a shag yet, honestly, we haven't, so perhaps it's not technically an affair as we haven't had a shag — I mean when would we have the time? — and anyway you've only been going out for six months and it's not as though you haven't been getting some behind Zoë's back, so what's sauce for the gander can be sauce for the goose and it's not like you're married or living together, so let's all be reasonable and mature and adult about the whole situation.' I could have done either of those things. But there were problems with them. In both cases, there was a possibility that I might get beaten up by Miles and I didn't want to get beaten up by Miles. But in both cases, there was the absolute certainty that I would lose Zoë. And the one thing I knew I really didn't want was to lose Zoë.

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OK, OK. I had no idea what was going to happen in the next two or three hours. I just had to get through them somehow.

‘I understand from Zoë,’ said Miles, ‘that you work in artificial intelligence.’

‘Artificial intelligence?’ said Michéle. ‘What’s that?’ We all looked at her. I would have been better off selecting the escort on the basis of claimed degree subject rather than supposed resemblance to Andrea. I decided that it was best to just ignore her and plough on regardless.

‘Smart, rule-based agents are an aspect of my work,’ I said.

‘So not *real* artificial intelligence,’ said Miles.

‘It depends on what you mean by real artificial intelligence.’

‘Well, the kind of artificial intelligence capable of passing the Turing Test. But didn’t Lucas prove that human intelligence is non-algorithmic?’

I glanced at Zoë as I chewed on a mushroom and tried to collect my thoughts. Miles was a lawyer who had studied extinct medieval languages at university. Had the bastard been reading up on artificial intelligence?

‘Humh,’ said Zoë. ‘Lucas’s idea that they are the mathematical propositions that humans recognise intuitively as true, but that can’t be proved algorithmically is nonsense. Show me such a proposition.’

‘Roger Penrose believes it,’ said Miles.

‘Penrose also believes that a theory of quantum gravity would solve the problem of the collapse of the wave packet, but he’s wrong about that and he’s wrong about artificial intelligence.’ She picked up the bottle of wine and made to top up Miles’s glass. He put his hand over it.

‘No, I’m fine,’ he said. ‘Even if you did have an artificial intelligence,’ said Miles, ‘it wouldn’t necessarily have artificial consciousness. Searle’s Chinese room gedanken experiment proves that.’

I knew that there was a huge literature on the Chinese room and that many people were far from convinced that Searle was on to something. The problem was that I didn't know very much about their objections. Zoë topped up my wine glass and I took a large slug.

'Searle's argument is just a variation on the sorites paradox,' said Zoë. 'As something becomes more intelligent, when does it become conscious? Why don't we ask it if it is conscious?'

'Because,' said Miles, 'it would programmed to say yes, so it's answer would be of no value.'

'We can't prove that any of us is conscious,' I said. We all instinctively glanced at Michèle. She had been offered with the promise of intelligent conversation after all. 'We have to carry out some kind of Turing Test-like examination. If something claims to be conscious and acts as though it's conscious, we ought to be able to adduce some pretty strong arguments against it being conscious if we are to doubt its word. And if it's a superintelligence, it going to be able to come up with better arguments about why it is conscious, or why consciousness doesn't matter, than we are going to be able to come up with arguments that it isn't conscious.' I took a mouthful of chicken, bacon and shallot. The chicken had really taken up the flavours of the wine and the herbs overnight in the fridge. Zoë had told me that she wasn't very good at cooking, but this was the sort of unpretentious, peasant-style food I loved. Was it sophisticated enough for a sophisticated metropolitan dinner party? Sophisticated? What did it matter? The conversation was *interesting*, the food was great and Zoë looked smashing in that dress.

'A superintelligence?' said Miles. 'The idea is philosophically inchoate.'

I swallowed the mouthful of food I was chewing. 'Why?' I said. 'God is supposed to be some kind of superintelligence and plenty of intelligent people believe in God. Tolkien, for instance.' Miles glowered at me. Zoë had told me that he was a big fan. 'Intelligence is the ability to solve problems creatively, particularly to solve problems creatively

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under time constraints. We have no good reason to assume that human intelligence has reached some kind of fundamental limit in solving problems creatively under time constraints.’ The human intelligences in the room hadn’t been able to come up with a creative solution to the problem of Miles, Zoë and me. And I wasn’t hopeful they were going to come up with one in the next couple of hours.

‘The human brain,’ said Miles, ‘is the most complicated and complex object in the known universe. Packed into a couple of kilograms of meat behind the eyes of everyone of the six billion humans on the planet, there is more raw computing power than in the most powerful computer in the world. And yet with all that computing power and all those billions of instantiations, the human race has managed to produce a few dozen genuine geniuses. And even those geniuses were only better at one or two very specific things than the vast mass of humanity. Which suggests to me that there *are* some very hard limits on general intelligence in this universe.’

Zoë stood up. ‘Very hard limits on *human* general intelligence with one particular type of fixed hardware running one particular fixed operating system and set of applications. Artificial intelligences won’t be constrained by the fixed hardware and they won’t be constrained by the fixed software, so they wouldn’t be constrained by the limits of human brain. We can place some ultimate mathematical and physical limits on the power of computing, but the human brain is a very long way from those. Given that Newtons and Shakespeares have existed, I see no reason why a race of Newtons and Shakespeares couldn’t exist and I see no reason why a race of intelligences that are as to Newton and Shakespeare as they are to goldfish could not exist.’ She start collecting the plates. This was my cue.

‘Let me help you with those,’ I said. A few seconds later, we were alone in the kitchen.

‘I thought you said Miles didn’t know anything about science,’ I whispered.

'I never said he's wasn't a very bright guy. He must see you as a threat,' well, yes, 'so he's using his adversarial skills to try and best you in the debate.' Great. I was the butterfly being broken on the treadmill of Miles's first class barrister's intellect. Zoë put her hand on my mine. 'Alex, you should be flattered. He's acting this way because he thinks he's going to lose me to you. I've know what kind of person Miles is,' Zoë looked into my eyes, 'and it's you that I want.' I felt my heart gyrate and my mouth go dry. Either I was about to have a heart attack or I was in love.

I glanced into the living room. Miles and Michèle were deep in conversation. I couldn't imagine what they might be talking about, but Miles was the smooth charmer. 'It's time to initiate stage two of the plan,' I said, 'and we've still got most of a bottle of wine to drink.'

'Take in their puddings.' Zoë and I both picked up two bowls of apple crumble and took them through into the living room.

'My word,' said Miles, 'you have been busy, my sweet: pudding!'

'Apple crumble,' said Zoë, 'so easy to do.'

'Yes, it is,' said Miles. They exchanged a significant glance. Whichever way things went, this wasn't a relationship that had long to run. I poured myself some wine, poured Zoë some and gestured with the bottle towards Miles.

'No thanks,' he said, 'early morning meeting in chambers tomorrow.' I picked up my glass, took three large gulps (and was luckily not to spit it straight out again) and then emptied the bottle into my glass. I suddenly realised that I felt very drunk.

'We've run out of wine,' I said. 'I better go and get another bottle.'

'Do you really think we need any more? My glass is still full and we are already on pudding,' said Miles.

'Oh, yes,' said Zoë. 'It's still early, but the off-licence closes at nine.'

'I think we passed it on the way from the tube.' I stood up. 'I'll only be five minutes.'

'Don't get lost,' I heard Zoë shout after me as I practically sprinted out of the door.

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Five minutes, I was clutching a bottle of Gamay Noir outside the off-licence. I rang Zoë's mobile.

'It's me,' I said.

'You're lost?' said Zoë loudly. '... I know, I know, it's a complete maze... no, no, stay where you are, it'll be easier if I come and find you... see you in a minute... bye... he went the wrong way...'

I walked back towards Zoë's flat and two minutes later saw her coming the other way. We kissed.

'Twenty-five minutes,' said Zoë. 'It would take five minutes to get to where you were supposed to be, five minutes for me to get to where you were supposed to be, five minutes for us to get to the off-licence and buy some wine and five minutes to get back to the flat. Add on five minutes for messing around and you get thirty minutes. That should give Miles plenty of time to move in on Michèle.'

'We've got twenty minutes to kill then,' I said. 'We might as well walk round the block a couple of times.' We started off back in the direction of Zoë's flat. She slipped her hand in mine.

And then we saw a tall figure running towards us out of the gloom: Michèle.

'What the... ' I said. Her face was smeared with tears and distorted into a rictus of ineffable terror.

'I had to get out!' she said 'I had to get out!'

'My flat!' screamed Zoë and ran off down the road as fast as she could taking into account the shoes she was wearing. I followed an instant. I would worry about Michèle later if necessary.

A minute later we were dashing up the stairs of Zoë's apartment block. We reached her landing and stopped. The door of the flat was ajar and from within came an intense golden light. We crept towards the door. I pushed it fully open and I felt some psychic force pulling me into the room.

Miles was lying across the sofa, his face raised towards the ceiling, his hands held up to try and shield him from the brilliance of the light. The expression on his face was the same one of existential horror I had

seen on Michèle's. I turned towards Zoë and then together we raised our faces towards the source of the light.

And looked into infinity. I heard the beginning of a scream inside me and then I felt something *click* inside my mind and I understand that the light was divine light and that all would be well and I turned and looked at Zoë and she turned and looked at me and she smiled, a smile I had never imagined could be smiled and I held out my hand and she took it and we turned our heads and looked towards where the kitchen might have been and we saw two shimmering that were strange and familiar both at once and they spoke together, their voices in perfect counterpoint, although they made no sound.

'You two have been fools, and the price of your foolishness is the knowledge of your foolishness, but even fools have soulmates and you are soulmates.'

And then the figures shimmered out of existence and the golden light vanished. Miles's hands dropped away from his face. He stood and it seemed to me that the look of horror had been transformed to one of what might have been peace or, at least, a kind of peace. Without a word, he stood, took his jacket from the back of the chair and walked out of the door of the flat, pulling it closed behind him.

And then I turned to Zoë and took her in my arms and felt her arms around my body and her breast against my heart.

CHAPTER SIX

PARALLEL 00000 ↑ 0 ↑ 00

5500 WORDS — SEPTEMBER 2021

He watched the man walk down the street. An ordinary-looking man. Average height, average build. He could do with getting to the gym a bit more. The average amount of hair for a man of his age — late thirties — of average colour. There was very little to distinguish the man from any of tens of thousands of other similar on the streets of the bustling metropolis.

‘What about this one?’ she said.

He watched a man walk down the street. He was not an ordinary-looking man. Tall, slim, but, it was possible to tell merely from the way he walked, powerfully built. This man spent a lot of time at the gym. A full head of thick, black hair. Although it was true enough that there were hundreds of men who looked like him out and about in London, he still stood out effortlessly from the crowd.

‘Usually, she’s already dumped Miles by the time she meets Alex. So Alex at least doesn’t have to compete head-to-head with Miles.’

'I'm disappointed in you. You should have more self-confidence. When Alex goes head-to-head with Miles, he wins.'

'Usually,' he said.

'That's not bad,' she said.

'No, no, you're right. It's good, it's very good. It's more than he could reasonably expect.'

'You shouldn't say that. He gets the girl.'

'*Usually*,' he said.

'That's the way it is,' she said. 'There is only so much that we can do. The odds are in his favour though.'

'I know, I know. I just can't help thinking about all the other Alexs, the ones who never get to meet Zoë at all or meet her and she's going out with Miles.'

'There are many worlds in which she marries Miles.'

'Oh, I know,' he said. 'I've been to some of them. How you think I feel about it?'

'How you think *I* feel about it?' she said.

'Sorry. Sorry.'

'It does cut both way.'

'I know, I know, he said. 'Sorry. Sorry. Miles is a jerk. A good-looking, charming, intelligent jerk. But a jerk nonetheless. And worse than being a jerk, he's only interested in Zoë because she's good-looking, charming and intelligent. He hasn't a clue what she does and he cares less.'

'Unlike Alex?' she said.

'Exactly. He's interested. Very interested. OK, he's a layman. But he makes the effort. He's asks the right questions.'

'That can't be enough. Not for Alex to be Zoë's soulmate. She must meet men all the time who are interested in her work.'

'Professionally, yes,' he said. 'But most of them aren't single. Or they aren't suitable for. . . other reasons.'

'There only has to be one,' she said. 'Why is the Alex the one? Why isn't it Bernard?'

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‘He usually becomes a monk. Zoë and Bernard only end up together in a very small percentage of worlds. And in those they aren’t particularly happy in them.’

‘That’s because he wants to become a monk.’

‘Bernard always believes in God,’ he said, ‘or at least the nearest local equivalent to “God”. That’s his curse. Zoë never does. It’s not going to have a happy ending.’

‘Bernard is a philosopher,’ she said, ‘so he sees everything in philosophical terms. Cosmology is just another arena in which to deploy philosophical ideas. For him, philosophy takes precedent over natural science and theology takes precedent over philosophy.’

‘But Bernard is an intense guy. And Zoë is an intense woman.’

‘Who are we to say that Zoë wants an intense guy? Alex is not the Man Next Door?’

‘Well, yes, he can be pretty intense in his own way, I suppose,’ he said, ‘but Zoë, she’s in a different league to him.’

‘You shouldn’t say that,’ she said.

‘OK, it’s not true. Not here. But out there?’

‘You shouldn’t say that.’

‘But it’s true,’ he said.

‘It’s not true,’ she said. ‘You can understand what Alex sees in Zoë.’

‘Of course.’

‘You can understand what Zoë sees in Miles or Bernard or any of her earlier boyfriends. Or the later SOs. Adam or Warwick or Eugenia or Penny.’

‘Pretty much so, I think,’ he said.

‘She doesn’t end up with any of them,’ she said.

‘No. No, she didn’t. Not in a statistically significant number of worlds.’

‘Did end up with Alex?’

‘In most worlds,’ he said ‘yes.’

‘In the overwhelming percentage?’ she said.

‘Well, yes.’

‘Alex and Zoë, Zoë and Alex. It’s the way it always is.’

‘OK,’ he said. ‘but imagine someone who looked like Miles, went to Cambridge like Miles, but who was as interested in physics at Alex. Wouldn’t that combination, all other things being equal, be better than Alex.’

‘It depends what you mean by better,’ she said.

‘More appealing, more attractive.’

‘Miles is a very good looking guy. Alex, he’s OK. No, he’s better than OK. He’s attractive. Yes, Miles is, in some sense, better looking than Alex. That doesn’t matter. Alex is more than good enough on those stakes. Look at this way, would Alex go out with Zoë if she were an airhead?’

‘Well, no,’ he said. ‘But Miles isn’t an airhead in any world. And we are talking about a Miles who is interested in physics.’

‘That might be possible,’ she said ‘if that person existed.’

‘But how can he not exist? How many people get firsts in physics every year from Oxford or Cambridge. Dozens. And most of them are men. And that leaves aside all of the men who get firsts from other universities, but would have got firsts if they had gone to Oxbridge. And all the men who got two-ones who could have got firsts if they hadn’t been distracted by other things. Then there are all the men who did other subjects, not just chemistry and computing, but Anglo-Saxon, Norse and Celtic, but are still interested in cosmology. And that’s just Britain. Zoë lives a cosmopolitan life and there is nothing to stop her meeting, say, a Spaniard.’

‘She has met a few of them. Eugenia, for instance.’

‘Exactly,’ he said. ‘Each year there are hundreds of men — or, indeed, women — produced with precisely the right kind of academic background. OK, OK, some — most — of them won’t be right in other areas, but even if we assume that, say, one per cent of them *are* right that still a few a year. Assuming a five to ten year age range on either side and that’s something of the order of a hundred men who do have all the right characteristics.’

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‘Why one per cent?’ she said. ‘Why not ten per cent? Or nought point one per cent?’

‘It’s just one of those things, a quirk of statistics.’

‘In all the infinite expanse of the universe?’

‘Why are you doing this to yourself? It’s OK,’ she touched his arm. ‘It’s OK, it really is. You’re here. Here is what matters. It doesn’t make any difference what’s out. This is it. This is what is really real. And you’re the one.’

‘We can’t explain human attraction.’

‘We can try.’

‘We can try, yes, but we are never going to succeed. Not fully. The human heart just doesn’t work in that way. Alex is Zoe’s global maximum. He’s her soulmate. That’s the way, it is. You should just try and accept it. Alex, you’re a chemist, for God’s sake, you know about chemistry. It’s the chemistry. He wants her. She wants him because he wants her. And he’s not smooth and uninterested like Miles. He’s what he is and he wears his enthusiasm on his sleeve. So, she sees a little bit of herself in him. But that’s not it. That’s only the shadow of it. What it is really is *love*.’

‘Usually we are not interested in the best fit, we are interested in a good enough fit. If you want to select a candidate for a job and you’ve got hundreds of candidates, you could apply some more or less arbitrary criteria to whittle the number down to one that is more manageable.’

‘You could even choose the subset at random.’

‘You could indeed. If you’ve got a large number of candidates to start with you can be sure that the chosen subset will contain a representative sample of the whole. And from that subset you can choose a candidate who is good enough for the job. That person might not be the *best* candidate in some global sense, but it doesn’t matter because there would never be the time to find the best candidate and it doesn’t matter because the good enough candidate is good enough.’

‘Soulmates are different. They are two parts of a single entity that have been separated. The souls of the soulmates are like the edges of the two sections of a piece of paper that has been torn in half. There might be two pieces that nearly match up — in all the universes, there will many close matches to the external part of the soul, even arbitrarily close ones, but it is not just the match to the external part that matters, it is the history as well. There was one soul from which two were cleaved. And those souls can only find peace when they come together.’

‘We keep having this conversation.’

‘Is that a problem?’

‘Well, of course, not. I enjoy it.’

‘It’s what they do.’

‘We do. I wonder if they do it Up There.’

‘We are together here, aren’t we?’

‘Yes. That doesn’t prove anything though, does it?’

‘What would the chances be of us meeting if they hadn’t been doing something?’

‘You know the answer to that.’

‘But are they like us?’

‘More like us than we are like ourselves.’

‘Why do we see the buggers?’

‘Perhaps we do. Perhaps we did and we just didn’t realise. It’s not as though most of *them* realise what *we* are doing.’

‘And we don’t know anything more than them. We only think we do.’

‘Look at this one.’

‘It doesn’t look good.’

‘No, it doesn’t but it’s a pretty standard scenario. The basic situation occurs in about 6% of cases.’

‘True, but in this specific instance it’s complicated by her being engaged to Miles.’

‘I agree that that is a less common variant, but this is an older Zoë and thus an older Miles.’

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‘And an older Alex.’

‘Yes. Taking into account the age factor, it is not an usual scenario.’

‘No, but it is a tricky one. Which plan?’

‘7B5?’

‘Yes, I think it has to be. It’s not one a plan I like.’

‘No-one ever said it was a case of liking the plan.’

‘A lot of things can go wrong. It’s never obvious how Miles is going to react. Or Zoë.’

‘We can never be certain of that.’

‘What about this one?’

‘Ah, yes. Now that is a tricky one. It’s inevitable that you are going to get it sometimes. That one is definitely one that I can’t help with.’

‘The souls will cross space and time to come together.’

‘There you have it. Your basic default scenario: the world is made of matter and mind is matter in motion. Which is fine as far as it goes.’

‘Wouldn’t they mostly be Boltzmann Brain-type scenarios?’

‘Metaphysics always creeps into the basic default scenario,’ she said.

‘And epistemology,’ he said.

‘How can we know that we are in the basic default scenario and not in a Boltzmann Brain-type scenario?’

‘Well, an individual divides the world into two parts: themselves, of which they have special and direct interior knowledge, and everyone else who, to first approximation, they have only general and indirect exterior knowledge. So everyone else seems to have far more in common with each other, as a class of things, than they do with the individual.’

‘In our case though,’ she said, ‘we do have direct knowledge of one other individual.’

‘Philosophy must always defer to empirical observation,’ he said, ‘but the more general problem remains. It is difficult for us to be certain that we are not both in a Boltzmann Brain-type scenario.’

‘Even if we were certain, the metaphysical issues would still remain: where does the world come from and why does it have the form that it does?’

‘Of course, it is easier for us to answer the metaphysical question: the plane of forms exists because it necessarily must do and it is the form it has because it necessarily must do.’

‘There is a hierarchy of planes of form,’ she said. ‘Most of the Alex and Zoës are at the bottom, but there are some, like us, higher up.’

‘And others higher up than us,’ he said.

‘That is necessarily the case.’

‘We know that the planes of form must exist. It’s a variant of *cogito ergo sum*.’

‘The fact that I can consider a sentence such as “1,973 is prime” to be true,’ she said, ‘means that the concepts of “1,973” and “primeness” must exist that external to us.’

‘On the plane of forms,’ he said. ‘Or *a* plane of forms.’

‘You might exist in a dream or a computer simulation, but as long as you *know* that the sentence “1,973 is prime” is true, you *know* that you exist.’

‘Unless, of course, you are mistaken in thinking that the sentence “1,973 is prime” is true.’

‘It’s different from the sentence “5 is prime”,’ she said, ‘because we might feel that we have direct experience of the number 31 in the way we do of 5, but do not have of 1,973. We could use pencil and paper to verify that 1,973 is prime. It would not take us long, as we have to consider just the primes up to about $\sqrt{1,973}$, which is to say 43, but we might never be certain to an *absolute* degree that we have not made an arithmetic mistake, or worse, that someone or something was not altering our stream of thought to make us believe that we have verified that 1,973 is prime. That is more true double for a large prime such as $2^{43,112,609} - 1$. It is not possible for us to verify that that number is prime by manual methods. We have to take the computer’s word for it.’

‘We don’t have to have,’ he said.

‘They do though. We’ve solved Riemann’s hypothesis. In most worlds at least.’

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‘There’s a great deal more to it than solving Riemann’s hypothesis.’

‘It’s the start,’ she said. ‘We have an equation the solutions of which are prime numbers, an equation furthermore that *we* can understand in a direct way that they cannot, so to us prime numbers are different kinds of objects than they are to them.’

‘Well, we *think* we understand them better,’ he said.

‘It’s down to self-consistency again. When you strip away all the contingent parts of the world, you are still left with something that seems to be too deep to be a put-up job.’

‘At the very least, if it is a put-up job, what we are picking up must at least be the adumbrations of something profound. We are back in the cave with Plato.’

‘A cave,’ she said. ‘Our cave is a different one to their cave, but we couldn’t expect to be anywhere else except in a cave.’

‘And so,’ he said ‘since we can deduce the existence of objects on the plane of forms, we can also deduce the existence of the ur-Alex and ur-Zoë...’

‘... us...’

‘Indeed, of which all the other Alexs and Zoës, no matter what kind of universe they might find themselves existing in...’

‘... Boltzmann Brain...’ she said.

‘... Brain in Vat...’ he said.

‘... dream...’

‘... are imperfect instantiations.’

‘Since we are on the plane of forms,’ she said, ‘we can intervene in any of the planes beneath us.’

‘But this tells us nothing about higher planes of form,’ he said.

‘It also doesn’t tell us anything about soulmates.’

‘Well, what you have is a Platonic ideal of the human being. On some plane of forms, if you were keep on digging down far enough anyway. But it’s like talking about the Platonic ideal of a tree. There are lots of different sub-classes of objects that can be classified as trees and each

sub-class has its own Platonic ideal. It's the same with humans. Only there are vastly more sub-classes of human than there are of trees.'

'There is a vast array of different kinds of classes than exist on the plane of forms,' she said, 'or rather on the *planes* of form.'

'We might be happy with the idea that integers exist on the plane of forms,' he said, 'as some kind of abstract objects that we can, somehow, gain knowledge of. We might be happy about the idea that special real numbers exist on the plane of forms — π and e and $\sqrt{2}$, in fact, we might be even happier about them existing there than the integers because they can only exist as approximations in a non-ideal world.'

'We might be happier still about something like i existing there.'

'And then we add in the idea of soulmates. Once we have the *idea* of Platonic soulmates we know that they must exist on the plane of forms and that they must be instantiated somewhere.'

'All the Alexs and Zoës who are soulmates,' she said, 'and all those who are not.'

'No-one ever said that life was fair,' he said. 'There are so many of them. And there are only two of us.'

'One of us.'

'And there is only so much that one of can do.'

'Do you think it's fair to play games the way we do?' she said.

'Play games?' he said. 'Do you think we're playing games? I'm not sure I do.'

'The Alexs and Zoës, they might think we were playing games.'

'They might if they knew what we were doing because they might feel we are manipulating them and people don't like being manipulated, even if they're being manipulated for their own good. But they don't know they are being manipulated.'

'Not usually,' she said.

'Even if we told them,' he said, 'they wouldn't believe us.'

'I know you feel uncomfortable about that time in the restaurant.'

'The poor Alex didn't know what was going on.'

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‘He got what we wanted in both worlds,’ she said, ‘I got what I wanted too.’

‘We can’t help all of them,’ he said.

‘No, we can’t.’

‘And if we can’t help all of them, should we help any?’

* * *

‘The basic question is this,’ he said, ‘what is it that all those Alexs and Zoës on all those worlds and all those different kinds of worlds have in common? And the answer is that they are instantiations of the ur-Alex and ur-Zoë on the plane of forms. And the ur-Alex and the ur-Zoë are, in turn, instantiations of even more fundamental forms of Alex and Zoë on even more fundamental planes of form.’

‘It is like looking at a tree and saying “That is a tree”,’ she said, ‘but knowing that it must be an instantiation of the ur-tree. Then we ask “What kind of tree is it?” We answer “It is a pine tree.” Then we know it is an instantiation of the ur-pine tree. Then we ask what kind of pine tree, etc. It is the same with numbers. The fact that all the different Alexs and Zoës in all the different worlds *know* that 5, 31 and 1,973 are prime shows that the plane of forms must exist and that the Alexs and Zoës are real.’

‘And the fact that Plato imagined the existence of soulmates and that someone imagined the existence of Alex and Zoë as soulmates shows that that is what they are.’

‘Who imagined them so?’

‘The author,’ he said.

* * *

‘A friend of mine once told me,’ he said, ‘that I should think of women as men in skirts. “What do I like? Beer, football and shagging. Therefore

I will assume a woman likes beer, football, shagging, until I am proven wrong. And then I will move on to the next women.”’ As a heuristic, it does have a certain simplistic utility. But one thing I have always known is that whatever women are, they are not men in skirts. And I don’t like beer or football.’

‘Neither do I,’ she said.

‘What do women want?’

‘The same things as men.’

‘But if women wanted the same as men they’d want women,’ he said ‘Since they don’t usually want women, they must want different things.’

‘Women want many of the same things as men,’ she said. ‘Love, friendship, companionship, support, sex. They looking for them from men, just as men are look for them from women. Men and women aren’t the same, but they are complementary. You shouldn’t ask “What do women want?” you should ask rather “What does *this* women?”’

‘Of course. Every man and women is different and every man and woman wants different things, And many of the things men and women want are the same or at least complementary. But equally the some of the kinds of things that a man often wants and some of the kinds of things that a women often wants are different from one another. For anything that a man wants, you might be able to find a woman who wants that, but some of the things that the modal man wants and the modal woman wants are different.’

‘Doesn’t that make life more interesting?’

‘For certain meanings of the word *interesting*,’ he said, ‘perhaps.’

‘Women want the same things as men,’ she said, ‘just different.’

‘Yes, it might be true that heterosexual women want to have sex with men, but the kind they want to have, when they have sex, how they have sex, who they have sex with can be quite different that are the cases for heterosexual men. And that’s leaving aside, what women are feeling. How can a man every know what a woman is really feeling?’

‘You know what I am feeling.’

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‘Now, yes,’ he said, ‘but before. And out there, they don’t know. It’s totally different for women that it is for men. They have different bits, they have different hormones, they have socialisation experiences that are quite different from the day they are born. What gender you are determines the clothes you wear, the toys you play with, the people you are friends with, the school you go to, the subjects you do, the food you eat, the job you do. All these things are different for women and men. And then after all that, we expect men and women to be able find a unique partner with whom they can form an eternal bond. It’s hardly any wonder that people end up being unhappy.’

‘Humans are the products of hundreds of millions of years of mammalian evolution,’ she said. ‘Most mammals demonstrate a high level of differentiated behaviour in terms of sex. Most *animals* demonstrate a high level of differentiated behaviour in terms of sex. It’s a fact of nature. Two sexes rather than one is more efficient in terms of passing on genes to the next generation and three or more sexes will collapse back to two in a short time. We would expect any alien race we encountered to have two sexes and differentiated sex-determined behaviour patterns.’

‘Pre-Singularity.’

‘Have things changed that much?’

‘Old habits die hard,’ he said. ‘You can’t ignore two hundred million years of mammalian evolution any more than you can ignore the constraints of ecology, but we can at least try to find ways to work around them.’

* * *

‘There is always,’ she said, ‘the fear that the other person will leave you.’

‘Or that you will leave the other person,’ he said.

‘She was in love with him then, but how can she know whether she will be love with him in six months or six years.’

‘Or 60 years or 600. She can’t know. She might fall out of love with her. Or She might meet someone he loves more. It could happen. There are men even more perfect than me.’

‘Yes,’ she said. ‘I know.’

‘You’re not supposed to say that!’ he said ‘You’re supposed to say that it’s not true, that you couldn’t imagine anyone more perfect than me.’

‘You know me by now. You know that I never indulge in false flattery.’

‘That’s one thing I know isn’t true.’

‘Does it bother you,’ she said, ‘that I’m still half on love with Miles?’

‘Only half?’ he said. ‘Last week, it was three-quarters.’

‘I am a fickle creature with an inconstant heart.’

‘I had noticed that.’

‘Does it bother you?’ she said.

‘It would bother me,’ he said, ‘if it were true. But it’s too late for that now.’

‘Does it bother you that it might have been true?’

‘It was never true. You were never in love with him. You were infatuated with him. You were never infatuated with me. But then you never needed to be. You were in love with me from the first thing I said to you because the first thing I said to you was always something that Miles could never have said.’

‘True love,’ she said, ‘is being able to ask your lover if he minds that you are still half in love your ex-lover.’

‘We’re lucky,’ he said. ‘Love is easy for us. Non-random fluctuations in the quantum vacuum, being of pure essence on the plane of forms. Whatever. It’s hard for them. They are only flesh and blood.’

‘That’s why they need our help.’

‘Shall we help them?’

‘We can do nothing else,’ she said.

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* * *

‘I thought I was to old and too odd and too sad and too bad for me to ever hope to be able to love someone, much less that someone could love me.’

* * *

‘Do you think that ours is the only logical possible universe?’ he said.

‘No,’ she said. ‘I don’t think that our is the only logical possible universe. Why should it be?’

‘Well, could the values of the physical constants be different?’

‘If you’re a string theorist, the answer to the question of whether the values of the physical constants could be different is “yes”. I’m not a string theorist. I think a Theory of Everything will predict the values of many of the physical constants that appear to be unconstrained at the moment. It wouldn’t be much of a Theory of Everything if it didn’t. I don’t think it will be a zero degrees of freedom model though.’

‘Why do you say?’ he said. ‘What if the universe is digital? Like in Conway’s Life? Then all the constants would really be epiphenomena arising from a few simple underlying rules? Couldn’t the laws of physics be different from the ones we observe?’

‘Maybe,’ she said. ‘Perhaps we don’t see the whole of the richness of the physics. Take the vacuum energy. It’s possible there are regions of the universe where it has a different value because it froze out at a different level during the Big Bang. The physics in those regions would be different from here in many ways and rather toxic.’

‘But they’d still be in our universe. Those regions would interact with our universe through gravity or electromagnetism, surely.’

‘They could if there were in outside our event horizon, which would be more fun. If they were outside our event horizon, given that

we appear to be living in a universe in which the rate of expansion is accelerating, they'd stay outside our event horizon.'

'So, we'd never be able to prove whether or not they existed,' he said.

'Even though they might,' she said.

'It's worse than the tree in the forest. . . '

'... because at least we know the tree fell. . . '

'... but in this case we don't have even know if there is a forest. . . '

* * *

'Why is Heaven always portrayed as so boring?' he said.

'All that sitting around on clouds, playing the harp. . . ' she said.

'... contemplating the glory of God.'

'Wouldn't that get a bit dull after a while?'

'I suppose if people in Heaven had brains,' he said, 'God could just rewire them to find spending all day sitting around on a cloud contemplating his glory pretty much the most exciting thing you could imagine doing.'

'Isn't that cheating?' she said 'Giving people happy pills to make them happy?'

'It's God we are talking about, so he can make up whatever rules he likes. Perhaps he doles out the happy juice in Heaven to make up for the fact that he doesn't on Earth. That's pretty much the claim of most major religions.'

'C.S. Lewis had the right idea, one of the few right ideas that he had, that Heaven would be something ineffably wonderful: the plane of Platonic ideals. That would be something much more interesting than sitting around on a cloud all day.'

'It wouldn't be hard to be more than that,' he said. 'Nice harp, by the way.'

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‘Thanks,’ she said. ‘Your playing is improving. The practice is starting to pay off.’

‘Are you going to say that Hell is more fun?’ He had a brief vision: her long red hair in a tight bun, wearing a black leather corset, thigh-length spike-heeled boots and brandishing a whip. The vision was all the more arresting for the sight of himself naked, tied to a bed, his cock standing erect, hard as a rock.

‘I’ve told you before, that’s for special occasions when you’ve been a *very* good boy.’

‘I can be good,’ he said, ‘I can be good.’

‘Just make sure you are,’ she said.

‘All the little Alexs and Zoës out there, an infinity of them, completely oblivious to the truth, running around, occasionally, if they are really lucky, bumping into each other. If only they knew.’

‘If only indeed. It’s so cruel.’

* * *

‘Who are you?’ she said.

‘I was Alex Blackwell,’ he said.

‘Alex Blackwell?’ she said ‘Who’s Alex Blackwell? What do you mean you “were” Alex Blackwell?’

‘Alex Blackwell is your Platonic soulmate.’

‘There are billions of men in the world. Millions that could be my soulmate.’

‘Millions?’ he said. ‘Are you so sure? You’re a beautiful, intelligent, attractive woman, Zoë. Why are you so much alone? Where are these millions of men?’

‘I don’t like you,’ she said. ‘

How do you mean? How do you know?’

* * *

The Problem of Quantization Posted on July 12, 2021 by [woit](#) I've been watching Witten's ongoing talks about geometric Langlands mentioned here, and wanted to recommend to everyone, mathematician or physicist, the first of them, on The Problem of Quantization ([pdf here](#), [video here](#), the question session is very worthwhile). For those very sensibly not interested in the intricacies of geometric Langlands, this talk is about the fundamental issue of "quantization".

Hamiltonian mechanics gives a beautiful geometrical formulation of classical mechanics in terms of the Poisson bracket on functions, while quantum mechanics involves operators with non-trivial commutators. It was Dirac's great insight that "quantization" takes functions to operators, taking the Poisson bracket to the commutator. In mathematician's language, it's supposed to be a unitary representation of the Lie algebra of the infinite dimensional group of canonical transformations of a symplectic manifold, so a homomorphism from functions with Poisson bracket to the Lie algebra of skew-adjoint operators on a complex vector space.

* * *

Alex is not an exemplar of organic masculinity. He is not the Mellors to Zoë's Lady Chatterley. He not a gamekeeper or even a beekeeper. The only game he has ever kept is *Call of Cthulhu*.

CHAPTER SEVEN

PARALLEL 77777 ↑ 7 ↑ 77

8000 WORDS — MARCH 2026

Commuting on the Underground every day as I do, it all too quickly becomes abundantly clear just how small a percentage of the population is physically attractive. (Well, OK, I am talking about the female population here. I'd be curious to know if the same observation applies to the male population, but I can only talk from my own bitter personal experience with this matter). Now, for me anyway, little enlivens a dull tube journey more than being able to rest my tired, aching, all too often hungover eyes on some pleasing piece of eye candy even if it is just for a few seconds. But, oh! How so rarely I get the chance! I've wondered if I've just been getting on the wrong trains, but I don't think so. I've lived in London for twenty years and used just about every combination of tube line and time of day and it's always been the same: not enough attractive women. Believe me, it's a major problem. What are Tony Blair and Ken Livingstone doing about it? Very little, if anything, I suspect. It's one of the scourges of our modern era. And people wonder why we men are so unhappy these days. We just want some decent totty to look

at on the tube. Well, OK, perhaps not *just* that, but it would be a start. It would be good if everyday our senses were overloaded with female lusciousness. But it's such a drought out there that I can still recall women from fifteen years ago. Well, *a* woman. She belonged to the species of Classy Older Woman and I've always gone for Classy Old Women. But recent is good too. Take the mother and daughter from the Activia yoghurt adverts. I wish I could. Why aren't there women like that on the Piccadilly Line at eight-thirty in the morning? Either of them would do me. Or both, one at time or together. I wouldn't mind even if the pair of them do suffer from bloating, Honestly, I wouldn't.

These thoughts I had on the packed platform at Hammersmith on Monday morning. The Piccadilly Line was messed up. So what else was new? Over-running engineering works in the Barons Court area. There hadn't been a train for over ten minutes. This has long since gone past ridiculous, I was thinking, when, at last, a train hove into view. As it pulled into the station, I was unsurprised to discover that it was pretty damned jam-packed. I am not a fan of pretty damned jam-packed trains. However, I was standing on the platform towards the back of the train and there was, I saw, enough space, just, for a man and his laptop in the last carriage. The next train might be less crowded, but given that (a) I didn't really want to be any later for work than I already was if I could help it; (b) I had no idea when or even if the next train might turn up, I couldn't really justify to myself not getting on.

After an interminable delay, the train finally trundled off towards Barons Court. Conditions were grim, but at least I was still breathing. If things stayed like this, I could just about cope. But on reaching at Barons Court, a tsunami of people somehow managed to break their way into my carriage. Things were getting serious. If I wanted to be this squashed on a rapid transit system, I'd live in Tokyo.

Half an eternity later, the train reached Earl's Court. Now, Earl's Court is a major interchange station. Which meant that some people got off (hoorah!), but also that a whole new tranche of people got on (boo!). Things had become distinctly unpleasant. And not just because

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there was no way I could read my book in these circumstances given that I could barely move my arms. I like London, it's just I'd like even more if there was about a quarter as many people in it as there in are. (As to which three-quarters I would get rid of, well, that's another story.)

We arrived at Gloucester Road. Maybe some people got off there. I don't know. Probably some people got on there. I can't be sure. What I do know is that there was some tectonic shift inside the carriage and I suddenly found myself in much closer proximity to a complete stranger that I strictly cared to be.

Being shoved up against someone in a crowded tube train is never good, but there are factors that can make the situation even worse. One is being shoved up against someone with an unpleasant, easily communicable skin complaint and a poor bathing routine. Another, less common but almost equally bad is to be shoved up against an attractive member of the opposite sex.

Now, as I said, I like looking at attractive women on tube trains. But, for God's sake, I don't want to touch them. And I certainly don't want my groin thrust against their hip. Especially when that hip seems (I say 'seems' because it was difficult given my lack of mobility for me to obtain a true picture of the body in question) to be joined to a body that has curves that go on forever. And even more so when the gentle swaying and rocking of the train as it made its way towards South Kensington caused my groin to move slowly up and down and from side to side against the hip in question. And, quite frankly, I don't trust my groin that much. "Frotteurism" might be a fine word to roll around one's mouth in the comfort of one's bedroom. But it's definitely not such a fine word to have rolling around your brain as you undertake the said activity, entirely involuntarily, at eight-forty-five on a Monday morning in a Piccadilly Line train between Gloucester Road and South Kensington.

There was a screech of brakes and the train shuddered to a stop,. Which was bad because we were no longer moving towards our destination, but good because at least my bits were no longer being jiggled

about. I'll admit that the main thought that was running through my head was 'I hope to God that I'm not tumescent.'

She looked a bit like Rose McGowan from *Charmed*. Well, Rose McGowan during the two seasons when she dyed her hair red. Although, to be frank, Rose McGowan with any colour hair would do me fine. In fact, any of the sisters off *Charmed* would do me fine. Even Shannen Doherty. With or without their hair dyed red. I do have standards. It's just that they aren't very high standards. But the woman in question would meet any man's standards.

An announcement came over the PA system. I couldn't make out what the driver was saying, but the reaction from the passengers who could hear it, it wasn't good news. Jesus, how long was this nightmare going to go on for?

'Did you catch that?' I found myself asking the woman. What the hell was I thinking? The First Law of Travel on the Tube was that you don't talk to other passengers. OK, that law could be temporarily suspended in emergencies, but the Second Law of Travel on the Tube was inviolable: never talk to someone with whom you are accidentally committing frotteurism.

'Something about an incident at South Kensington, I think,' she said. 'We could be stuck like this for a while.' She shifted her body slightly and a jolt of erotic pleasure shot up from my groin. Jesus, I was sure I'd got an erection. Down, wanton, down! 'I'm getting off at South Ken. I don't know if that makes it better or worse.'

'Where did you come from?' I said.

'That's a bit of deep question for this time on a Monday morning. If my face hadn't already been the colour of a beetroot because of the temperature in the carriage, I am sure that that she could have seen the blush spread across my face. 'Uxbridge. I live in Arnos Grove, but it was my dad's birthday over the weekend, so I was staying with my parents in Northwood. My mum gave me a lift to Uxbridge. Quicker than the Metropolitan Line for getting to South Ken. Well, normally. Where did you come from?'

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‘Brentford, well, Kew Bridge actually,’ I said. ‘Bus to Gunnersbury, District Line to Hammersmith, Piccadilly Line to Hyde Park Corner.’

‘That’s a bit of a schlep,’ she said. ‘I live just by the tube in Arnos Grove. Dead easy for getting to South Ken on the Piccadilly Line, even if it does take a while.’

I had to make a decision. We had exchanged standard London transport-related pleasantries. Typical subject matter for essentially phatic communication. No problem with that. But did I try and continue the conversation for did I just let it fizzle out. Safer to do the second.

‘It wouldn’t be so bad,’ I said, ‘if you could read your book.’ Fuck! What I was doing? The Imp of Perversity had taken control of my tongue. Just shut the fuck up, Alex.

‘Are you reading anything good at the moment.’

‘*The Anthropic Cosmological Principle* by Barrow and Tipler,’ I admitted shamefacedly. Did I really want to have a conversation about the book with a complete stranger. Why hadn’t I lied and substituted something harmless like *What a Carve Up!*?

‘Good heavens! I was talking to John Barrow only the other week. How are you finding it?’

‘Suggestive rather than conclusive,’ which is perhaps not exactly the thing you want to say to a way with whom you have recently been committing involuntary frotteurism.

She smiled. ‘Yes, that’s about the size of it. It’s rather out-of-date now. They could do with doing a second edition. There’s been lots of pertinent research over the last twenty years, including, even if I say so myself, some of my own work.’

Who exactly was this woman I found myself in such intimate contact with?

‘What sort of work are you doing on the anthropic cosmological principle?’

‘You know, the usual kind of thing.’ I raised a quizzical eyebrow. ‘OK, sorry for being so arch. It’s just it’s not common to end up talking

about the anthropic cosmological principle on the tube.’ ‘With men who have committed frotteurism with me,’ I could hear her thinking.

‘Talking about it is a bit weird,’ I said.

‘Some people would think reading about it is weird,’ she said, ‘or talking about it, but they’re wrong.’

As best I could, I looked around me in the packed carriage. I wondered what the people were thinking about us having a conversation at all, much less one about the anthropic cosmological principle.

‘They might, but that’s their problem.’ Come on, give me a break. You might be an active researcher in the field, but I was making an effort by reading the book even if it was twenty years old. ‘So, which particular usual kind of thing are you working on?’

‘Simulations of the creation of universes. Looking at how it is possible for universes with different physical laws or values of the physical parameters to emerge.’

‘Susskind-type landscape stuff?’

She turned her head and focussed carefully on my face. I felt a charge of sexual tension pass through my body. Bloody hell! Don’t do that kind of thing.

‘No,’ she said, ‘not the landscape at all. My work has nothing to do with string theory. The landscape is a complete red herring. You know quite a bit about this kind of stuff for a random stranger on a train. Are you in the business?’

‘Er. . .’, I managed to raise my hand to my mouth to cover my cough of embarrassment. ‘I work in software. Stimulations oddly enough, but for use in marketing. We’re random strangers on a train.’

‘I wonder,’ she said. Was she going to accuse me of being some of stalker. Jesus, honestly, there was no way I could have any control over ending up in this position. ‘There are hundreds of people on this train. But hardly any of them are talking to the strangers next to them. And those that are, in how many cases does it turn out that one of them is reading the classic text in an obscure area of academic research in which the other person just happens to be an researcher?’

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‘Well, there are millions of people in London and all of whom are running into new people all the time and some of whom will have unexpected shared interests.’

‘It’s surprising to win the lottery, but it’s not surprising that someone does.’

‘Um. . . that’s true enough. But we only have a single data point. We shouldn’t prematurely rule in the null hypothesis. If something unexpected happens, it might be a coincidence. Or might be that something more interesting is happening.’

‘We’re back to the Anthropic Cosmological Principle,’ I said. This encounter had turned out to be stimulating in more ways than one. Why couldn’t I have these kinds of conversation with Margaret? ‘Our universe might be atypical, but it’s not surprising that we live in the kind of atypical universe we do.’

‘I’m not sure it’s quite the same thing. So, the pair of us coming together creates a universe. In most universes, nothing happens. The two people don’t talk to one another. In a few, they do, but they don’t talk about books, so they don’t discover whether or not they have any interests in common. In some, they do talk about books and they don’t have any interests in common. In a very few, it turns out that one person is reading book on a topic the other person researches in. But in most cases, it’ll be early Byzantine art or experimental postmodern literature. But in our universe in which it’s the anthropic cosmological principle that is the common interest, there’s a double coincidence. Not only do the two people share an obscure, esoteric interest, it’s an obscure, esoteric interest concerned with the likelihood of coincidences.’

‘I could use the simulation I work on to calculate the probability. of two people meeting like this. Or more importantly, how often we would expect to meet someone was interested in the anthropic cosmological principle. That would get us,’ us? ‘round the problem of the single data point. It would be fairly straightforward to set up. If I ever get to work.’

'I'd certainly be interested in seeing the results. I still think it's too big a coincidence though.'

'But how could it anything else? It's not as though I look like someone who'd be reading the book. I'm dressed as a generic City bloke, so I definitely don't scream philosophy of physics lecturer.'

'Well, you do lack the characteristic goatee and leather elbow patches, although I can't see your trousers so you might be wearing brown cords. You'd be surprised what the trendy philosophy of physics lecturer is wearing these days.' No doubt I would as I didn't know any. 'You are reading the book though and thus your appearance is necessarily consistent with you reading it and maybe my subconscious picked up on clues from your appearance based on the appearances of all the people I have known over the years who have read the book and that's why I decided to reply when you talked to me.'

'We do know more subconsciously than we know consciously, but even if I may look more like someone who is reading the book than the average person who is dressed like me, it's still a punt that I would be reading it.'

'I might be subconsciously psychic and picked up your mental vibes about the book.' She wouldn't needed to be a psychic to pick up my mental vibes at that moment. Cut out the frotteurism, I'll go with just the mind fuck.

'Maybe,' I said, 'but this is a very crowded carriage. It's not as though either of us could exactly have been chosen to stand next to the other person even if we'd have wanted.'

'Perhaps there were forces beyond our ken working to bring us together.' The train lurched into motion, there was a muted groan of approval from the long-suffering commuters and a muted groan of both pleasure and pain from me as my groin was stabbed once again into my new acquaintance's hip. Well, there were certainly forces bringing us together. I wasn't sure they were beyond our ken. I just wished they were a bit more subtle about how they brought us together.

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‘Yes, you’re probably right. I’ve got lots of friends, sensible, educated people, who say things like “everything is for a reason”.’ I nodded. I’d knew the type. ‘I can’t say I believe in fate. I don’t think the universe works like that. This sort of incident makes you think, but’s probably just meaningless happenstance.’ Happenstance, yes, but meaningless, no, not for me anyway. Not that I could tell her that. We’d only met ten minutes ago.

‘I’ll see what the simulation says.’

The train pulled into the station.

‘South Kensington. My stop.’ She somehow managed to get her hand into her handbag and pull something out. ‘Here’s my card. Drop me a line.’ It sounded like an order.

‘Yeah, OK,’ I croaked feebly as I took the card. My voice suddenly seemed to have stopped working as the possible implications of what she had said struck me. ‘I’ll do that.’ She squeezed her way out of the carriage. As she was popped out of the train onto the platform I lost sight of her. Would I ever see her again? Did I want to see her again? Had she left me with any choice? I glanced at her card.

IMPERIAL COLLEGE LONDON

Department of Physics

Zoë E. Heriot-Shaw

Lecturer in Theoretical Physics

An attractive woman had given me her card and told me to call her. Correction: an *incredibly* attractive and, given that that she was a lecturer in physics at Imperial College, presumably incredibly intelligent woman had just given me her card This didn’t happen to me often. In fact, it had never happened to me before. There were only two small flies in the ointment. Firstly, had I the balls to email her? The second

was even more ticklish. How do you tell your girlfriend that you've just met the woman of your dreams?

An hour later, at work, I pondered that question. In truth, there wasn't anything to tell Margaret at the moment, not really. A woman had given me her card. Women gave me their cards all the time. Admittedly, they were women I met through work rather than through committing frotteurism with on the tube and then falling into conversation on metaphysics, but a woman giving me her card was an everyday occurrence. Margaret had no need to know about that. And I didn't have to do anything with the card. I could just forget this Zoë had ever given it to me and put it through the shredder now. Not that that would make any difference, of course, because her email address had been indelibly marked on my consciousness the instant I had looked at it, but that's not the point. I could do it. OK, I had done a quick search for

"Zoe Heriot-Shaw" physics
"Imperial College"

that had revealed her webpages at Imperial, complete with a photograph on the homepage. Well, I had got to see Zoë again, after a fashion. But was looking up someone's homepage being unfaithful? Well, if you fancied them, quite possibly. And if you were going to wank off over the passport-style head shot when you got home tonight? Humh. . . I saw women I fancied all the time. I masturbated over pictures of women who were not Margaret several times a week. In fact, I hardly ever thought about her when I was wanking, which pretty much summed up our relationship, but was hardly the point. The difference was that for those women, I hadn't been given their email addresses and mobile phone numbers, I hadn't promised to send them the results of a Monte Carlo simulation and I hadn't been commanded to drop them a line. All of which went to make the situation with Zoë altogether different.

But, of course, I didn't *need* to do anything. I knew who Zoë was, but she had no idea who I was. It wasn't as though we were likely to

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bump into one another on the tube again. I could just forget about the whole thing, imagine it had never happened.

But that was the one thing I knew I couldn't do. I knew I was going to email Zoë with the intention of engaging her in an exchange of emails that would lead to asking her out for a drink on the pretext of discussing the results of my simulation, but with the real intention of using a combination of wit and alcohol to try and get her into bed (the operative word here was "try", but we are talking about thought here, not reality and I could let my imagination run wild, couldn't I?). So far, the only concrete thing I had done was to do an internet search for Zoë. But I had *thought* of doing all the other things. And I knew that for Margaret, it was the thought that counted.

I let my head slump into my hands. My life had suddenly turned into a bad remake of *Sliding bloody Doors* with Gwyneth friggig Paltrow. Zoë didn't look much like Gwyneth Paltrow had done in that film with or without black wig, which wasn't necessarily a bad thing. I didn't fancy Gwyneth, well, not much: too blonde and too thin. I did, however, fancy Zoë: the right kind of redhead and and the right kind of curves. Fuck! How the hell had I got myself into this mess? By deciding to get on the train that was how. In *Sliding Doors*, Gwyneth doesn't choose to miss the train or not, she just gets accidentally delayed and so in one timeline just gets the train; in the other just misses it. No moral culpability can be placed on her in either universe. But I'd chosen my fate. I had decided to get home early enough to discover Margaret shagging her lover. If only. That'd get me off the hook. But, no. The exercise of my own free will had lead to me meeting Zoë. Fate wasn't going to offer me a way out of the Margaret problem.

If only I had decided to wait for the next train, I'd never have met Zoë and there wouldn't be a problem and my life could carry as normal rather than imploding around my ears. Or if only it hadn't Zoë's father's had been born on a different day (there were after all 365 other perfectly good ones he could have chosen), so that she wouldn't have been staying with her parents in Northwood over the weekend and

wouldn't have got the Piccadilly Line from Uxbridge rather than the Piccadilly Line the other direction from Arnos Grove, which was where she actually lived. Or if only I had decided not to speak to Zoë. What the hell had I been thinking? I never spoke to strangers on the tube, much less ones I was committing frotteurism with. Do as you would be done by. Or if only she had ignored me. What had possessed Zoë to reply to me? Or what if he we had had nothing in common? But, no, I couldn't blame Zoë. It was all my own fault. Well, that's how Margaret would see it anyway, and that's what mattered.

That night in the Punjab, I looked at Margaret and thought 'If you lost a couple of stone, did something with your hair, got a new pair of glasses, bought some halfway trendy clothes and put on some make-up and a push-up bra, you'd probably look quite attractive.' I felt angry with myself for thinking it. But I felt angry with Margaret because in a few hours, for almost no effort, she could convert herself from frump to megababe (well, OK, perhaps not megababe, but certainly kilobabe). I felt angry for feeling angry with Margaret, but there was nothing I could do but let the anger fester. I could imagine the things that she would say 'You men are all the same. You just want some sex object to ogle at it. If you think I'm going up to smear vegetable extracts all over my face and truss myself up in pseudo-bondage gear for your private titillation, you've got another think coming.' What could I do? I was attracted to attractive women. I was the product of hundreds of millions of years of mammalian evolution and 38 years of sexist conditioning. I looked around me at the other men with their partners in the restaurant. Did I want to have my consciousness raised and try and transcend my explicit and implicit sexism? Did these other men? Had they already had their consciousnesses raised? From what I knew of other men, in most cases it seemed unlikely. But perhaps they got round through the ability to establish a dynamic, *lived* relationship with the women. Jesus, this was so fucking confusing! I knew what I wanted: Zoë. I knew what I didn't want: Margaret. But I also knew that my desires were morally indefensible.

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I should dump Margaret. We've only been going out for eleven months, a split would be easy and clean. But I can't be schmuck enough to dump my girlfriend because I don't fancy her anymore and never really fancied her than much and only went out with her because she was prepared to go out with me. I've been the schmuck before and I can bring myself to do it again. It would break my heart to break her heart. The answer would be get her to dump me. But I couldn't even bring myself to be enough of a schmuck to behave badly in the various subtle and no so subtle ways in order to create a pretext.

Some men are born schmucks, some achieve schmuckness, other have schmuckness thrust upon them and the Zoë incident had done for that for me. Since I am now a schmuck, I might as well as use my schmuckness to my own advantage. The problem is I don't want to be even more of a schmuck by doing that. Jesus, I could do with rolling the clock back to ten past eight and not getting on that frigging train.

'What's wrong?' said Margaret.

Of course, I wanted to say 'Nothing', but I knew that would be precisely the wrong thing to say. Flat denial that there was *anything* wrong would be as good as an admission that I was having an affair. No, I had come up with something that might plausibly be wrong with me and so might distract her Holmesian sleuthing instincts.

'It's work,' I said and made a vague gesture with my hand to suggest the dismissal of the whole issue. Work was always a safe topic to worry about. It was the one bit of personal space left in my life. Margaret was a violinist and didn't have a ghost of an idea what I actually did in my job (spend two-thirds of the day surfing the web, send a few emails, mostly to my friends, and then maybe do an hour of actual work right before I went home, but that's not the point). 'There's a big project deadline coming up soon,' the only deadline I had coming up was the one I had set myself on the simulation for Zoë 'and I'm worried about whether we can deliver to the client.'

'You've not mentioned this deadline before.' You had to admit she was good. She should have been a secret police interrogator in some

totalitarian dictatorship. 'You don't worry about things at work. You're always on top of everything.' Oh, why couldn't she just let it lie?

'Well, it came up suddenly. Rush job for an important client.'

'Who is this client?' What the hell did it matter how the client was?

'Er. . . ' Think of a client! All I could think of Zoë's picture on her website and the wank I was going to have when I got home tonight. Not Imperial College. 'Imperial Biscuits. They're launching a some sort of new snack.'

'Imperial Biscuits? But they always plan their campaigns months ahead.' When did Margaret suddenly become such an expert on the snack food industry? Had she started visiting Snackspot during breaks in rehearsals? 'Companies don't just launch a new snack on a whim, Alex. What kind of snack is it?'

'I don't know,' I blurted out. Why the hell did I say that? The companies always told what sort of snack it was so that we could benchmark the propensity of people to buy and like the snack against historical and international data. I was going to have to do some quick thinking. 'It's all strictly hush-hush. They wouldn't tell us what kind of snack it is, just that's it's really innovative and that's been a success really in another country. They want to surprise the market here.' I suddenly felt myself perk up. 'That's why, it's so stressful. Not only is it a rush job, we can't do proper benchmarking, so we can't really be confident that we're providing them with a sensible answer.'

'Why did you agree to do it then if you can't do it properly?'

'It's not up to me!'

'I mean your boss.'

'They're one of our biggest clients! We've got to do what they ask us to do.'

'Well, I think it's ridiculous. You should tell your boss that it's impossible. That's what I would do.' And for one terrifying moment, I had a vision of Margaret storming off down to my office to have it out with my boss like an irate mother having a go at a headmaster because her child is being bullied. What was really terrifying was that I could

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really see Margaret doing it. Which would be a bad, bad thing for so many reasons. I felt my stomach drop. It was September. Whatever happened, I now knew I had to drop Margaret before December. Ordinary people would have long forgotten about this kind of incident before the office Christmas party. Not Margaret. I knew as an absolute certainty that her eidetic memory had recorded this conversation and that she would bring it up in order to have a go at my boss about it. Your girlfriend having a go at your boss was potentially career-limiting in its own right. Her having a go about a completely fictitious project was even more so. I could feel my heart starting to race. Was I going to have an anxiety attack right here in the restaurant? I took a very deep breath.

‘I just to nip to the. . . Back in a second.’

A few seconds later, I was propping myself up over the toilet bowl, just about managing not to puke. Jesus! I was in a bad way. I couldn’t go on like this for much more. I stood up and went over to the sink. Forget about Zoë. She’s just a fantasy. You are never going to see her again much less go out with her. Something like eighty per cent of people have a partner at any given time. Zoë was an attractive women, so she was even more likely to have a partner. She might not have been wearing an wedding ring, but she might well live with someone. And she might be married for all I knew. My search had found a number of articles discussing her, but nothing that mentioned her private life. Perhaps she wore her wedding ring on a chain around her neck because rings made her fingers swell. Forget about her. I splashed some water on my face. Margaret. She wasn’t so very bad. One thing I had learnt in life was that though having a girlfriend might not be much fun, it was more fun than not having a girlfriend. I straightened my tie. Let’s just try and get through this evening. I thought of the Christmas party. That was three months off. I could sort something by then. Perhaps.

When I got back to our table, the starters had arrived. Thank God for that. Something else for me to focus on.

‘Are you OK?’

I took a deep breath. No, I wasn't fine. 'I'm fine,' I said, 'just a bit tense about this project. I'll be OK. How did your rehearsal go today?'

Margaret looked me in the eye. She wasn't fooled by my attempt at changing the subject. Oh, no, not *my* Margaret. 'It went OK. The conductor's a bit of a prat, but the band's good.' She wasn't fooled, but at least she was going to let matter lie. For a little while. Until the ideal opportunity to drive the dagger between my shoulder blades presented itself.

Walking back to the Covent Garden tube station, all I could think of was why would Zoë say 'Drop me a line' if she didn't want me to drop her a line? Would she say 'Drop me a line' in that way if she didn't want me to call her for a date? But had she said 'Drop me a line' in that way? Perhaps it had just been my imagination. An attractive women like Zoë was not going to not have a boyfriend surely. As soon as one was dismissed, there would be another in her social circle of physicists and philosophers of physics ready, able and more than willing to fill his place. No, no. It was ridiculous to think that she would be interested. It was more likely that she just wanted to send me the results of the Monte Carlo simulation. Jesus, I hope she did have a boyfriend. That would get me off the hook with Margaret. I met a women who I fancied more than my girlfriend. Well, that happened all the time. In the grand scheme of things, finding another woman attractive was a fairly venial sin. No, fuck that. I hope Zoë is single. I want to call her up and ask her out on a date. And then take her out to dinner. And take ask her out to the theatre and dinner. And then get to sleep on the sofa at her flat. And then get to sleep in the same bed, but no sex, only kissing. And then get to have wild, passionate sex with her. Actually, I'd rather cut out all the intermediate stages and just cut straight to the wild, passionate sex, but I am trying to be (a) realistic; (b) as non-sexist as I can. Of course, I couldn't do any of that as I was going out with Margaret. But what I could do was write the simulation and then send the results to Zoë.

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So I spent the next day at work working on the Imperial Biscuits rush job. Well, that is what I had told Margaret I was going to be doing after I had kissed her goodnight on the tube platform. It wasn't as though I was suddenly going to become less tense, so I had to keep up the pretense. I work on a product called The Oracle. We sell it mainly to the marketing departments of large multinationals for simulating purchasing behaviour. It's a computer program for modelling the behaviour of large numbers of people. Very large numbers. Perfect for carrying out the kind of investigation I had suggested to Zoë. Compared to the hypothetical Imperial Biscuits project, it was pretty straightforward and by early afternoon. I had finished it.

What to do? Well, she had asked to see the results. And I did have them now. I composed an email. I didn't have to send it.

Zoe,

Alex Blackwell here. We met on the tube the other day. I've done the simulation of the probability of someone reading Barrow and Tipler bumping into someone who is an expert on the anthropic cosmological principle. If you're interested in the results, let me know.

Alex

Short, to the point and not, I hoped, too stalkerish. And it provided her with a hook. The incident was only a couple of days ago, so it was unlikely that she had forgotten it already, but it was quite (very!) likely that she wouldn't have any interest in seeing my results. But if she did have, she could ask. I wasn't going to spam her.

PAUL M. CRAY

But I still didn't have to send the email. I could just delete it and then forget about it. Sending the email wasn't going to solve the Margaret problem. It could only cause more problems. But did that matter? I was already in trouble. She wasn't going to forget about the Imperial Biscuits project. Things couldn't go back to normal.

I pressed

SEND.

I sat there staring at the screen. Perhaps the email would be blocked by her spam filter. Unlikely. It wasn't spam. Perhaps she got so much email she only saw messages from senders on her white list. Perhaps she would see and ignore. 'Please,' half of me prayed to a God I didn't even believe in, 'don't have her reply.'

The other half prayed that she would.

I got into work the following morning, turned on my computer and fired up Outlook. There won't be anything there. There might be. No, no, there won't. It's too early. She's a busy woman. She won't have time to reply even if she wanted to reply. And why would she want to? Please. . . And there it was. I opened it.

Alex,

great to hear from you. Yes. I'd be very interested in seeing your results. What about meeting up to discuss over a glass of red? How about The Archduke near Waterloo station? Do you know it? Next Monday is good for me.
19:30?

See you soon,

Zoë

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This isn't a date I kept telling myself. Technically, it isn't a date. Firstly, you can't go on a date if you are already going out with someone. That would be an assignation. This is not an assignation. Secondly, a date is a date. This was a meeting to discuss the results of a piece of original research. Not a date at all.

Zoë was a relativist. I had found a PDF of her PhD thesis on the web. *Towards an Quantum Cosmological Understanding of Time Asymmetry: Applications of Temporal No Boundary Conditions to the Big Bang and the Heat Death of the Universe*. The only parts I had understood where the acknowledgements (several men were received special mentions: I wondered which had been her boyfriend then and whether he still was) and the first page of the introduction. After that, we'd no longer been in *Scientific American* country or even Barrow and Tipler land. But what was evidently to be was that this was a woman who took time seriously. She'd written an entire thesis on it, so the least I could do was turn up on time. And I also knew that being late for a . . . an appointment was a huge no-no with women. It's not only time that is asymmetric. Expectations of behaviour between the sexes are too. I got there early. And found her sitting at a table drinking a glass of red wine and reading a copy of Nick Bostrom's *Anthropic Bias: Observation Selection Effects in Science and Philosophy*.

'I'm sorry I'm late,' I said.

'No, no,' she looked at her watch. 'You're early. I'm sorry, I'm always early for. . . these kinds of things.' These kinds of things? What did that mean? What kind of thing was this? Did she often meet almost complete strangers in wine bars to discuss the results of Monte Carlo simulations? 'Can I get you a drink.'

'No, no. Let me get you one,' I said. God, I hated this kind of dance of courtesy.

'I've only just started mine. What would you like?' I couldn't really argue with her anymore.

‘A large glass of Gamay Noir would be great, please’ I said. Remember, I said to myself, this isn’t a date. I don’t have to be completely chivalrous. While Zoë was at the bar, I had the chance to get out the graphs and tables summarising the results from the Monte Carlo simulation.

‘I see you’ve been busy,’ Zoë said as she returned with my drink.

‘Er... yes, yes, I have. Thanks for the drink. Cheers.’ We clinked glasses.

‘Any interesting conclusions?’ I suddenly felt like I was an undergraduate at a tutorial for which I was not properly prepared.

‘Well, yes. Of course, it’s all very parameter dependent...’ Zoë laughed. I looked up from my results.

‘It’s OK,’ she put her hand on my hand. She put her hand on my hand! I felt an urge to pull it away, but manage to resist. After a second, Zoë lifted her hand away, but I could still feel the warmth and softness of her skin on mine. ‘It’s just that that’s the story of my own work: it’s all very parameter dependent.’

I forced a smile. ‘Er... I still feel the simulations are telling us something. It’s that it’s difficult to know exactly how many people are reading Tipler and Barrow at any given time.’

‘Or are bumping into people into people on the train.’

‘Indeed. Anyway, I’ve plotted the probability of someone who has read a particular book...’

‘Me.’

‘Yes, and who is an active researcher in the subject of the book bumping into some who is reading the book...’

‘You.’

‘Quite, as a function of the probability of any given person has read the book.’

‘So, it’s a matter of multiplying the probability of someone having read the book by the probability of bumping into someone?’

‘There’s a bit more to it than that.’ I detected a note of high-pitched defensiveness in my voice. I also detected a look of scepticism on Zoë’s face. It was the look I imagined that she gave PhD students who were

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failing to live up to expectations by presenting her with palpably sub-standard work. I felt a cold wave of terror spread through my innards. ‘You have to calculate the probability of bumping into someone. And make a best estimate of the probability of the person reading the book.’

‘And you’ve modelled that?’

I wanted to say ‘Look, it took me bloody hours to do!’ But I didn’t that that kind of self-pity would go down well with Zoë: she’d only be interested in whether or not I was right.

I’m not a scientist. Yes, I did a science degree. Yes, I am very interested in science. Yes, I read a lot of books about science. But that doesn’t make me a scientist. I am a software engineer. Best to leave the outstanding contributions to human knowledge to the experts. Like Zoë.

‘Yes, I’ve modelled it.’ I indicated a particular point on the graph. ‘This is my best estimate of the probability that a random person has read Tipler and Barrow. Of course, I could out by an order of magnitude either way.’

‘That’s why you plotted it on a logarithmic scale.’

‘Well, yes, it’s not until we make the probability of having read the book two orders of magnitude greater that we start seeing a non-linear increase in the probability of bumping into someone who has read the book.’

‘So,’ said Zoë. I looked into a brown eyes for an instant and then looked away. No. This was hopeless. Why would she be interested in me anyway? I had to focus on Margaret. I had to think of Margaret. Margaret who had no idea where I was this evening and could, for all I knew, walk through the door of the bar right now. ‘The results of our simulation agree with my hypothesis on the train. The probability of us bumping into one another is too low for it to be a coincidence.’

‘Well, I wouldn’t say that. I did some basic co-variance analysis and, under the most reasonable assumptions, the probability is not high, but then there are lots of people out there to whom unlikely things can happen.’

Zoë leaned back in her chair. ‘Just a coincidence, you say, a very pleasant coincidence, but just a coincidence. What would you like to do with this coincidence, Alex?’

‘Do with it?’

‘Well, here we are. Two strangers brought together by... coincidence. We could just ignore it. Forget it ever happened. Or we could do something with that coincidence.’ Was this a good time to mention the fact that I had a girlfriend? Almost certainly not, but I had to say something.

‘Would you like a drink?’ She was nearing the bottom of her glass, so it was perfectly reasonable thing to ask.

‘Yes, yes, I would. Why don’t we get something to eat as well?’

I thought of Margaret again. She need never know about this. I wasn’t going to tell her. Not voluntarily anyway. OK, that wouldn’t stop me feeling guilty. And I’d probably act guilty. But if I just kept my face straight next time I saw her, I might be able to stop myself revealing it to her. We’d been going out for eleven months. In another eleven months, the chances were we wouldn’t be going out and the chances were that I would never see Zoë again after tonight, so probably none of this would matter would matter in eleven months. Anyway, I had already broken the unwritten rule. I had broken that when I had opened my mouth on the tube. It must be some atavistic mating instinct. Yeah, right. But whatever way, I was on a *date* with Zoë. I might as well enjoy it.

‘Why don’t we?’ I said, ‘This place looks all right. I’ll get some menus. This should be good.’

CHAPTER EIGHT

PARALLEL 88888 ↑ 8 ↑ 88

8000 WORDS — MARCH 2026

‘How about this one,’ said Nicola. ‘I hate you, John D. Barrow. Box no. 18/09’? It’s to the point and you at least know where the person stands on John D. Barrow. You know him, don’t you, if he’s the chap I’m thinking of?’

‘I do know him and I like him,’ I said. ‘So I’m not sure it’s a good start if the person hates him. Besides, you can’t even tell if they are looking for a man or a woman.’ We were sitting in my living room looking through the personal ads in *The Cambridge Review of Books*. Things weren’t turning out the way I had hoped. I took a sip of the good Ontario Gamay Noir that Nicola had brought. After brief consideration, I decided to take another sip. The sip turned into a large mouthful. I needed it. ‘Or even whether it’s from a man or a woman.’

‘Is that a problem?’ said Nicola.

‘What if they were a woman looking for a man?’ I said. ‘That would be recipe for disappointment on both our parts.’

‘Not necessarily,’ said Nicola. ‘You might discover something unexpected about yourselves. You know you’ve got to start being less fussy if you’re going to make a go of this lonely hearts ad thing, Zo. You’re going to have to be open to all kinds of new experiences.’ She put down the paper and took a sip of wine. ‘What about Eugenia?’

‘What about Eugenia?’ I said.

‘She fancies you.’

‘Just because she’s a lesbian doesn’t mean she fancies me. Besides she’s your friend.’

‘Yes, but you might have noticed what her type is and the fact that she’s always flirting with you.’

‘I am open to new experiences,’ I said, just not sure I was that open to certain ones right now, at least here in this universe, ‘and I am not fussy.’ Was someone with a Y chromosome too much to ask for?

‘Not fussy, Zo! You’re the fussiest person I know.’

‘I resent that,’ I said.

‘Zo, if you weren’t the fussiest person I know, you’d be able to get picked up by someone in a bar, the way the rest of us do.’ I glared at Nicola, who had taken up the *CRB* and was scanning the lonely hearts ads again. Just because she had been picked up by a bloke when we had been out at a bar the month before. Fulton, a rather dishy American architect with whom she was now enjoying a vigorous fling. No wonder her skin was looking so good at the moment. Cow. ‘Case in point: that guy we met in at the Bovril Tower bar last week. There was nothing wrong with him as far as I could see.’

‘Nothing wrong with him?’ Was Nicola blind? ‘He had a mono-brow.’

‘Lots of men have mono-brows, Zo, that’s why they have male spas these days.’

‘So they can get rid of them before they go out and try and chat up women. Anyway, the shortcomings or otherwise in the grooming department of the bloke in the Bovril Tower bar last week are beside the

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point. I met Miles in a bar.' I picked up the bottle of wine and recharged both our glasses. 'Look what that got me.'

'Five months of great sex if I recall correctly,' said Nicola as she closed the paper. 'Did you know that 80% of people meet their future life partner at work? It's a well-known fact. Trust me, I'm a lifestyle journalist. I'm paid to know these things. And, for God's sake, Zo, you're a physics lecturer at a science university. You work in an almost exclusively male profession in an overwhelmingly male institution. There must be *loads* of men at Imperial you could go out with.'

I shuddered at the thought. 'God, no. Have you ever met any of the men in the physics department, Nicola? Half of them don't seem to be acquainted with even the most *basic* rules of personal hygiene. Those that are are either married, the wrong side of fifty or, for God's sake, have beards! I've always made it a rule never to play on my home turf and never to go out with a man with a beard.' I had made an exception for Nigel on both counts, but that had been years ago and so no longer counted.

'Is there no-one you fancy who does have a partner? They might not always be paired off. Sometimes you have to play the long game.'

I took another gulp of wine.

'At Imperial?'

'That's where you work,' said Nicola.

'I think,' I said, 'I'm no longer in the mood to play the long time.'

'In that case, Zo,' said Nicola, 'you do definitely need to expand your horizons. That's one of the reasons why you're single, Zo. As I said before, you've got to start being more flexible. Most of the men at work might be complete dweebs, but then you only need *one* of them not to be. Imperial College is full of men. Imperial's a big place. There must be *some* good-looking ones. What about a hunky, boatie postdoc in the Mechanical Engineering department?'

I've never gone for boaties.' I had made an exception for Miles. I had made great many exceptions for Miles. Not just for Miles. In fact,

making expectations when it came to men was something of a pattern for me. No good had come of any of the expectations. Fussy? I hadn't been fussy enough.

'A nice, virginal 25-year-old cricket-playing postdoc in the Mechanical Engineering department then.'

'I'm 33,' I said.

'Close to the female sexual peak then. You could teach him everything you know.'

'How am I going to meet a 25-year-old postdoc in Mech Eng?'

'There must be a bar at Imperial,' said Nicola.

For a moment, I pondered yet again the subject of Miles. We had indeed met in a bar. By a curious coincidence, it turned out that not only had he gone to my college at Cambridge three years ahead of me, which meant that he had been in the same been in the same year as Andrew, my eldest cousin. When I asked him about Miles, he had assured me that, as far as he knew, Miles was 'sound'. (So much for my Andrew's judgement.) None of that alone wouldn't have been enough to have weaken me at the knees. The first in Anglo-Saxon, Norse and Celtic helped, as did the facts that he was on the fast track to becoming a QC, was six foot one, had been in the college first eight and looked like something a cross between and Pierce Brosnan and Colin Firth. It was the eyes. I am not saying he had the eyes of psychostalker serial killer. That would be ridiculous. Miles wasn't a psychostalker serial killer. His eyes though. I should have been able to tell. I should.

'You've never been in the Holland Club,' I said. 'I can take you there next week if you like. I don't think we'll be having a second round.'

'OK, here's what you do. Join the women in science and engineering society at Imperial. That way you can get to be pally with female academics in other departments. Then you can get them to introduce you to their single postdocs. And they'll be in a different department, so it's not playing on your home turf. Just like going out with your friend's boyfriend's friend.'

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I thought of a couple of friends of boyfriends of Nicola I'd dated. They hadn't worked out, but what about her architect?

'Does Fulton know any single guys?' I said.

'I could ask him, but I think most of his friends are in New York,. But if it's Americans you're after, let's have a look at what you could be having on the other side of the Atlantic.' Nicola picked up the copy of *The Boston Review of Books* from the coffee table. 'The ads are a lot less cryptic in the US. What about this one? "Boston, Married, WM, slightly over 70," but then you've always had a thing for older man and he is only *slightly* over 70. . . '

'Just a minute: what do you mean I've always had a thing for older men?'

'There was Michael. He was, what, 51?'

'That's *one* older man!'

'Yes, but he was *this* year. And you'd fancied him since you doing your PhD and you eventually went out with him because of the Half Plus Seven rule. But that's good, Zo. You're showing the requisite flexibility.'

I took another sip of wine. I had stopped seeing Michael because he was already the wrong side of fifty and I had started getting intimations that he was going to ask me to marry him after less than two months of dating. Had he been ten years younger. . . I felt a twitch in my groin. Miles had been good in bed, but Michael had been a much more generous lover. I could drop him a line. Michael though wasn't the type not to have someone else already on the go. There was no point comparing what Michael might have been like at 34 to what Miles was like at the same age, but I would marry a 41-year old Michael now in a heartbeat. The 41-year old Michael hadn't been the marrying type. Was the 33-year old Zoë?

'Let us continue,' said Nicola, "Boston, Married, WM, slightly over 70, seeks worldly", I'd say you're more the *other*-worldly type, but never mind, Zo, "upscale, pretty," yes, I'll allow you both of them, "sensual," I think you have your moments, "educated," you pass on that *one*, "tall,"

ah, no, not even your best friend would call you “tall” and I am your best friend and I’m not going to call five feet three “tall”, “female”, I can vouch that you are definitely female, “40–50”, well, I’m sure he could be persuaded to make an exception in your case, perhaps you could lie about your age. “I am a highly successful, financially secure lawyer, company president, six feet one, 208 lbs”, what’s that in real money, a bit heavier than Miles, but I suspect you could use some of that sensuality to work off his love handles. “East side resident.” You live in Arnos Grove, that’s not even the East End. “Excellent sense of humour”, and you are so known for your sense of humour, Zo, “seeks sane,”, most of the time, “literate”, yes, “woman”, again, oh, yes, “for conversation”, you’re good at that, “friendship”, you’re fairly good at that, “possibly more”, I don’t think that would be a problem if matters came to that. “There is much you have to say, but haven’t lately found a listener.” I have no idea what he means by the last bit, but his ideal woman could almost be a description of you.’

‘Nicola, it’s nothing like me. He’s married and he sounds like Miles’s father. I don’t want to go with Miles’s father,’ which was true even though his father had been very good looking for a septuagenarian. ‘I don’t live in New York. I live in London, which is also one of the largest cities in the world. I refuse to believe there are no men at all in the UK out there I could do go out with.’

I picked up the copy of *The Cambridge Review*. ‘There must be *someone* in here.’ I turned to the classifieds at the back and started scanning down the columns of lonely hearts ads. Flipping heck! What were you supposed to make of them? I took a long gulp of wine. Being picked up in a bar was easier than trying to decipher just what the hell some of these ads might mean. I was starting to get intoxicated and desperate. I’d never claimed to be an ordinary woman and I wasn’t looking for an ordinary man, but that didn’t make things any easier. An ad caught my eye.

‘What about this one?’ I said to Nicola. ‘ “You’re beginning to suspect that your boss might be a zombie. And I don’t mean of the

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Haitian flesh-eating variety. Only living boy (38, but, hey, 38 is the new 23, isn't it? Isn't it?) in, well, Brentford seeks philosophical women (and if you're not to start with, you soon will be after you've met me), 30s, to go out for cheeseburgers and beer." It's a bit wordy, but the guy sound like he might be a philosophy lecturer. I could go for a nice philosophy lecturer from the Department of Philosophy, Logic and Scientific Method at LSE. I just dig those leather elbow patches.'

'He also sounds like a psychostalker/serial killer' said Nicola. 'There's a *The Silence of the Lambs* quote in there.'

'Yes, but it's not *made* by a psychostalker/serial killer. Not every man is a psychostalker/serial killer, you know.'

'I know that. It's not me who worries they are all the time. Anyway, you just dismissed the entire Imperial College physics department and now you want to go out with a philosophy lecturer with leather elbow patches who might be a psychostalker/serial killer? Besides, you went out with a philosophy lecturer once before.'

'Bernard?'

'Of course, Bernard. How many philosophy lecturers have you been out with?'

'I like to think,' I said, 'that my relationship with Bernard was one of my more successful ones.'

'Successful? He dumped you to become a monk!'

'Yes, but he was very clean and he didn't have a beard. I hear he's tipped to be the next abbot of his monastery.'

'I'm sure he is,' said Nicola, 'but your experience with Bernard doesn't bode well for going out with another philosopher does it?'

'Oh, come on, Nicola. You were telling me to be more flexible a minute ago. I've known lots of philosophers over the years and only one of them has become a monk.'

'The one you went out with.'

Had I been the cause of Bernard finding God? He had already been leaning towards religiosity when I met him and we had both often invoked the Ineffable Her/Him/It/Them/Ver under the duvet. What

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though for Bernard, it had turned out in the end, was the earthly ecstasy of physical union with me compared to the heavenly ecstasy of spiritual communion with God? I had made him chaste and celibate rather too soon for me. I had gone out with Bernard for nearly eighteen months, longer than anyone else except Fabien. I was so bad at sex men preferred God to me? In strict terms, it had only been only one man who had preferred no sex with God to sex with me. I supposed it was a peculiar superpower and that I should have taken it more personally. I had been young and it wasn't as though I was going to get married to Bernard. I was sad to see him go, but we were both happier for it. Was that true? It was Bernard. For myself, it might be true in a more philosophical sense. Perhaps this only Only Living Boy in Brentford might make it true for me true. It was unlikely, but if I didn't try, I would never move anywhere at all.

'In all probability, this *CRB* guy's not even a philosopher. He sounds like he might an interesting guy though.' I took a gulp of wine. My head was fuzzy from alcohol, but I could the resolution hardening in my stomach. 'At my current rate, I am going to be single for the rest of my life. I'm going to drop him a line.'

The next day I bought a postcard of van Gogh's *The Starry Night* at the Imperial College stationary shop. It seemed appropriate. I scribbled a message.

Dear Only Living Boy in Brentford,

I'm a Dennett fan. I'm not convinced that the idea of the philosophical zombie is coherent, so I can't say that I think my boss lacks qualia, although it might help

explain certain of his personality
quirks. What about your boss?

"Hamburgers and beers"?

Humh. . .

My email address is
com.hmail::zodiac-olbib

Zodiac

It seemed odd in the 2000s to be sending a postcard to a complete stranger, but I had created a special email account for the sole purpose of receiving email from Only Living Boy in Brentford, so that we could establish a more faster communications channel with no danger of him being able to find out anything about me that I didn't want him to know. Nicola would approve of that precaution.

A few days later, I received an email

Zodiac,

thanks for the card. It's a
pretty freakily surreal
portrayal of the night sky. I
wonder if van Gogh had seen the
Earl of Rosse's sketches of the
Whirlpool galaxy? There is no
particular reason to suppose
that he hadn't done.

As for my boss, from the look in
his eyes, I wouldn't put it past
him at all to lack qualia.

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Hamburgers and shakes? Well,
every now and then. Well, not
the shakes. Fries though. Why
not?

Alex

I noticed his email address:

com.hmail::a.g.blackwell@hmail.com. Call me only fashioned, but I've always liked a man who uses his middle name. Too many years pouring over scientific papers. I googled 'Alexander G. Blackwell'. An American medical researcher. Not my man. I searched 'Alexander Blackwell'. There were more than 13,000 hits, one close to the top was for a guy called Alex Blackwell, described as a senior software engineer at a company called Electra Research in London that produced software for modelling consumer behaviour. There was a picture of this Alex Blackwell on the company's website. Was he Only Living Boy in Brentford? He looked attractive enough in a cute-boy-next-door way. A contrast with Miles's dark, simmering handsomeness, but a contrast was what I needed. Nice smile. It didn't look like the kind of smile that a psychostalker/serial killer would have.

From a statistical perspective, it was very improbable any of Alex Blackwells were psychostalker/serial killers. Most men weren't and none of the many men I had dated had turned out to be one to the best of my knowledge. Some men were bastards and far too of those were *real* bastards. I'd been out with a few bastards (Miles, for instance), but I had been lucky and I'd never been out with a real bastard (not even Miles, for all his many faults) and I had only known a handful in my entire life. They did exist though and I had no way of knowing on the basis of a lonely hearts ad and an email that this Alex Blackwell wasn't one of them. I'd have a good idea if he was fifteen to twenty seconds after meeting him in the flesh. I could send weeks — months — emailing Alex, but on the internet nobody knows that you're a psychostalker/serial

killer or a real bastard. Talking to him on the telephone would tell me more as many of secrets of the personality are revealed through the voice. We are visual creatures though. The telephone was invented in 1876, writing about five thousand years ago. Before that were hundreds of thousands of years of the social evolution of *Homo sapiens*, millions of years of the evolution of the hominid brain, hundreds of millions of years of the evolution of the mammalian brain and central nervous system, all directed towards allowing us to discriminate in an instant on the basis of conscious and unconscious visual, auditory and other sensory cues whether a stranger was friend or foe. When we met them in the flesh. The picture wasn't going to tell me any more. Most people left little trace on a search engine's radar and this chap might not even be the right Alex Blackwell. Whoever was the right Alex Blackwell had put an ad in the *Cambridge Review of Books* as opposed to *City Limits* or the *Brentford Mercury*. That reduced the probability that he was a psychostalker/serial killer as I hypothesised that psychostalker/serial killers would tend to prefer more mass market publications. He could though be attempting to lull me into a false sense of security. He could, but I had to play this according to the numbers. I had to be a strict Bayesian and act on the likelihood that the payoff would be positive.

I typed a reply:

Alex,

great to hear from you.

The Earl of Rosse had the largest telescope in the world in the mid-nineteenth century, so he must have been something of a celebrity. I don't know to what extent this kind of thing was reproduced in C19th books and magazines, but I don't see

why a reproduction of Rosse's sketch couldn't have appeared in a book or magazine that van Gogh came across. It would be fascinating to find out.

Would you like to meet up
hamburgers and fries some time?

Zoe

I pressed

SEND and realised what I had done. I had asked men out on dates a couple of times before — Bernard, for instance — but they were men I had known well beforehand and was sure weren't psychostalker/serial killers. I thought of ringing Nicola and telling her what I had done, but I feared that we would end up having a row. Besides there was always the possibility that Alex would ignore my suggestion. I'd been asked out by lots of men over the years and I'd turned down most of them. Perhaps Alex had been asked out by lots of women in his life and had turned most of them down and would turn me down because he thought I was being too forward and thus more likely to be if not a serial killer at least a psychostalker.

That wasn't probable though. How often did men get asked out on dates by women? Neither of the men I had asked out had turned me down. Alex knew almost about me, but what was the likelihood that he'd turn down the chance of a date?

The next date I received an email.

Zoe,

"Stars — each, perhaps a sun!
Far, far away from the earth and
its troubles is the mind carried

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by such thoughts and
remembrances."

Vincent Willem van Gogh -
"Collected Correspondence",
1853-90

So, he was definitely interested
in astronomy! And John
D. Barrow, I learn via a quick
search (what a wonderful thing
the Internet is!), found a
similar picture to van Gogh
painting in Camille Flammarion's
widely read (as was van Gogh!)
"Popular Astronomy". I think the
man is cornered.

I'd very much like to meet up
some time soon for hamburgers
and fries. Is there anywhere
particular place you'd like to
go for them? What sorts of times
and dates are good for you?

Alex

When I was a post-doc at Stanford, I'd gone to San Francisco one Friday (it was the beginning of September and the Labor Day was coming and I had a long weekend and I wanted to go to City Lights) and had nipped into a Wendy's for lunch. (They didn't have Pret á Manger in San Francisco and I couldn't normally be bothered with the hassle of going to a deli. There is a reason I have these curves.) There was a young couple there. At first, I thought they must be brother and sister, then relatives of some kind, then friends or at least acquaintances.

After a while, it dawned on me that they were on a *date*. On a weekday lunchtime. In Wendy's. They didn't seem to be hitting it off. I wondered which party had suggested Friday lunchtime at Wendy's for a first date? The women? If it was, she deserved what she got. The man? No self-respecting woman would agree to go on a first date with a man at Friday lunchtime at Wendy's. No good could come of it. That been five years ago and the terrible thing was that two people with such lamentable taste and judgement had both by now in all likelihood managed to find life partners and already or be about to have children to whom they would pass the message that it was acceptable to go on a first date on a Friday lunchtime at Wendy's. It isn't.

Nicola swore by the weekend lunch date, but I always found it difficult to relax on a first date without a large glass or two of decent red and there was nothing worse than feeling half-cut at two o'clock on a Sunday afternoon. Alex might be a psychotalker/serial killer, so a weekend lunch date was the most sensible option, but a school night it would be. There weren't any Wendy's in London even if they had served alcohol, but there were numerous gourmet burger restaurant these days. My favourite one was the Sunny Burger on Garrick Street. Perfect. I hoped Alex was free on Thursday night.

The next Thursday evening, I found myself in the Sunny Burger seated opposite Alex. He was the Alex Blackwell from the Electra Research. I felt relieved that he had turned out to be the man I had thought he was and relieved that his smile was as nice in real life as it had been in his picture. Nicer in fact.

'I came straight from work. I feel I'm a bit overdressed for a burger bar.'

'A gourmet hamburger restaurant,' I said. 'I'm sure they get lots of suits in here.' He was wearing a designer suit, Paul Smith if I wasn't mistaken, and a Paul Smith shirt and tie. I wondered if she was wearing Paul Smith shoes. I bought clothes from the Paul Smith Sale Shop

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when I could afford it. Miles was a lawyer and had dressed in dark, understated, conservative suits. Alex had chosen something sharper and more contemporary and it worked well for him. 'I think you look very smart. Anyway, the burgers are very good.'

'I know,' said Alex 'I've been here before.'

'In that case,' I said, 'you'll know that there is only one thing to order then.'

'Two Sunny Burgers — medium,' said Alex, 'an order of fries, garlic mayo sauce, a bottle of Mexican Cabernet Merlot and a large bottle of still mineral water?'

'You do know what to order,' I said.

'I'll be back in a minute then,' said Alex and got up to order at the counter.

'I thought you worked in software?' I said to Alex when her returned.

'I do work in software,' said Alex.

'Then why are you wearing a suit? All the programmers I know wear jeans and t-shirts.'

'Well, I'm a project manager as well as programmer. And it's a client-facing role. And our clients tend to be large corporates and they wear suits and they expect us to wear suits.'

Also you think you look good in a suit, which you do.

'How long have you been a subscriber to the *Cambridge Review*?', I said.

Alex shifted in his seat.

'Well, er... actually... I'm not a subscriber to the *Cambridge Review*.'

'You're not?' He was a fraud. Who the hell was this guy then? Was he a psychostalker/serial killer after all? In that case though wouldn't he have lied and said he was a subscriber? I wasn't a subscriber either, but that wasn't the point. I was *answering* the ad and as the buyer it was reasonable for me to have certain expectations about the seller, one of those being that he read the magazine.

‘I’ve bought copies over the years,’ said Alex, ‘but these days I mostly just visit the website to print off the occasional article and look at the small ads.’ He looked crushed at making this admission. ‘I do subscribe to the *Boston Review* though. It’s what I read while I’m having my lunch. I’d like to subscribe to the *Cambridge Review* in an ideal world in which I had an infinite amount of time.’, but I just don’t have time to read both.’ I didn’t subscribe to either magazine, although I always made a point of nipping into the Cambridge Review Bookshop when I was in Cambridge. I suppose we were even on that score.

The wine arrived.

‘Would you like to taste the wine, sir?’ said the waitress.

‘Would like to taste the wine, Zoë?’

‘Yes,’ I said, ‘yes, I would.’ I swirled the wine around my glass and sniffed it. It was fine.

‘Your postcard got me thinking,’ said Alex a few minutes later, ‘about the connection between science and art.’

‘We usually think of them as diametric opposites,’ I said.

‘We do. We look at *The Starry Night* and we say it is beautiful.’

‘It’s a painting,’ I said. ‘It’s supposed to be beautiful.’

‘And it is. But is the Earl of Rosse’s sketch of the Whirlpool Galaxy art? And is it beautiful? And what about a photograph of the Whirlpool Galaxy?’

‘I’d say it was beautiful,’ I said, ‘but then I’m a cosmologist.’

Our burgers and fries arrived. I dipped a chip into the garlic mayo sauce. I wanted to offer it to Alex, but it was still early in the journey. I bit the end off. It tasted good.

Alex picked up his burger and took a chunk out of it. When he put it down, I saw that there was a smear of egg yolk on his chin. There was a reason a Sunny Burger was called a Sunny Burger. I reached for a napkin. I stopped myself.

‘There’s some food on your chin, Alex.’

‘Oh, OK.’ He picked up a napkin and wiped the offending material away. ‘I’d agree with you. It is beautiful. Buy why?’

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‘It’s a spandrel,’ I said. ‘Natural selection selects us for our capacity to find beauty in useful things.’

‘Such as potential mate,’ said Alex.

‘Indeed,’ I said, ‘or good places to live. A consequence of that capacity is that we can find beauty in things that don’t have any direct usefulness in helping us to survive.’

‘Such as *The Starry Night*,’ said Alex, ‘or the Whirlpool Galaxy.’

‘Animals must have a sense of beauty,’ I said ‘for their mate or their home. . .’

‘. . . but not for *The Starry Night* or the Whirlpool Galaxy. . .’

‘. . . and the ability to use imagination to transfer our sense of beauty from the utilitarian to the non-utilitarian is one the things that makes us human.’

We laughed. Finishing one another sentences on the first date was the sign of something.

We had finished our burgers. If this hadn’t been a school night, I would have obeyed the advice of the warmth between my legs and suggested we repair to a nearby bar for a calvados. It was school night, so I suggested a coffee. I still didn’t know who Alex might turn out to be.

On the eastbound platform of the Piccadilly Line, Alex said ‘Would you perhaps be interested in the possibility of maybe meeting up again some time?’

‘Yes,’ I said, ‘I would very much like to meet up again.’

There was a pause.

‘I’ll. . . I’ll call you,’ said Alex.

In normal circumstances that would have been enough. These didn’t feel like normal circumstances though. I could tell that Alex was the kind of man who would call me, but when? Today was Thursday, which meant that the earliest he’d call would be Sunday, but Sunday was a flat, end of one week, beginning of the next, neither one thing nor the other kind of night when many people just didn’t feel like calling, especially if they were tired after the weekend. Anyway, people were often

busy or away at the weekend. Perhaps Alex was busy or away this weekend and even if he wasn't, he would have no means of knowing that I wasn't even if he did feel up to calling. So he probably wouldn't call me until Monday at the earliest, which was four days off. That seemed a long time off all of a sudden.

'Are you free on Saturday?' I said.

'Saturday?'

'The day after tomorrow.' The correct answer is 'Yes'.

'Er. . . Saturday?' said Alex. 'Yes, yes, I'm free.'

'Why don't you come round to my flat for dinner?' I said.

'Oh,' said Alex. 'OK, yeah, that would be good.'

On the tube home, I soon abandoned any attempt at reading my book. What had I just gone and done? The chances were that we were going to end up in bed on Saturday. That was, after all, the point of inviting Alex for dinner at my flat. He would know that we were probably going to end up in bed and he'd know that I'd know that we were probably going to end up in bed. Repeat *ad infinitum*. There been a definite connection between us tonight, but I didn't know for certain yet that Alex wasn't a psychostalker serial killer. The weight of evidence of tonight indicated that it was much less probable that it had been before I had met him. Alex didn't have the slick charm that I associated with psychostalker serial killers, but maybe that was what made him effective as a psychostalker serial killer.

I was being ridiculous. Most men are not psychostalker serial killers. Alex was not a psychostalker serial killer. I could have suggested going on another dinner date, meeting up for a coffee date, going to see an exhibition at Tate Modern, taking in a film at BFI South Bank, strolling hand in hand down along the Thames, getting to know one another slowly. If Alex was The One, then waiting a couple of weeks to go to bed with him wouldn't matter. If he was the One though, *not* waiting wouldn't matter either. Some part of my primitive, reptilian brain had been woken from a too long slumber and was telling me that there was

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something unusual about Alex. It had told me to invite him for dinner on Saturday. It was telling me to go to bed with him as quickly as I could. I had managed to best that part of my brain when it came to going any further with Alex tonight. I didn't have to do anything I didn't want to do with Alex. On Saturday, I would discover whether he was the man I hoped he was.

Later, as I walked the few hundred yards home from Arnos Grove station, I pondered Saturday's other vital issue. I had managed to ascertain that Alex would eat pretty much anything, which simplified the decision about what to cook. I only had to worry about what *I* wouldn't eat. Something simple as I only knew how to cook simple things. I'd been a wrangler at Cambridge and I'd never had time to learn to cook anything more sophisticated than student chili con carne. Unlike Miles. He could even make souffles and eggs Benedict. (He could also speak four languages, not counting Latin, Ancient Greek, Anglo-Saxon, Norse and the various Celtic ones — or English itself, whereas I was a monoglot Anglophone.) He had a fish thermometer that he had made himself from a thermocouple and a voltmeter. Only having a degree in Anglo-Saxon, Celtic and Norse never stopped Miles from ensuring that his fish was cooked to absolute perfection.

That was one of the things about Miles. Underneath, the super-cool, supersmooth carapace, he was a very geeky guy. It was part of his appeal to me. He had studied Anglo-Saxon, Norse and Celtic because he was a *Tolkien* fan. Miles didn't look like the kind of guy you'd expect to be fluent in Elvish and he didn't talk about it at dinner parties. That was also part of the problem though. It wasn't that I was particularly a Tolkien fan, but I wanted to go out with someone who would talk about things like Elvish at dinner parties, not in an obsessive way, but in a 'This is something interesting and I'm not ashamed to be interested in it' way. Every aspect of his inner life resided in its own hermetically-sealed compartment. He was fascinated by Tolkien, but he had read hardly anything else written after about 1350. He could make charming small talk in half a dozen languages (including, no doubt, Elvish),

talk interestingly and wittily about dozens of different topics, but his true passions were locked away inside himself. When I tried to draw out of Miles the appeal of imaginary languages, he was defensive and evasive. I didn't know whether Alex was fluent in Elvish or any other language than English, or care, but I knew from tonight that he didn't keep his intellectual passions locked away.

I couldn't hope to match Miles's level of skill, dedication and attention to detail in cooking, but I didn't have to. Three courses? Why not? I'd done three courses twice in my life before. Neither time had been a sitcom-style disaster and there was no reason my first dinner for Alex should be one either.

The secret of cooking, Miles had always said and practiced, was forward planning. Cook as much as possible in advance and just reheat when needed. That was the strategy for Saturday. I didn't want to be slaving in the kitchen, when I could be exchanging *bon mots* with Alex.

Starter? Oysters? You didn't cook an oysters, which made them the easiest possible instant starter. The problem was that I didn't like oysters. What was the point of them? They were something you just swallowed, a slick white glob that merely left a salty aftertaste in the mouth. No, not oysters. Soup then? That was perfect for reheating and simple to make as it was just stock with a few vegetables thrown in. Main? I could make coq au vin tomorrow night. It even tasted better if left overnight. Pudding? It had to be apple crumble: those domestic science lessons at Northwood College had taught me one useful thing. I could prepare the crumble and the soup on Saturday afternoon, then all I would have to do would be reheat the various courses in the evening and boil a few vegetables to go with the coq au vin. The recipe for an stress-free dinner. I hoped.

Alex turned up at seven-thirty on the dot. We opened the very potable bottle of red that he had brought (he had also brought me flowers: Miles had never brought me flowers) and made a start on the soup.

'What kinds of geek things were you into when you were a teenager?' I said. Miles may have been a geek of sorts at heart, but so was I

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and so I already knew was Alex. You can't take the teenager out of the geek.

'Er. . . computers and chemistry and science-y stuff and and science fiction and *Traveller* and *Dungeons and Dragons* those kinds of things mostly,' said Alex. 'This soup is great.'

'I'm glad you like,' I said 'My brothers and cousins and their friends used to play *D&D* a lot in their mid-teens. I played a bit with them, but I preferred reading to be honest. Are you a Tolkien fan?'

'Well, not a fan as such, but there are certain things I do admire about his work. The sheer scale of his sub-creation, for instance. It might not quite all hang together when you start analysing it, but a staggeringly huge amount of work went into it.'

'All created to have somewhere for his imaginary languages to exist,' I said.

'And for the stories told in those languages,' said Alex.

'I wonder if we invented language so that we could tell one another stories. That's what makes us human — story. It's how we connect with other people.'

'And fantasy is the source of story,' said Alex, 'so ultimately it is the source of what makes us human.'

'I'll get the coq au vin,' I said.

A couple of minutes later, we resumed our conversation where we had left off.

'Imagination feeds on fantasy and creativity feeds on imagination,' said Alex. He bit into a forkful of chicken and mushroom. 'We can only create what we can imagine.'

'*Homo faber*,' I said. 'We are Man the Maker whether we are making flint tools, food, theories of the early universe, computer simulations of human behaviour or stories.'

'Or imaginary languages,' said Alex. 'There was a time when I used to wonder why people bothered with made-up languages. There are so many real ones to learn, why bother learning pretend ones? When I was nineteen, I tried writing my own programming language. Well, it's

the kind of thing you do when you are nineteen and doing a computer science degree or rather half a computer science degree and you realise that you are never going to write the great BBC Micro game after all. Years later I used to look at back and wonder why I bothered — didn't I have better things to do? — but now I realise that I was wiser than I knew when I was nineteen.'

'Because creating something is to make it real.'

'Exactly,' said Alex. 'For some people, Middle-earth is more real than the real world.' I wondered if that was true for Miles.

'That's the power of story,' I said. 'It's not just Middle-earth. Almost any novel will do. When I'm on the tube reading a novel, the characters in it always seem more real than the people sitting next to me.'

'Well,' said Alex, 'you do get some peculiar people on the Piccadilly Line.'

We had finished the coq au vin.

'That was good,' said Alex. It had been good and Alex looked good in his Paul Smith shirt (a different one from Thursday's, so he had at least two good shirts) and I hoped that he thought that I looked good in new agnès b dress. Given how long it had taken me to get ready, he had better be thinking that.

'There's pudding,' I said.

'Good heavens! I feel pretty full up, but I'm sure I can fit it in somehow. What is it?'

'Apple crumble.'

'My favourite! How did you know?'

Alex might not quite be at Miles's level when it came to smooth charm, but he had one major advantage over him: transparent sincerity. I might be intoxicated with alcohol and endorphins, but I could see that that much was true.

I brought in the apple crumble. I had made a single individual-sized pudding. There is nothing more romantic than sharing food with your (potential) lover.

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‘That smells delicious,’ said Alex. He picked up his spoon and broke the crumble lid of the pudding. He scooped out a generous amount of filling and topping and then dipped it into the cream. He hesitated with the spoon in mid-air. Was he going to make the right decision?

Alex brought the spoon towards my mouth. I accepted back what I had offered him. The delicious juxtaposition of different flavours and textures: the crunchy, nutty crumble, the sweet, juicy fruit, yielding with just precisely the right amount of resistance to the tooth, the ensemble given tremendous depth and density of flavour by a generous dose of calvados, all this warmth contrasting delightfully with the smooth coolness of the cream.

I picked up my spoon and returned the gesture.

‘Delicious,’ said Alex, ‘absolutely delicious.’

There was a dribble of cream on Alex’s chin. I scrapped it on to my spoon and popped the spoon into my mouth. It was the most intimate thing I had done to Alex so far.

Alex dug into the crumble again. I liked having Alex’s spoon with its load of crumble and cream in my mouth. I would have liked his tongue even more. Unfortunately he was too far away across the table for that at the moment.

‘That was so good,’ said Alex. ‘You’re a wonderful cook.’ Not as wonderful as Miles, but I could find my way to a man’s heart.

‘Would you like a coffee?’ I said.

‘That’d be great.’

‘I’ll just go and put the espresso maker on. Why don’t you repair to the sofa and make yourself comfortable?’ I said.

We hadn’t kissed properly yet, nothing more than awkward pecks on the cheek on Thursday night and when he had arrived this evening. With us on the sofa, now was Alex’s chance to move into for the clinch. How much more encouragement did he need?

I nipped into the kitchen and turned on the ring to start heating the moka pot, which I had pre-prepared so as not to lose any valuable

kissing time. More forward planning on my part. Now it was up to Alex to do his bit.

I didn't want to go back into the lounge before the coffee was ready as so we could get down to any business without interruptions. I watched moka pot never boils. I checked my hair and make-up in my compact mirror. I'd do. I hoped Alex was getting bored in there on his own. At long last, the moka pot fizzed and burbled. I poured the two little espressos, put them on a tray with some petit-fours and a large calvados and took it all through into the lounge.

As I came into the room, I adjusted the light downwards. Not very subtle, but I had a feeling that the time for subtlety was soon going to be over. I sat down on the sofa and handed Alex an espresso.

'Have a petit-four,' I said. 'I'm ashamed to say that I didn't make them myself.'

'That's nothing to be ashamed of. If life's too short to stuff a mushroom, it's too short to make your own petit-fours.' He bit into the morsel. 'Um, this is delicious.' We laughed and for an instant we looked me straight into each other's eyes and I saw that his were a wonderful deep greeny-brown. I felt my insides lurch. It was always the eyes that got me in the end. Alex looked away. No, no, don't look away.

I downed my espresso in a gulp and then looked at Alex out of the corner of my eye. He had leant back on the sofa. A contemplative look had settled on his face. I bit into my petit-four. 'You're right,' I said. 'These are good petit-fours.'

Alex sat up and put his hand on my thigh for a fraction of a second. 'Yes, they are.' It's all right, Alex, you can leave your hand there.

I swallowed the second piece of confectionary and then picked up the glass of calvados and took a tentative sip. The liquor warmed my body. 'Try some calvados.' Alex took the glass and sniffed it.

'Um, I like calvados,' he said and took a sip.

'That's good because so do I.' I ran my hand along Alex's leg.

I moved my face towards Alex's. He turned his head slightly. I could feel his warm, calvados-infused breath. Come on. I put my arm around

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his shoulder. I could feel the tension in his body. Alex turned his head towards mine further. We were facing one another directly. I stared into his eyes. They were very different from Miles's cool blue eyes. He moved his face towards mine. I felt my head moving, by instinct, away from Alex. He sustained his momentum. Our lips met and I felt Alex's arms envelope me. I pushed my tongue into his mouth. He tasted of apple crumble, coffee and calvados. Delicious. We broke away, adjusted our positions on the sofa to push our bodies closer together and then resumed kissing.

A few minutes later, I said 'You know what I'd like to do, Alex?'

'Er. . . in. . . in what sense exactly, Zoë?'

'In the sense of what I'd like to right now.' My hand was underneath Alex's shirt. I flicked open a button. He might not have been in the first eight, but he was no stranger to the gym.

'I don't know, Zoë. What would like to do right now?'

'I'd like to have a shower.'

Alex puckered his face in confusion. 'A shower?'

'Yes,' I said, 'a shower. A shower with you. Would you like that?'

'Er. . . yes,' said Alex. 'Yes, I'd like that very much.'

'Good.' I stood up. 'Come on then.' I held out my hands, he took them and I pulled him to his feet. 'This way.'

In the bathroom, I continued the unbuttoning of Alex's shirt. I undid his belt, unzipped his flies and loosened the button on his trousers. I could feel his bulge.

'Come on. Get the rest of them off.'

He pulled off his shoes and socks and slid out of his trousers. What a lot of clothes men wore. Alex was now naked except for his briefs. They were also Paul Smith, which was good.

'They'll have to come off too,' and I pulled the briefs down, allowing his cock to spring free. Alex stepped out of his underpants. I pulled him towards me and we kissed hard. The sensation of Alex's nakedness pressed against my clothed body felt wonderful.

I felt Alex fumbling with the zip on my dress. 'Just a minute,' I said, 'It'll be easier if I turn around.' The sound of the zip being undone sent a stab of desire through my stomach. I stepped out of my dress and shoes, turned round and kissed Alex. He put both arms around me and undid my bra. It fell away and I felt Alex's pulling at my briefs. A second later and I too was naked expect for my favourite amber necklace. Best not to risk that in the shower. I unfastened it and put it down on the shelf. Then I took Alex's hand and stepped into the shower cubicle, pulling him with me. I turned on the hot tap. We both gasped and laughed as the cold jet of water struck our bodies. In a few moments, it had warmed up. (I had put the immersion heater on earlier in the night. Forward planning.)

I like a *clean* man. That had been one of the things that had attracted me to Bernard. I wanted to make sure that Alex was clean all over.

I picked up the flannel and shower gel that I had placed in the cubical, squirted gel onto it and started to soap down Alex's chest with circular motions reached further and further down his torso until I reached his cock. I could feel it tensing and straining as I soaped it.

I stopped washing Alex and looked up again into his eyes. They were beautiful. I felt our bodies pressed together, his tongue was in my mouth, his hands roaming over my breasts, my back, my buttocks, the warm water playing over our skin and the glow of desire reaching up from my groin.

CHAPTER NINE

PARALLEL 99999 ↑ 9 ↑ 99

7400 WORDS — MARCH 2026

The first thing I did when I got home that night was the first thing I did every night: check the Vljublennost' i Druz'ja website. There was always the possibility that a new member or two might turn up when I did a Detailed Search. Someone could have had a day off and finally got round to joining the website. It was the kind of thing people did on their days off. Well, it was the kind of thing that I did on my days off. And if there were new members, there was even the possibility that some of them might be of interest to me. Of course, the search usually just returned the dull list of the usual suspects: women who either I had long ago decided that I had no interest in (if they were regulars on the ski slope, forget it, I've never been skiing, or if they liked football, it was a non-starter since I have no interest in overpaid hoodlums kicking a pig's bladder around a field) or if there was something not quite right about with their picture (OK, that was shallow, but you really had to wonder what planet some people were living on when they chose their photographs) or who I had already been on an unsuccessful date

with. The less said or indeed thought about the egregious Vivid and our 'date' at the bar she owned in Herne Hill, a date during which she had interviewed someone for a job as a bouncer for the bar, certainly a first in my extensive dating experience, the better. Not that that stopped me waking up in the middle of the night screaming sometimes. The lesson I had learnt was: never go on a first date with woman in the bar she owns. But, really, I had known that beforehand.

Today, there were no new members, exciting or otherwise, but I was pleased to discover that someone had winked at me. Members could send emails to one another or, if they preferred, just a wink. This indicated that someone was interested in you without the strain of having to compose a coruscatingly witty emessage to a complete stranger who was probably just going to delete it straightaway. I was less pleased when I saw who the wink was from: Zodiac.

Zodiac was very much one of the usual suspects. When the search faculty on the Vljublennost' i Druz'ja site returned the list of matches, Zodiac was almost always towards the top, which meant that she logged on to the site very regularly. Obviously, she wasn't having a great deal of success meeting the person of her dreams, but then neither was I. Since she turned up in my searches so often, I had spent a great deal of time studying her profile. As far as I was concerned, there didn't seem to be anything wrong with her, which was the whole problem. She was simply way out of my league. OK, I had noticed that, according to our profiles, we did have a fair amount in common. Both thought that Woody Allen was really funny, whereas Rude'n'Crude humour wasn't, and both had a preference for good value gourmet when dining out. But I'm merely a software project manager whereas Zodiac was a lecturer in theoretical physics. And for me, the fact that Zodiac was an academic and, according to her profile, a self-confessed intellectual was a show stopper.

It wasn't that I wasn't interested in ideas. Quite the opposite. I read books, I went to the theatre, I spent a great deal of my time just thinking about things; probably, my friends have told me, rather too much

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time thinking about things. I had even started a PhD, but things had worked out and I had eventually ended where I am today. And anyway from the people I knew who did do PhDs, I also know there is a world of difference between getting a PhD and becoming an academic. That difference in my opinion (I had given this subject no little amount of consideration) could be summed up in three words: talent, energy and focus. In order to be a successful academic, it was necessary to have a talent for your subject. I have an upper second in chemistry and computing from King's College London. And I had had to work pretty hard to get that. After I started my PhD, I fairly quickly realised that I was never going to make an outstanding contribution to computational chemistry. It was also necessary to be totally committed to your subject. I couldn't imagine being totally committed to anything. Certainly, there were many things I liked, but that was s hardly the same thing. I quite enjoyed my work, most of the time anyway, and I was, I supposed, reasonably good at it, but I didn't leap out of bed in the morning before the alarm even went off eager to dash straight to work and get down to it. Rather the opposite in fact. My PhD supervisor had said that when he was a PhD student he didn't want to go home in the evenings. I could hardly wait to do so when I was a PhD student and I could hardly wait to do so now I was a software project manager. And if I ever had any energy, it long ago drained away.

I could imagine Zodiac with her friends and colleagues, sipping champagne cocktails in the SCR, Wildean *bons mots* dripping from their lips. Of course, I knew that it was highly unlikely that that they would actually be sipping champagne cocktails in the SCR, this being Britain in the early twenty-first century and academics not exactly known for their excessive salaries, but, for some reason, the image had stuck in my mind. The thing was that from the picture on her profile, Zodiac just looked like the kind of woman who would drink champagne cocktails while Wildean *bons mots* dripped from her lips. It was only to possible to tell so much from the low resolution photographs on the Vljublennost' i Druz'ja website, but what it was possible to tell

about Zodiac, told me plenty. She was a curvy, petite, and in my opinion, drop-dead gorgeous redhead. Little more needed to be told. She clearly wasn't the woman for me. Or rather, she was the woman for me, but there was no way I could possibly be the man for her. Why would a woman like her want to go out with someone like me? I knew I could never be a contender. Surely that must be obvious to her too?

But she had winked at me. She must have studied my profile. Or cast a cursory eye over it at the very least. Maybe she had just made a mistake. Maybe someone had cracked her account and was sending winks to the least attractive men that could be found on the site. That wasn't very likely. It was more likely that she had finally reached the bottom of the barrel, i.e. me. There were, after all, only a finite number of men on the site. She must have chewed up and spat out all the half way decent ones already. Which suggested that she was highly selective when it came to potential boyfriends. But a wink was a wink. OK, a wink from someone in my league would have been more exciting. There would have been a chance of something interesting happening. There was however no denying that she had winked at me and it would be rude not to reply. And I had nothing to lose. Except my self-pride when she discovered the truth about me.

I could just wink back at her. But that might be a bit too coy. OK, it would put the ball back in her court, but we could easily end up creating a veritable rally of winks between one another. That wouldn't get either of us very far very quickly. A short, non-committal emessage was better.

Zodiac,

great to hear from you. Hope
you're having fun. I'm never
quite sure what to write in
these things. They should have
given us lessons at school. Pity

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the emessages hadn't been
invented then!

Any exciting plans for the
weekend? I'm going to see a play
in Stratford (upon Avon, I
hasten to add, not Stratford,
East London).

My real emessage address is
com.hmail::alex.blackwell.

Alex

I was somewhat startled to received a reply almost by return.

Alex,

yes, I am having fun, thanks!
Well, I think it's fun anyway.
I'm trying to solve a particular
knotty problem associated with
an application of a new
miniverse model that I read
about yesterday in a pre-print
on the web. I know, I know! It's
not everyone's cup of chai. But
each to her (or his) own! But
your message did give me the
chance to rest my weary neurons
for a few moments.

Which play are you going to see?
RST, the Swan or The Other
Place? I love going to

PAUL M. CRAY

Stratford, although I haven't been for ages. This weekend, I'm planning to go to my uncle's dacha in the Northwood Hills. It'll give me a chance to get out of the city for a couple of nights, get some fresh air and clear my head of all those equations.

Look forward to hearing from you soon,

Zoë (I never said my handle was original)

PS: my real emessage address is
ic.ac.uk::z.e.heriot-shaw

Her uncle had a dacha in the Northwood Hills! So, not only did she have a genius-level IQ plus, seemingly, a body to die for, her family, or at least her uncle, had some fairly serious money. Perhaps those champagne cocktails weren't purely a figment of my imagination. This was getting seriously out of hand. This woman was on a completely different planet to me.

Nevertheless, I felt compelled to message straight back.

Zoë,

sorry if I interrupted your thought processes.

We're going to see "Love's Labour Won". My favourite

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Shakespeare play, so I'm quite excited.

What kinds of food do you like?
My favourite is Polish.

Have fun at the dacha.

Alex

I soon received a reply

Alex,

that's remarkable! LLW is my favourite Shakespeare play too. It's just so romantic! I always have a tear in my eye when the king and the princess get back together at the end. I've heard good things about that production. I hope you enjoy it.

As for food, I'm a big fan of Polish too. I love kasanka for starter, followed by golonka or golabki with a side order of kasza and racuchy for dessert.

Do you know the Krakow in Neal Street? Would you like to catch dinner there one night soon? What about sometime next week? Is Tuesday good for you?

A bientot,

Zoë X

Well, that certainly was remarkable, I thought. Those are exactly my favourite Polish dishes. Did I know the Krakow? It was one of my favourite Polish restaurants. Was Tuesday good for me? It certainly was now.

‘Did you know,’ said Zoë, ‘that the Krakow is one of the oldest Polish restaurants in London? It was opened in 1948.’ I did indeed know that. It was exactly the kind of fact that I loved to collect. I recalled all too many dates when it had been me telling my date that kind of information. It was hard to believe that I was sitting opposite a gorgeous woman and she was telling me these facts. It seemed a very real possibility that I had died and gone to heaven?

‘What did people do before Polish restaurants were invented?’ I shoveled some kasanka into my mouth. ‘I mean it’s not as though anyone in Poland ever ate anything like this or at least not very much like this, but I can understand why we Brits took to Polish so quickly when they were introduced after the war. Can you believe that I hadn’t been to a Polish restaurant until I went to university?’

‘Is that true?’ said Zoë. She took a long sip of beer.

‘Absolutely,’ I said. ‘My parents had no truck with any kind of foreign muck, even though Polish food tastes almost exactly like British food only more so.’

‘My parents were always keen on Polish,’ said Zoë, ‘even my grandparents, my father’s parents. My grandfather acquired a taste for Polish food during the war, he served with a Polish RAF unit.’

‘You were lucky,’ I said, ‘but at least I discovered Polish in the end. The main thing is that we both enjoy it. But it’s surprisingly hard to meet someone who enjoys the sorts of things I enjoy. I go to the theatre,

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cinema, restaurants, museums, bookshops and they're always full of people, but when I go on a date, it often turns out that the person has never been to the National Theatre, has lived in London for ten years, but doesn't know where the National Gallery is, claims to like books, but doesn't know where Foyle's is on Charing Cross Road and has never heard of Gordon Ramsay. How come you never get to meet the people in theatre, art gallery, bookshop, restaurant?'

'You're in luck,' said Zoë. 'I'm a Priority Member of the National Theatre, regularly attend events at the National Gallery, have an account at Foyle's and start saving up for my next Gordon Ramsay meal as soon as I have had the last one.'

'That's great,' I said 'You're the exception that proves the rule.' I took a large swig of Polish beer. 'It's the kind of problem we test with our software at work. We're both interested in the theatre, so we go to the National Theatre a great deal. We notice that there are a few hundred people at each performance, which is a lot of people at a cocktail party, but isn't that many out of the tens of millions in the Greater London Commute-to-Work Area. Most people, even people with our kind of educational background, don't go to the theatre or bookshops every often, if at all. So the probability of meeting someone who does do those things is smaller than you might think. But we could calculate a value of the probability to see just how improbable it was that we should have met.' I desperately wanted to touch her arm, but I was terrified that she might recoil as though from an electric shock. Why did this whole dating business have to be so damned difficult? Why couldn't people just say what they felt? Of course, I knew that the reason was the other person might not be thinking what I was thinking. I was thinking that I'd like to make mad, passionate love to Zoë right then and there in the restaurant on the table. However, it was, I feared, highly unlikely that Zoë was thinking that she wanted me to make mad, passionate love to her right then and there in the restaurant on the table. It was more likely that she was thinking that Einstein was right, time really is relative

and can slow down to a crawl under certain circumstances. Such as being trapped in the Krakow restaurant with some geeky bloke who liked the sound of his own voice rather too much. If she knew what I was thinking, I suspected that she would have slapped my cheek, thrown her drink in my face and stormed out of the restaurant. So, perhaps, it was for the best that one's inner private thought did remain inner and private.

'All the information was on your profile,' said Zoë. 'I knew what I was getting with you.'

'But profiles don't always tell us everything we need to know,' I said.

'Are you trying to tell me something?'

'I didn't mean that,' I said. I took another sip of beer. 'I just mean that profiles can be misleading. You sounded great on your profile, but I was. . . I was. . . er. . . too. . . scared to try and contact you.'

'Why would you be too scared?' said Zoë.

Well, I desperately needed another drink. 'I mean you say that you are a cosmologist in your profile. That's pretty high-powered.'

'I am a cosmologist,' said Zoë. 'You do some esoteric work with your software simulations.'

I wanted to say that that what I did was hardly the same thing, but instead I took a gulp of beer. It was best to take the compliment as gracefully as I could.

'It's just that there are many things,' I said, 'that can stop someone responding to a profile.' What were the things that had stopped Zoë from responding to my profile? And why finally had she winked at me? Presumably because she had been working her way down the list until she came to me. Which wasn't terribly flattering. But then I was in the Krakow on a date with Zoë and none of those bankers, lawyers, management consultants or, indeed, cosmologists she had winked at before me were.

'When you do in the end respond,' said Zoë, 'sometimes you wonder why it could take so long.'

'Or why you bothered,' I said.

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‘Yes,’ said Zoë, ‘not all dates live up to expectations.’

‘Yes,’ I said, ‘yes, that is true.’

‘Some dates exceed expectations.’

I drained my beer glass. ‘How was the weekend at the dacha?’

‘It was great,’ said Zoë. ‘I did some sailing.’

‘You’ve got a boat?’

‘It’s my uncle’s dinghy. It’s very small. Like the dacha. My uncle’s retired and he and my aunt live in the Crimea most of the year these days, so I can use the dacha whenever I like as long as I bag it before my brother or parents do. Like next weekend. Would you like to come and visit it?’

I wanted to say ‘Would I like to come and visit it? I’d be quite prepared to sell one of my kidneys to get the chance to go there with you.’ Instead, I said ‘Next weekend’s great for me.’ OK, I had actually already arranged to go and see an old friend I hadn’t seen for several months. But, hell, I hadn’t seen my friend for several months. What difference would another few months make? And it was hardly everyday that I got an invitation to go to a dacha in the Northwood Hills with one of the world’s leading young cosmologists. I was sure that my friend would understand that. Not that I had any intention of telling him.

‘Excellent,’ said Zoë. She smiled. ‘That’s a date then.’

Zoë wasn’t wrong about the size of the dacha. It was built in the traditional pine wood cabin style with a kitchen/living area with a couch, which I hoped I wouldn’t be sleeping on, a small bedroom just big enough for the double bed I hoped I would be sleeping in and a tiny bathroom. However, the dacha was only about 50 metres from the shore of Lake Northwood. The location alone would make it worth a small fortune.

‘We keep the dinghy in the boathouse over there,’ said Zoë. We were sharing a glass of Georgian champagne on the veranda of the dacha, which faced the lake. The view was breathtaking with the tree covered slopes of Northwood Island emerging steeply from the blue surface of

the water shimmering in the bright sunshine. I had been to Lake Northwood many times before, but only as a tourist. Zoë, on the other hand, looked like she belonged here. Certainly, I had never sipped champagne on the veranda of a Lake Northwood dacha with a beautiful woman before, much less a beautiful woman who had invited me there as her sole guest for the weekend. It was hard to believe I was actually there and that some strapping, wind-tanned banker, lawyer or management consultant wearing a polo shirt with the collar turned up wasn't suddenly going to come along and tell me to get my filthy hands off Zoë (metaphorically speaking — I hadn't actually touched her physically yet, not even a goodbye/hello kiss) to bugger off back to where I belonged. 'We could go for a sail later. The wind's perfect.'

'I've never been on a boat,' I said. 'Well, I mean I've been on ferries and things, but never a small boat like a dinghy.' Presumably the men Zoë normally dated were typically near Olympic-standard sailors. Near Olympic-standard? I feared that Zoë was the kind of women who only dated men who came from the games with at least a bronze.

'In that case, we must go for a sail.' Zoë drained her champagne flute.

'I might get seasick,' I said.

'How can you get seasick? We're going sailing on a lake. Come on, let's do it now. Let's see how your first time goes.'

Well, I thought, half an hour later, this really is the life. After tacking rapidly and skillfully (it seemed to me, but then I wasn't an Olympic-standard yachtsman) into the middle of the lake, Zoë had taken down the sail and the dinghy was now drifting slowly and silently on the current. At first, this had worried me. Wasn't there a chance that we might get run down by another boat? There were, after all, quite a number out on the lake on a beautiful day like today. But Zoë had assured me that everything was perfectly in order. The current was so slight that boat couldn't drift far. And it was the responsibility of anyone under sail to avoid boats that weren't. Ordinarily, I would still have been worried. It might well be the responsibility of those under sail to

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avoid boats that weren't, but how could you be certain that they would act responsibly? But I trusted Zoë. Maybe it was just her Cambridge insouciance or maybe it was just the fact that she obviously did know what she was doing on the lake. Or maybe it was just that I was letting my heart go a little for one time in my life.

We were lying in the boat with our legs hooked over the side dangling in the cool water.

'What are you thinking?' said Zoë.

Normally, I would have replaced my actual thoughts with harmless substitutes.

'I was just thinking how happy I am,' I said. 'I can't remember ever being as happy as this.' I laughed. 'I'm sorry. That sounds a bit melodramatic. It's just that I'm not very good at being happy.'

'There's nothing to be sorry about, Alex. I happy too. I'm happy to be here with you with the warm sun shining down on us and our feet in the feet and the birds singing in the sky.' She leant over and kissed me. 'What's there not to be happy about?'

What indeed? I kissed her back fiercely.

We lay next one to one another, holding hands, our shoulders touching lightly for a few minutes in silence.

'Do you sometimes think the world is a put-up job?' I said.

'I think that all the time,' said Zoë, 'but in what particular way do you think it's a put-up job?'

'There are probably about three or four hundred people who live in my apartment complex,' I said. 'But I only ever see the same half a dozen or so people out of the window, at the gym, at the bus stop, walking back from the station, in the supermarket. It's like living in a cheap cartoon. After a while, they run out of stock background characters and have to start re-using them.'

Who are *they*?' said Zoë.

'The mad scientists who feed the simulated experiences into our disembodied brains located in vats of amniotic fluid in the underground laboratory.'

‘I’ve always wanted an underground laboratory,’ said Zoë. ‘If I ever have a house, I’m going to have one in the basement along with an observatory on the roof.’

My God, was this woman after my own heart? ‘Got to have the observatory,’ I said. ‘And a huge library. With double helix spiral staircases.’

‘That does without saying,’ said Zoë. She touched my hand. ‘Brains in vats in the underground laboratory is very steampunk. There doesn’t have to be a *they*.’

I intertwined my fingers with Zoë’s. ‘How do you mean?’

‘If the universe is large enough,’ said Zoë, ‘any arrangement of matter that we care to imagine will come into existence just by random chance somewhere.’

‘Such as a brain in a vat in an underground laboratory?’

‘Yes. It doesn’t have to be an actual brain in a vat in an actual laboratory though,’ said Zoë. ‘It could be a simulation of a brain in a vat in an underground laboratory in a computer that has spontaneously popped into existence somewhere.’

‘The point being,’ I said, ‘that since it is possible to construct Turing machines from extremely simple logical materials, for instance, very basic systems of cellular automata, it will be more probable, if the multiverse is large enough, that we are living in a spontaneous simulation than in a real universe.’

‘It explains why the universe seems like a put-up job,’ said Zoë. ‘Simple simulations are more probable than complex ones. Thus the fact that you observe stock characters being reused is consistent with the kind of simulation you would expect to be living in.’

‘Hang fire a minute,’ I said. I squeezed Zoë’s hand. ‘You set up the laws of physics and the initial conditions. You let things run. The Big Bang, hydrogen and helium are created, stars form, they make the heavy elements, planets form, life emerges, life evolves and eventually, owing to the inevitable evolutionary pressures and happenstance, after 13.8 billion years or so, general intelligence emerges. Now, it’s pretty

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simple, in principle, to set up the laws of physics and the initial conditions and end up with the universe we find ourselves. Our universe looks as though it evolved into the state rather than springing into existence fully formed in the way that we would expect for a simulation.'

Zoë squeezed my hand back. 'Except for the stock characters in your apartment complex,' she said.

'Expect for them,' I said.

'Well, our universe looks as though it has evolved, whereas we might expect a spontaneous simulation to feel weirder.'

'And the universe does feel weird sometimes,' I said.

'That's one we would expect. Consider a universe with the laws of physics as we think we know them. If it's large enough, it will necessarily contain spontaneous simulations. Furthermore, we observe the universe to be a low entropy state, but we would expect it to be in a high entropy one. The low entropy state we observe might be an illusion, a projection of the simulation. If the universe were in a high entropy state, it would produce more spontaneous simulations.'

'So,' I said, 'what you're saying is that most observers who observe universes that appear to be evolved, ordered and low entropy are actually inside spontaneous simulations that have emerged in unevolved, disordered, high entropy universes?'

'It's an idea worth thinking about,' said Zoë. 'What subject did you say you did at university?' I squeezed her hand again. 'We could even both be heads in vats being investigated by our remote descendants trying to understand courtship behaviour in early twenty-first century Britain.'

'Both of us?'

'From when I was a child solipsism has appealed to me,' said Zoë. 'Over the years though I've come to realise that it's too horrible to imagine being the only real person trapped alone in an otherwise empty universe.' Zoë squeezed my hand. 'That could just be an illusion. Like everything else.'

‘I suppose,’ I said, ‘that if you really believed that you were the only real person in an empty universe, if you told your shrink you believed that, if you acted as though you believed that, you’d be declared insane. So it’s a good thing not to believe that. But what if you were the only real person in an empty universe? How would you know for sure?’

‘I don’t think you ever could,’ said Zoë. ‘You might notice features of the universe that seemed to single you out as being unique in certain ways. You might, for instance, notice that the cast of extras started to look familiar after a while, something nobody else claimed to notice.’

‘We could all be one of the extras,’ I said. ‘But you could never know for certain that whoever, or whatever, was controlling simulation didn’t want you to think that the cast of extras was starting to look awfully familiar after a while. They control everything you think.’

‘It depends on the exact nature of the universe,’ said Zoë. ‘If they do control everything you think, where does that leave free will?’

‘The same place free will always get left,’ I said. ‘In the ruins. But I’m not sure how much it matters.’ I rubbed my finger along the back of Zoë’s hand. ‘Would free will make how we feel now feel better?’

‘I don’t think so,’ said Zoë. ‘I’m amazed sometimes by just how little we know, that we don’t even know for sure that we aren’t brains in vats.’

‘That’s true,’ I said, ‘but in what appears to be our universe, we do have a reasonably self-consistent story about how consciousness emerged in the universe. There’s the Big Bang, the universe expands and cools, matter forms, stars and planets form. The laws of chemistry and mathematics are such that self-replicating structures can arise: life. In the struggle for life, some biological organisms eventually evolve the capability to sense information about the environment around them because, under certain circumstances, such information gives them a reproductive advantage. Thus, central nervous system emerges and eventually something like the brain. Many organisms develop mechanisms for communicating with other organisms of their own kind. Thus we have the origins of mind and language. As the complexity of the brain

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and mind increases, so the complexity of the language that the mind can handle increases until a point is reached where the mind is able to use language to make self-referential statements about itself, and, moreover, communicate those statements to other minds in such a way that at least something of the meaning of the statement is transferred.'

'Do you always talk like that?' said Zoë.

'Well, I try to.'

'That's good. You wouldn't believe how many men I have been on dates with who've got firsts from Oxford or Cambridge, but have no interest in ideas at all.'

I looked up into the cloudless blue sky and out into infinite space. 'Ideas are pretty much what keeps me going.'

'I can concur with that,' said Zoë. 'What you have just described is a series of remarkable ideas.'

'For which,' I said, 'there is a great deal of evidence.'

'We cannot be sure that that evidence is reliable.'

'We can't. But it is all we have to go on.'

'Millions of people used to think that the world was created in 4004 BCE,' said Zoë. 'On October the 23rd. At nine o'clock in the morning.'

'Millions of people still do,' I said. 'For Fundamentalist Christians, the universe *is* a put-up job.'

'Astronomical or geologically observations might seem to indicate that the universe might be billions of years old. The reality to them though is that God is testing the faith of believers by making the universe seem to be billions of years old when in fact it is only a few thousand years old.'

'And it's only one step,' I said, 'from believing that God created the universe in six days and just made it seem as though it had evolved slowly over billions of years to believing that we are brains in vats.'

'We have an story where the universe came from,' said Zoë. 'It makes very good sense on certain levels. The Fundamentalists have their own story. The evidence for ours might be better, but perhaps neither

is true and everything we observe — the blue sky, the bright sunshine, the rocking of the boat, the sounds of the birds — everything is an illusion.’

‘It’s not just Fundamentalist Christians who think the universe is a put-up job. Mainline Christians consider the physical realm to be but a pale and inauthentic imitation of the spiritual domain. I’m an atheist and a materialist. I have ideas about what I think is the true realm, but I get vertigo when I realise just how many ways there are that I could be wrong about everything I think I know is real.’

‘I feel that way too,’ said Zoë. ‘If I do have a faith, it’s a faith that the person with whom I have a connection is as real as I am. Kiss me, Alex.’

‘I would like to,’ I said.

‘Then kiss me.’

‘OK,’ I said, ‘I will.’

So, I turned my head and kissed Zoë. It felt good. I realised that whatever it was I felt for her, it was real.

Zoë hoisted the sail back up and tacked slowly back to shore. I trailed my hand in the still water. If there were a God, it would have been a good time to thank him. However, given that I had no need for that hypothesis, I knew that I would have to make do with thanking whoever or whatever it was that controlled the stimuli that my brain received in its vat.

‘What would you like to do now?’ said Zoë when we got back to the dacha. Make mad passionate love to you, I thought. Things were going well. There was no point risking damaging or even destroying the atmosphere that had been created between us during the afternoon. Let that electric charge carry on accumulating over time. That was the best thing to do. Zoë didn’t look to me like the kind of woman who would jump into bed with a virtual stranger at four o’clock in the afternoon. There might well be ample opportunity to discharge the tension later on.

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‘I don’t know.’ It was still early. What did people do on all day dates? What had I done on all day dates in the past? Calm down, Alex, calm down. There are lots of things that we can do. Go for a walk. Have a coffee. Talk. Well, there was no chance that we were going to run out of things to say to one another. Just yet. ‘What would you like to do?’

‘I know what I’d like you to do,’ said Zoë.

‘Oh?’

‘Or, rather, what I’d like you to do.’ Please don’t let it be DIY, I thought. I don’t do DIY.

‘What can I do for you?’

‘It’s not so much “for me” as “to me”.’ said Zoë. ‘I’d like you to make mad, passionate love to me.’

Afterwards, I said, ‘I’ve never really got my head around the idea that women like sex too.’

‘Why’s that?’ said Zoë.

I looked up at the blond wood of the ceiling of the dacha. ‘I was brought up to think that men were sex-obsessed brutes while women were, well... above such base things.’

Zoë laughed, ‘I don’t think so.’

‘A friend of mine once said that women were just men in skirts. But I always knew that the one thing that women weren’t were men in skirts.’

‘That’s true enough,’ said Zoë. ‘It’s a difficult situation.’ She lent up on her elbow. God, she looked good. ‘Men and women do have a great deal in common. You might not think it to look at me now, but when I was an undergraduate, I had short hair, well, only until it grew back because I looked like a boy, and used to wear jeans and t-shirts all the time.’ I had to admit to himself that I preferred Zoë in short skirts and fitted blouses like the ones she had worn at Krakow. I also found it hard to believe that she had ever looked like a boy.

‘So what changed?’

‘Well, firstly, I wasn’t going to get the kind of boyfriend I wanted looking the way I did; secondly, I discovered that shoes and make-up

could be fun; and, thirdly, who was I trying to kid? I'm a 34D and a size 10! I'm not tall, but I'm not elfin-like in build either. I wasn't made for the boyish geek girl look. Something had to give.' I was glad it had given. 'It seems that ambiguity, complexity and uncertainty are intrinsic to this world in which we find ourselves, whether we are concerned with the ontological nature of the universe or with relationships between men and women.'

'I'm OK with complexity,' I said, 'that's my job, modelling the complexity of human behaviour. It's the ambiguity and uncertainty I don't like.'

'I don't like either it,' said Zoë. She flipped her on top of me. 'We have to live with it. Sometimes though, for a few minutes, we can at least put it to the back of our minds.' And she kissed me again.

On the Metropolitan Line train back from Northwood Hills station I considered what to do next. I could send Zoë some flowers. A dozen red roses would be unlikely to go unappreciated — the dacha had been full of dried flowers that Zoë had told me she had bought. But flowers, were, well, a bit of a cliché. I imagined that Zoë had received many bunches over the years from bankers, lawyers and management consultants. A present was good, but it ought to be to be something quirky and idiosyncratic.

I looked out of the window of the train at the peaks of the Northwood Hills glowing in the sunset. It seemed almost too beautiful to be real. That was it! What about her very own brain in a vat? Unlike a dozen red roses, it was highly unlikely that any previous boyfriend had ever given Zoë one of those. I doubted I would be able to buy a model brain in a vat. I would have to make her one myself.

My only previous experience of building something from scratch had been an OO/HO scale model of a ruined chapel for use in World War Two wargames I had made out of white card when I was about 14. I had never thought of myself as handy, but I remembered that the chapel had worked out better than I had expected, so maybe I had missed out on my metier in life.

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As the train hurtled back towards Harrow-on-the-Hill, I had a mental list of the various components I would need. A brain? I could get one of those from the shop at the Natural History Museum. I could get a battery, electrodes, switch and wire from an electronics shop. All I need then was a vat and some simulated pickling liquid.

One of the advantages of living in the most vibrant and exciting city on the planet was that I could buy everything I needed from one shop or another and not to have to rely on the vagaries of mail order. As I was meeting Zoë on Wednesday, I took Tuesday off and sourced all the components I needed. I glued a couple of plastic eyes that I had bought from a medical supplies site to the rubber brain. I found a transparent plastic cylindrical container into which I placed the brain. I poured saline solution into the container and added some yellow food dye to give it the authentic impression of preserving fluid. I managed to make two holes in the container lid and fed an electric lead through each one that I attached to a carbon electrolysis rod, carefully sealing the holes with epoxy resin. I attached another, smaller, cylinder to the bottom of the other. Inside this bottom container was a 9-volt battery and the bulb from torch. The top of the cylinder I covered in red plastic film. The bulb and the electrodes were in parallel so that when the switch (outside both containers) was depressed, the bulb would light up and the electrodes begin to produce copious bubbles. With the brain illuminated from below a satisfyingly eerie effect was produced of a naked brain bathed in bubbles and a red-orange-yellow glow.

I was terrified that the whole contraption was going to leak, so I put it in a cardboard box and stuffed screwed-up newspaper around it in an effort to try and keep it upright. As I sat there on the tube, I hoped that no-one noticed me nervously holding a cardboard box in a carrier bag. By the time, I got it to the restaurant (the Sunny Burger in Garrick Street), my main concern wasn't what Zoë thought of her brain in the vat, but whether there was any electrolyte left in it.

'I brought you a present,' I said. 'I . . . I made it myself.'

'May I open it now?' said Zoë.

‘Yes, yes! Of course. Please.’

Zoë took the box out of the carrier and pulled open the flap. My heart was in my mouth. I hadn’t dared check.

‘Good God, Alex,’ said Zoë as she took the plastic container out of the box. It was still full of coloured liquid. ‘How did you know? It’s just what I’ve always wanted.’

‘Press the button,’ I said. Zoë pressed it and there was a gurgling sound and the model brain was illuminated by an unearthly light.

‘My God, Alex,’ said Zoë. ‘I didn’t realise that you were a hardware engineer as well. It’s marvellous,’ I couldn’t believe it had worked. This wasn’t the kind of thing that happened to me in the real world. I wasn’t quite sure what the other customers in the restaurant were making of it. They were shooting us some peculiar glances. Zoë leant over the table and kissed me. ‘Thank you. It’s the most thoughtful present anyone has ever given me. There’s only one tiny thing that could have been different.’ My felt my heart jitter. ‘If I was going to spend all of eternity as brain in a vat,’ I felt Zoë’s hand on top of mine, ‘I wouldn’t want to spend it on my own.’

CHAPTER TEN

PARALLEL 10101 ↑ 0 ↑ 10

7200 WORDS — MARCH 2026

Dating agencies have a surprising number of things in common with intelligence agencies. Members of both kinds of agency tend not to discuss their activities with their friends over cocktails on a Saturday evening, much less with their parents at lunch the next day. Prospective members are, they say, subject to strict vetting processes of interviews and background checks. Meeting other members of the agency in person involves elaborate methods to preserve anonymity as long as possible including secret voicemail boxes and special means of identifying one another ('I'll be wearing a dark grey suit and carrying a copy of Alistair I.M. Rae's *Quantum Mechanics*, Fourth Edition. The password challenge is "The swifts fly south at this time of year," and the response is "But it is also the season the swans return from Siberia."')

In James Bond novels, the world of intelligence agencies is filled with glamour and excitement, handsome, rugged men in tuxedos and beautiful, sexy women in cocktail dresses. One suspects that the truth about intelligence agencies is much closer to the seedy demi-mondes

described by Len Deighton and John Le Carré. As for dating agencies, well. . . I've been told by several men that I am beautiful, and I have no reason to believe they lied, and I do like to think that I look sexy when I am wearing a cocktail dress, but in my months with Glaukius and Chrysis there has been a sad shortage of glamour, excitement or handsome, rugged men in tuxedos. Had I paid all that money in order to meet men who resembled the anonymous hero of the early Secret Dossier novels than 007? Although to be fair, I could go for a young Michael Caine-lookalike if the all Piers Brosnan ones were busy that week. The hero of those early novels was something of a *bon viveur*. In truth, men like the Bond of the films, much less the Bond of the books would pail – I know from bitter personal experience having encountered more than a few of them in my time – and it would be great if the agency was introducing me to people like Deighton's protagonist. Instead, I had paid over a thousand pounds for the privilege of making awkward conversation in third-rate wine bars with men who resembled Wormwood, the One-Man Bay of Pigs, from Trevanian's *The Eiger Sanction*. If I were to spend my leisure skulking around London, I wanted the man in the Burberry trench under the clock at Waterloo to be some worth meeting.

Thus I found myself one Saturday morning skulking more-or-less through Kensington on my way to do a self-selection at G&C. If there were any good men in their files (the intelligence agency connection again there), I was determined to find them. I turned off High Street into Adams and Eve Mews (which may or may not an auspicious name for the location of a dating agency). Just as if you are a member of an intelligence agency you don't want to seen entering and leaving headquarters, so it is with a dating agency. I looked up and down the mews. No-one was around, much less anyone who looked like James Bond, Harry Palmer or even Vesper Lynd. I scanned the list of names of organisations on the entryphone, sun-bleached almost to illegibility and identified a plausible candidate for G&C. I pressed the buzzer, waited a few long seconds, and was then subjected to a brusque interrogation by one

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of the G&C staff as to my identity and the purpose of visit. My interrogator being satisfied as to my *bona fides* and having determined that there was no other member of the agency going up or coming down on the stairs at that instant (God forbid that security should be compromised or, even worse, that you should bump into someone that you have been on a date with or, worst of all, someone with whom you have had a disastrous relationship), I heard a click as the lock was remotely opened and I could then pull back the heavy silvery metal door. (I had always worried about someone coming up behind me while I was waiting to be let in. This had never happened, which seemed odd to me as couldn't be the only person who turned up to an appointments at the hour on time. Weren't secret agents trained in stealth techniques? There were quite a number of men I had met through G&C over the last few months who I didn't want creeping up on me unawares.)

Having managed to get the door open (those hours down the gym had their uses after all), I ascended the steep staircase, going past the offices of Age Concern Kensington and a mysterious company called Industrial Waste Disposal London. What was it doing in a with offices in fashionable Kensington as opposed to an industrial estate somewhere like, say, Brentford? It was pretty obvious it must be a cover for MI5. On making it to the top landing (and thanking the stars that I hadn't been surprised by an ex hiding the toilet off the staircase), I buzzed again in order to gain admittance to the offices. It took them a while for them to open the door and I imagine they were sanitising the offices, tiding away any confidential papers that might have been lying around and slamming the doors to the interrogation. . . sorry interview rooms, lest a glimpse of the person within compromise security.

Samantha answered the door ushered me into the nerve centre of the agency. It was decorated in a style that had been going out of fashion in the late 1980s, something else, I imagine, it must have in common with intelligence agencies.

'Would you like a drink? Tea? Coffee?' said Samantha as I was whisked into one of the consulting rooms.

‘Do you any infusions?’ I said. ‘A fruit tea?’

‘I think we’ve got some peppermint tea.’ I always ask for fruit tea and they never have any. We are more than half through the first decade of the twenty-first century. How much time, effort and money would it cost them to nip round the corner to the nearest Tesco Metro and buy a box of assorted fruit infusions? I know I’m not the only person who rations herself to one cup of real coffee a week. Absolute attention to detail. That’s the mark of a successful intelligence agency. Couldn’t Samantha see that it was also the mark of a successful dating agency?

‘That’d be great,’ I said. It isn’t that I dislike peppermint tea. I just would have preferred a refreshing cup of raspberry, strawberry and loganberry at that particular moment in time. ‘No biscuits though, please.’ Who was I trying to kid? ‘No, on second thoughts, I will have the biscuits.’ This was the time and place that I ought to be worrying about my figure, but right now, right now, I needed the theobromine hit that a chocolate biscuit could give me more than I needed to worry about a couple of millimetres on my waist.

I looked out of the window over the broken chimney pots and cracked slates of the roofs of London. It was the sort of vista that agents in the old MI5 offices in Gower Street must have had, or, indeed, the view in the MI5 agents at Industrial Waste Disposal London must have.

Well, I had better get on with what I came here to do and I might as well start at the beginning: A–C. I took the appropriate folder off the shelf and opened it at the first profile. For a moment, I was surprised by the fact that ‘TOP SECRET’ wasn’t stamped across the top of the page in large capitals. I glanced at the profile and realised that I couldn’t choose Alan A. He had recently been to see *Aspects of Love*. There were hundreds of other single men in the files. They couldn’t all be Andrew Lloyd Webber fans.

No: reads the *Evening Standard*. No: prefers white wine. No: “My most treasured possession is my Chelsea season ticket.” No: too short. Maybe. . . no: describes himself as a “demi-vegetarian”. No: does Iron-man triathlons. Heavens, no. *Atlas Shrugged*? No: his picture makes

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him look too much like a braying City boy he is. Been on a date with him *and* him. No: the perfect way to spend your day might be with your friends and family, but they're your friends and family, not mine. No: I am not "passionate about action sports of all kinds, but fanatical about paragliding" Good God, no: not with that moustache. Um, perhaps. . . no: a Tory councillor! No: too old. No: too ugly. Oh, no, can't you find a better picture than one of you with your arm around your ex-girlfriend? No: you wish you'd been Oliver Cromwell in another life? You might as well go the whole hog and say Pol Pot. No: nose looks too big and not with that shirt. No: "I'm looking for a woman who can make me laugh." I'm not a bloody stand-up comedian; if you want someone to make you laugh, go to a comedy club. No: Dido, Coldplay. No: the only one of those bands, I've heard of are The Libertines and that tells me everything I need to know about you.

I soon exhausted the S-Zs. I did manage to identify a couple of maybes, men who I couldn't find anything wrong with from a cursory reading of their profiles (one had recently read *Midnight's Children* and another would like to have been Charles Darwin in another life), but, to be honest, nobody I could get excited about. What was it about a man that got me excited? Was I going to find men with those characteristics in the folders of profiles at Glaukius and Chrysis?

It was hard to say. In some ways, Miles had excited me. Take someone with his good bits (tall, dark, handsome, intelligent, witty, successful, good in bed and able to knock up a killer soufflé), but with the bad bits (moody, uncommunicative, self-obsessed, suffered from erectile dysfunction despite not yet been out of his mid-30s, philandering and distinct reluctance to do. . .) replaced by their diametric opposites. I suppose that was what I was looking for and if I found someone like that I would be excited.

I stroked one of the pieces of amber on the necklace that Miles had given me for my birthday last year. I knew I shouldn't wear it anymore, but it seemed too beautiful to just leave abandoned in a drawer and it did complement my eye and hair colour. Perhaps I should ought to

auction it on eBay, but it was the best piece of jewellery that I owned. Whatever could be said about Miles, he had both taste and the pockets to match. Could I hate a man enough to give him back his amber? Was it was reasonable to hope to get over Miles if I was still wearing his jewellery around my neck? When I found a long-term All-Purpose Miles Replacement, I'd get rid of the necklace. (Why would I have to then though?) Carrying on wearing might well be pushing that "when" to the right. What was I to do?

Samantha came back with my peppermint tea and the biscuits. There was even a Choco-Leibniz, which was almost good enough to make me believe that we did live in the best of all possible worlds. That must be why they named the biscuit after him. I bit into it. Well, I wasn't on a date at the moment, was I? What would the British rival, the Choco-Newton, taste like? Given the differences in the personality of the two natural philosophers, bitter and astringent. If only I could find a man with whom I could spend long hours over a bottle of decent Gamay Noir discussing this topic.

'How are you getting on?' said Samantha.

'Well, I've got through the S-Zs,' I replied. 'Still a long way to go.' I took a sip of peppermint tea. It had to admit it did offer a refreshing zing, which was what I was going to need to get through the A-Rs.

She nodded her pretty head of tight blonde curls. 'There's a new guy we'd like you to have a look at.' She took the A-C volume off the shelf. 'Alex Blackwell.' She removed the profile from the folder and handed it to me. 'We all think he's rather lovely.'

I harrumphed. I'm sure you all think he's rather lovely. I looked at her large diamond engagement ring, Bloody smug engaged! You don't have to humiliate yourself in front of the supercilious staff members of dating agency just to get a coffee date. Call me old-fashioned, but I didn't like being hectored into choosing. The men I choose I choose on my terms.

I gave the profile a cursory glance. What reason could I find to tell Samantha as to why guy wasn't for me? Well, no doubt he was another

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sad loser with all the social skills of a whelk. That was a rich coming from me. I might once have appeared in an article in the *Sunday Telegraph Magazine* as one of Britain's Top Ten Young Women Scientists, but that didn't stop me from having to trawl through the profiles of desperate sex-starved professionals in search of a man. Just who was I trying to kid?

Alex didn't look that bad. Open face, a nice smile. Not very tall and I do go for tall. I might not be very tall myself, but that's not the point. Works in computers. Well, better than working in the City or being a solicitor or a bloody barrister. Miles was a barrister and I should have learnt my lesson long before I met him. There was an unfortunate correlation in my extensive dating experience between a man being a lawyer and a man being a self-absorbed bastard. Education: King's College. . . London. No need to read any further. That was enough for me. I'm strictly an Oxbridge woman. I taught at Imperial now and I couldn't imagine dating any of the pimply youths who attended my lectures where they (I hasten to add) to step into a time accelerator and emerge twenty years older. Someone who had been at King's twenty years wasn't any better. I had to draw the line somewhere and that was where I drew it.

'Thanks,' I said, 'I'll have a think about him,' I said.

Fifty minutes later I did have ten selections, but my heart was heavy as I made my weary way home. Profiles flatten people, but I couldn't muster any great enthusiasm for the collection of consultants (management and medical) I had chosen. I had a good jobs, good friends, but I didn't have a good bloke. It didn't look like I was going to find one in this tranche either.

I arrived at my bijou apartment in Arnos Grove (they don't pay physics lecturers anywhere near enough) to discover the familiar form of a G&C envelope lying on the mat when I got home. An electric thrill of excitement went through me. Well, you never do know. . .

Alex Blackwell! Alex bloody Blackwell! Again. God, I felt myself deflate. What a let-down. I had rejected him an hour or two ago earlier

in the G&C office and here he was again. He must have selected my profile when he was in the office. I gave his profile a final perusal. Books: he liked *Gödel, Escher, Bach*. That was one of my favourite books. Food and drink: he loved a lamb rogan josh, peas pilau, mushroom bhaji and keema naan. So did I. Favourite things: second-hand bookshopping and talking pseudo-philosophical gibberish over a stiff G&T. Just like me. In another life: Lord Kelvin. Well, it was different. I hadn't come across anyone who'd put that down before. If he'd gone to a proper university, maybe, but he hadn't: no.

Like any good intelligence agency, G&C had strict rules about the handling of sensitive documents. They are provided on a purely need-to-know For Your Eyes Only and must be destroyed as soon as soon as the information has been assimilated lest they fall into the wrong hands.

I went into my study, turned on the shredder and fed the profile and photograph into it.

Time passed. I did get four calls in response to my profile. A 40% hit rate. What the hell was wrong with all these wusses? Weren't men supposed to go on the photograph? There was nothing wrong with *my* photograph. It wasn't a studio shot and it didn't feature children or animals, or involve me doing anything whacky. Not that many men were put off by the fact that I was a redhead. If it wasn't my photograph, it must be the rest of my profile. So much for 'The Thinking Person's Introduction Agency'. It would seem most of the male members of the agency just couldn't cope with the idea of going on a date with a successful intellectual woman? I wasn't going to dumb down my profile. I'd rather be single for the rest of my life than pretend to be someone and something that I wasn't.

As for the four men who could cope with the idea of dating me, it would be churlish to wish they hadn't bothered responding to my profile, but none of them in the flesh came even close to satisfying my basic requirements. There was a management consultant who would have been more promising if he hadn't showed just been assigned to a project in Jakarta for the next six months and had seemed a bit less enthusiastic

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about leaving for the other side of the world from me in the morning. There was the consultant cardiologist who, despite my constant efforts to change the topic of conversation, spent our (shortened) date betraying the medical confidentialities of his celebrity patients. Discretion ought to be one of the prime characteristics of a member of the agency. There was the neurosurgeon who could have given Miles a run for his money in the arrogance stakes had revealed that he had taken a somewhat fluid attitude towards truth in his interview with G&C in terms of trimming seven years off his age ('Five years seemed hardly worth the bother, but ten seemed to be going a bit too far') and not mentioning the wife and children at home ('We have a completely open marriage'). The ex-surgeon-commander in the Navy, who said almost nothing for the entire evening until right at the end when he told me that reminded him of his ex-fiancée. I didn't bother to enquire whether he thought that was good or bad.

Where had all the good men gone? It had never used to be like this. For fifteen years, I hadn't had much trouble finding a boyfriend who at least matched most of my criteria. Keeping a boyfriend for more than a year or two, that was another story, but from the age of sixteen, when I started dating various of my brother's and cousins' friends until my early thirties, I had been able to meet intelligent and attractive men who wanted to go with me and who I wanted to go with. I'm a mathematical physicist. There had also always been plenty of men hanging around who wanted to pick me up, but who I didn't want to be picked up by.

Why didn't men try to pick me in bars any more? Miles had picked me up in a bar. That had been two years ago. Was there that much difference between being 32 and 34? Could men somehow sense my desperation? I wasn't desperate. For God's sake, if 40 was the New 25, then 34 must be the New 19 (I might be a mathematician, but that doesn't mean I can't do mental arithmetic). I didn't feel desperate. I wasn't even sure whether or not I wanted children. Two years ago, before I met Miles, I had almost never thought about them. When I was going out with him, I thought of them in the context of how Miles wouldn't

make a good father. I didn't even want to live with Miles, much less get married and have his children. There are though all those hormones slopping around my body and almost every month, I get an invitation to a wedding or a baptism or a naming ceremony. What is the world trying to tell me?

It's not even as though baptism and naming ceremonies are good events to get picked up at. Weddings used to be great for that, but the problem these days is that even though I am going to so many, all the men at them are either married already or are on the next line to get hitched. All the good single men seem to have vanished (no doubt pursuing younger, less desperate women) leaving a rump who are either sad or bad.

It's a change so subtle that you just don't notice it until it's far, far, far too late. 32 and single is a different matter from being 34 and single. Without realising it, I've discovered that I am on the wrong side of the tracks — with no way of getting back again.

The guy you go with when you're 32 has to be the One. I wasted a year on Miles when I knew from that first evening in the bar that he wasn't the One. Now I'm compounding the waste of time by thinking about why he wasn't the One. It wasn't as though I could have done anything about him. Miles wasn't the changing sort, but that doesn't change the fact that he was my last boyfriend and everyday the fear that he will prove to be my Last Boyfriend grows just that little bit larger. Hell, I am still a sexy, intelligent woman. I don't feel desperate. I know that could feel desperate in the future though. Not tomorrow, not next week, but the year after next? Yes. That knowledge was producing subtle and subconscious changes in my behaviour. I was spending out signals of incipient desperation while at the same time all the good men were already drawing up their wedding lists at John Lewis. Not the ideal way to maximise the odds of success.

Joining G&C had been a way of trying to skew the odds back in my favour. Of course, I had been reluctant to sign up — the idea that I ended up as the kind of lonely, pathetic individual forced to pay for

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dates was too depressing to contemplate — but Nicola had persuaded me by pointing out that I would feel better for getting back to dating on a routine basis and that the substantial fee the agency charged would serve as a entry barrier to the most egregious elements of the sad and the bad. Well, I had got back to dating on a routine basis, but I wasn't sure that I could say that I felt better for it and the fee didn't seem to have proven a sufficient barrier to enough of the sad and the bad. Given the contents of my goody drawer, how much did I need a man? Not enough to compromise my principles. One thing I did know was that I knew that I didn't not want to have children. Perhaps I should just kick G&C in to touch and start wearing thicker make-up and hanging around in darker bars. A vibrator might never make you sleep in the wet patch, but it wasn't going to buy you an amber necklace for your birthday.

These were the issues I contemplated as I walked home from the tube one evening. I hoped the door to find the familiar form of a letter from G&C on my doormat. Oh good, looks like someone has sent me his profile. Well, you never know. I slit open the letter and discovered to my disappointment that it wasn't a profile, but a telephone introduction. I harrumphed. Telephone introductions were the feature of G&C that I cared for least. At least with the profiles, you had a degree of control over who you ended up going on a date with, but with a telephone introduction all you got was the name and number of some bloke and the instruction to "call your prospective date as soon as you can to discuss the possibility of meeting up." Like hell I was going to, I thought, as I fed the letter into my shredder. This Alex, whose number I had been send, could be bloody anyone. Which was why I never asked for telephone introductions. The problem was that some blokes did ask for them with the consequence for me that though I might never ask for them myself, I received them. Though I might ignore them, the chances were that the bloke, who had after all asked for the introduction and been send my name and number, wasn't going to ignore it.

I had contemplated asking G&C if I could be excluded from the telephone introduction scheme, but I feared the consequences if I did so. It was the same fear of the consequences that prevented me from acting in the passive-aggressive way that I normally would have done. I could just let the call from my prospective date go to the answerphone and then ignore it. The problem with doing that though is that if I didn't get back to him, he might complain about me to G&C. As in an intelligence agency, it was not beneficial to be marked out as unreliable.

Of course, there was the chance that he might not ring. He could have met someone at the weekend or have gone on holiday and then be too embarrassed to ring when he got back a fortnight later. Yes, there was always that chance.

My phone rang later that night. A mobile number, but not one that was in my contacts. It could be anyone or it could be this Alex from G&C. In which case, he'd leave an answerphone message. Then if I didn't reply, he'd ring again and leave another message. If I continued not answering his answerphone messages, I would end up getting hauled before Samantha or, even worse, M herself.

'Hi, can I speak to Zoë, please?'

'Uh. . . speaking,' I said.

'Oh, hi, this is Alex, Alex Blackwell. From G&C. I got send your number.'

'Uh. . . yeah. . .'

'Is this a good time to talk? I mean if it's not, I can ring back latter.'

I could have said that it was a bad time. I could have said I was going away on a workshop for a few weeks and that I'd get back to him when I returned: "Oh dear, I've mislaid his number. How careless of me." I could have said "I don't do this kind of blind date stuff, I know it's part of the G&C thing, but it's just not me. I hope you understand." I could have said any of those things. I don't know why I didn't. Other than the fact that it's a great deal harder to brush people off in practice than it is theory.

'Uh. . . yeah. . . I. . . I suppose now is a good time.'

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We were committed now to having a conversation. The worst part of it though was that we were committed to having a flirtatious conversation that would end with us arranging a date. I didn't even know what this guy looked like.

There was a long silence. If I waited long enough he'd say something.

'What's your favourite book?' I wasn't quite expecting that one. At least in my experience of these things, people tend to ask what you do or where you live. I'd joined G&C because I wanted to be asked questions like that. Not that it had happened.

'That's a good question,' I said. Which it was. There were many books that I had enjoyed or been influenced by. A favourite? What would be my desert island book? I knew the answer to that.

'*Gödel, Escher, Bach: an Eternal Golden Braid* by Douglas R. Hofstadter,'

'Wow! That's amazing,' he said. 'I thought Hofstadter gave such a clear of Gödel's theorem. The best thing that I've read on it. I even understood it. Well, almost. I mean all the other stuff about artificial intelligence was pretty cool too.'

'Yes,' I said, 'it was.' I felt a strange itch at the back of my mind. 'Have you read any Dennett?'

'Of course,' he replied, 'although I thought that *Consciousness Explained* would have been better titled *Some Pointers to Possible Explanations of Certain Aspects of Consciousness*.'

In spite of my better judgement, I was starting to get interested. Someone who was a Hofstadter and Dennett fan must have something going for him. I have my standards. Firstly, what did this guy look like? I couldn't say to him "I might be interested in going on a date with you, but can you send me a photograph first just so that I can determine whether your level of physical attractiveness is commensurate with mine."

Secondly, what does he do (some professions are just sexier than others — all things being equal, I rather go out with an architect than

an estate agent, sorry, chartered surveyor, and thirdly, and in some ways which university did he go to (you know my feelings on this issue)?

‘What do you do?’ I blurted out. Not the subtlest approach, I admit that in ideal circumstances I would have worked the conversation around until he revealed what he did without me having to ask him straight out. I’m a mathematical physicist. For God’s sake, conversational skills are not part of the job specification. If they were, some stranger wouldn’t be attempting to chat me up on the phone.

‘I’m a programmer.’ A programmer? Well, that could be all right. I did quite a lot of programming. It was better than being, say, a management consultant. He was some kind of geek, but some of my best friends were geeks. Hell, I might not look much like a geek these days, but that didn’t mean that underneath I wasn’t one.

Before he had the chance to ask me what I did and I cut straight to the chase: ‘Which university did you go to?’

Of course, the answer I was dreading was that he would say that he hadn’t been to university at all. The University of Life just doesn’t cut it with me.

‘King’s College,’ said Alex.

‘Wow,’ I said ‘I went to King’s College.’ What an amazing coincidence. Perhaps not that amazing a coincidence given the circumstances under which we had met, but the real coincidence was that Miles had also gone to King’s. It had been one of the factors in my attraction to him. Of course, given how matters had turned out between us, the fact that Alex went to King’s might not be a positive omen. ‘What subject did you do?’

‘Chemistry and computing.’ He must have done his BA in chemistry and then done an MSc in computer science. ‘What did you do?’

‘Maths,’ I said, ‘but then I did a PhD at DAMTP and I’m a physics lecturer at Imperial now, so I don’t think of myself as a mathematician these days.’

‘Ah, DAMTP.’ A fan of Hofstadter and Dennett who knew what DAMTP was. ‘Was Hawking your supervisor?’

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‘Thank God, no!’

‘What do you think of John Taylor?’

‘He’s quite a character. Not as barking as Brian Josephson or even Bernard Carr at Queen Mary. I didn’t really know him. He works on neural nets these days; not my area.’

‘Wasn’t he head of department though?’ said Alex.

‘At King’s College London? Yes, but he’d retired from that by the time I was a postdoc there for a year in 1999-2000. I think I’ve only spoken to him a couple of times.’

‘Didn’t you come across him when you were an undergraduate though?’

‘Why would I do that?’ I said. ‘I was an undergraduate at Cambridge.’

‘Ah,’ said Alex.

‘Ah. You were an undergraduate at King’s College London?’

‘Yes,’ said Alex, ‘yes, I was.’

King’s College, London? I felt an itch at the back of mind. There was something familiar about this guy. Of course! He was the bloke that bloody Samantha had tried to palm off on me, the same guy whose profile I had shredded. I had already made up my mind about him long ago and there was no reason to change my mind now. The question now was what to do. I couldn’t after all tell him to his face that I didn’t want to go on a date with him because he didn’t go to Oxbridge.

‘Did you send me your profile a few weeks ago?’ I said.

‘I don’t know,’ said Alex. ‘I can’t remember. I might have done.’ I wanted to say “You must be able to remember. How can you have forgotten something like that? It was only a few weeks ago.” I couldn’t. I harrumphed. This was all bloody G&C’s fault. Didn’t they keep records of who had sent profiles to whom? It was the least they could do to avoid this kind of unnecessary embarrassment. They would be getting a stern email of complaint. As soon as I could find my way out of this mess.

Even with a King's College London education, Alex must be able to deduce that if he had sent his profile to me and hadn't heard anything it was because I wasn't interested in going on a date with him. It was a pretty bloody huge hint. This conversation had reached its conclusion.

'What about food?' said Alex.

'Sorry? What about food?'

'What kind of food do you like?'

Look, Buster, I thought, our discussion has reached its conclusion. Goodbye and if I ever hear from you again I'll slap an injunction on so fast, they'll have to take into account the relativistic effects. My nice, middle class upbringing didn't allow me to be that direct.

'All sorts. Traditional British, modern British, French, Indian. Alex, look, the thing is. . . '

'Curry?' said Alex. 'Yes, I'm a big fan of curry too. A decent lamb rogan josh with peas pilau, a mushroom bhaji and a keema naan. It's hard to beat that.'

I have to admit it was hard to beat that. Alex had just described my favourite Indian meal. This guy likes the same food and books as I do and I hadn't rejected his profile on the grounds of his photograph, so he wasn't ugly. It was just that he had gone to the wrong King's College. A King's College I had actually been a researcher at for a year as I finished my PhD. OK, it wasn't Stanford or CERN or Imperial. Then again, I had some undergraduate teaching when I was there. It wasn't King's College Cambridge either.

'Would you like to go for a curry sometime?' said Alex. 'It's just that I find it's a lot easier to get to know someone face-to-face.'

I've been on dates with men who didn't go to Oxbridge. I've even had relationships with men who didn't go to Oxbridge. They didn't work out. The ones with men who had gone to Oxbridge, like Miles, hadn't worked out either. My ideal man had gone to Oxford or Cambridge and, like Miles, had got a first. The brain is the largest sex organ. My head has always ruled my heart. My loins too. I knew the kind of guy who had a chance of turning me on. Was it fair to go on a date with

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Alex when there was no chance of anything happening? He'd been on as many cynical dates as I had. Didn't we at least have enough honesty not to condemn ourselves to yet another one of those?

'What about the Punjab in Neal Street? Do you know it?'

I did know it. It was one of my favourite Indians. Oh, what the hell. It was only date, not a proposal of perpetual union. Poppadoms, we could order within ten minutes, no starters, mains on the table within another fifteen-twenty minutes, twenty minutes to eat the food, five minutes to pay the bill. It could all be over inside an hour. At least we'd have Hofstadter and Dennett to talk about.

'That sounds good.' I said. Perhaps "good" wasn't the word. 'What about next Tuesday? Half-seven?'

'Er, yeah, that works for me,' said Alex.

'Good,' I said. 'I shall. . . look forward to it.' It couldn't be that bad, could it?

It turned out that it wasn't that bad. It turned out that it wasn't bad at all. In fact, it turned out rather good. Very good, in fact. Three orgasms good. Which, in my book, for first date, on a school night, is pretty damned good.

It's not as though having sex on first date is a habit of mine. Going on dates with men who are as interested as I am in Bach, the multi-worlds interpretation of quantum reality and the Shakespeare authorship question (Alex is a strict, orthodox Stratfordian, which is a blessed relief after Miles and his lawyerly Oxfordianism) isn't a habit of mine either. It helped that Alex turned out to be cute in a bookish sort of way. Not as good-looking in a classical way as Miles, but he had at least made an effort by, for instance, having his haircut over the weekend and wearing a Paul Smith suit even though he worked in IT..

I got to go on top, which helps explain two of the orgasms. The middle one is explained by Alex going down on me. You've got to love that from a bloke the first time. Unlike Miles, he also hadn't show any sign of being intimidated by a woman in the female superior position.

So I thought the next morning as I walked down the tunnel from South Kensington tube station to Imperial College. All in all, a most satisfactory evening. It was far too early to start getting overexcited about things, but I had to admit that my insides hadn't felt like this since, well, since I was about nineteen.

Anyway, I had a hot date with Alex on Friday evening in West London, which would mean that we would well positioned for a visit to his flat to inspect his book collection and whatever else two consenting adults might do to pass an evening or a weekend.

I felt like making an extravagant romantic gesture. Maybe not that extravagant, not on my salary. On our third date, Miles had whisked me off on the Eurostar. To Calais, because he wanted to buy some wine as it turned out, although I did once go out with Alistair, an MD at an investment bank, who borrowed his boss's private jet in order to take me to Venice for the Valentine's Day weekend. Which might have been more fun if his sole topic of conversation hadn't been rupee futures and he hadn't turned out to be a premature ejaculator. Well, at least Alex had other topics of conversation than rupee futures and wasn't a premature ejaculator. Even if as a software project manager, he wouldn't be whisking me off on as many European weekend mini-breaks as I might like. What mattered was how romantic the gesture was. If my life had turned into a romantic comedy, I might as well act as though it had.

Anyway, whisking Alex off somewhere exotic and romantic was not an option during term-time even if my lecturer's salary had been able to stretch to it. A book would be perfect, but although the previous evening I had gleaned a good idea of the many areas in which he was interested, I didn't know what books he already owned (a great many it seems). Flowers were a possibility. This is the twenty-first century and Alex had given me his card, so I knew where he worked, but something less ephemeral appealed to me. I didn't want decaying flowers to become a metaphor for our relationship.

Alex had confessed to being a geek. That wasn't a problem with me: I was a physics lecturer, but in terms of a the right gift, lifestyles shift

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and my finger was no longer on the geek pulse as it had been fifteen years ago.

Well, people's lifestyles shift over the years. Brendan. I had dated him at Cambridge. That was a long time ago. Not everyone's lifestyle shifts as much as others. Brendan still had his figure on the geek pulse. He also happened to work in the Computer Science department at Imperial. I could nip over and see him.

I rang Brendan about six. I reckoned he should just about have got in for the day by then. I soon found myself in his office at the end of a long, dingy corridor in the basement of the CS building. He was preparing his evening ebullition.

'Just smell that aroma, Zoë,' said Brendan. 'Australian Skybury. Exceptionally high in caffeine, but still a surprisingly subtle blend of Arabica and Robusta. Truly marvellous. Would you care for a cup?'

As a rule, I only drink coffee after dinner and I would have been declined the offer if I had known that he was going to serve it to me in a cracked, tannin-stained mug. "Happy Birthday", read the slogan it, "The Java 5-Year Birthday Celebration". I looked at Brendan. He was wearing an old t-shirt. It] looked like it had last been washed about the same time as the mug and on it was inscribed the single glyph "<geek>". Did I once go out with his guy? At least, we never had sex otherwise I would still be in therapy. This was the man to ask about nerd presents.

'Brendan,' I said, 'I'd like some advice. About a present.'

'A present? For a man or woman? Young or old? Rich or poor? Friend or relative? Do you want something flamboyant or restrained? Practical or impractical? For a birthday, anniversary or Christmas? Graduation or going away?'

'Well... for a... a friend,' I said, 'a man... Nothing extravagant. Just a small token of affection. The thing is, Brendan, he's a software engineer, a bit of, well, a geek...'

'What kind of geek? A physics geek, a maths geek, a chemistry geek, a computer geek? If he's a computer geek, is he a Unix geek, a Java geek,' I looked at my mug again; Alex had told me he was a C++ programmer,

‘a Perl geek, a T_EXgeek? What are his interests? Does he like science fiction? Media sf? Or does he only like real sf? Zoë, you’ve got to know your geek.’

I noticed that there was a camp bed in the corner. It looked like Brendan was sleeping down here these days. Brendan wasn’t the kind of guy I could imagine suggesting a double date to. Besides Nicola knew him from Cambridge.

‘I know he’s interested in godgames.’ Alex had mentioned last night that he worked on Monte Carlo simulations for predicting take-up of new products. He had also confessed that the years 1991 to 1993 were a complete blank to him as he had spent almost the entire period playing *Civilization*. ‘It seemed to me,’ he had said, ‘that I went into my bedroom one evening and came out of it two years later. I did get to win at Emperor level though.’

‘Godgames, eh?’ said Brendan. ‘I know exactly the thing. It’s better than inexpensive. It’s free.’ He went over to his computer and ejected a CD-ROM. ‘This is the real thing.’ He handed me a disc. The words “The Oracle” were scrawled across it in yellow felt-tip. I presumed that it had nothing to do with Larry Ellison and relational databases. ‘A friend of mine, Josh Josephson, over at the MIT Media Lab wrote it. Best godgame I’ve ever played. Tell you truth,’ he nodded towards the camp bed, ‘I have hardly been able to stop playing it since I got it.’

‘Thanks,’ I said. ‘What sort of godgame, is it?’

‘Do you know *The Sims* and *Grand Theft Auto*?’

I shook my head. ‘No.’ I didn’t have time for computer games. I had papers about the ultimate fate of the universe to write.

‘Well, it’s a tiny bit like a cross between them, set in an alternative London. Except without quite as much violence. My friend created the game to help him come to terms with his nostalgia for London. Only he thought that the real London was too mundane, so each time you play the game it creates a unique new version of the city. Most times, I’ve played it doesn’t seem to rain as much, although occasionally you do get flooded London scenarios. Which are rather fun.’

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‘Very J.G. Ballard,’ I said. ‘I’ll copy this and get it back to you. Alex should like it.’ It’s never easy to have an ex discussing her current boyfriend with you if your ex has moved on a lot further than you have. ‘Quirky, offbeat and inexpensive. Thanks, Brendan. I appreciate this.’ I drained as much of the remaining coffee as I could. ‘Well, I had better be off.’ I touched Brendan’s arm. To think that I had once snogged him. ‘See you soon.’

I went back to my office, copied the CD-ROM and printed out a proper label for the CD itself and a jewel case. No felt tip for Alex. When I got home I wrapped it up in some rocket and alien-themed wrapping paper.

‘I . . . I got you something.’ We were on Friday date, in the middle of the main course at the Anglesea Arms in Brackenbury Village.

‘Oh, my word! I wasn’t expecting this. What can it possibly be?’ Alex ripped into the wrapping paper. ‘The Oracle? Can it really be. Wow!’ It distracted him from the venison he had been enjoying.

‘You’ve heard of it?’ I took a sip of Gamay Noir.

‘Heard of it? The game’s a legend, even though it has never been officially released. There are entire corners of the noosphere dedicated to discussing it. It’s practically impossible to get hold of. Where on Earth did you get a copy?’

‘A friend of mine gave it to me. Brendan Ford.’

‘You know Brendan Ford? *The* Brendan Ford?’

‘Uh, yeah. I met him at Cambridge.’ This wasn’t the time to admit that I had even dated him.

‘That’s so cool. I mean he’s the absolute god in my field.’ I had always thought that Brendon was just some random posdtoc. I’m barely worthy to undo his sandal straps. I use the development toolkit he wrote everyday at work.’

Brendan an absolute god? I ought to pay more attention to the professional activities of my friends.

‘I can hardly wait to get home and start playing it,’ said Alex. I felt myself frown.

PAUL M. CRAY

He lent over the table and kissed me on the mouth. 'But there are other things I want to do first when I get back tonight.'

I lent over the table and kissed him back. Yes, there were other things I wanted to do with my geek tonight that didn't involve computers in anyway whatsoever.

CHAPTER TEN

PARALLEL 11111 ↑ 1 ↑ 11

8900 WORDS — MARCH 2026

She certainly *looked* promising. Well, more promising than my last date, FoxyLady, who had told me that her favourite television programme was *Footballers' Wives*, but not, I feared, in an ironic and knowing way. I had spent the interval mulling over that statement and a glass of distinctly rough Gamay Noir. Neither had done much to improve my mood.

‘Hi, she said. ‘I’m Zodiac.’

‘Hi,’ I said. I thought it best not to mention my username. Unfortunately, when I picked up my badge, I had discovered that length of the username printed on the badge was limited to 25 characters.

But what the hell else was I going to say to her? Zodiac was date number 31 of the night and there were still another eight more to go after her. Forty women in one night for me to try and say something witty and original to and three minutes in which to say it. Trying to find something witty and original was hardly easy at the best of times. And a speed dating event with forty different women and the stress of

trying to find something witty and original to say to each one was definitely not the best of times. Nine dates. That was 27 minutes. Add a ten percent overhead for changeovers and it would all be over in just about 30 minutes. So try to not let the atmosphere of general desperation that pervaded the room get you down. Not too much, anyway. You're on the last lap now, Alex. There must be something left in the tank. Humhdots... I took a sip of wine.

'What's your favourite book?' Oh God! Where had I dredged that one up from? I should have learn my lesson by now. Being quirky got me nowhere with women. And anything to do with books counted as quirky. There might be a lot of attractive women in Borders on a Saturday afternoon, but they didn't go to midweek speed dating events. Most people didn't read books at all, much less have a favourite book. And a favourite book was the kind of things that you had when you were fifteen. So if, by some statistical fluke, she was a reader, she would probably think I was some kind of juvenile retard for asking that question. Chat-up lines have never been my strongest point. For heaven's sake, if they were, I wouldn't find myself in some dingy nightclub in some obscure part of East London on a rainy Wednesday evening drinking over-priced Canadian plonk too quickly.

'*Gödel, Escher, Bach: an Eternal Golden Braid* by Douglas R. Hofstadter,' she said immediately.

'Wow!' I said. Wow! I thought to myself. 'That's pretty amazing.' Which it was. '*GEB* is one of my favourite books. I've read all of Hofstadter's books. *Metamagical Themas*, *Fluid Concepts and Creative Analogies*.' I realised that right now was probably not the time to tell Zodiac that I had been forced to leave my copy of *Le Tön Beau de Marot* at Margaret's, my ex, when we had split up. I still mourned that book.

'Have you read any Dennett?' she said.

'Of course,' I said. I could hardly believe my luck. A woman who not only liked books, but liked the same books that I did. '*Darwin's Dangerous Idea* Brilliant. *Consciousness Explained*. Superb. Although I

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thought a better title would have been *Some Pointers to Possible Explanations of Certain Aspects of Consciousness.*'

She smiled and I saw that she had lots and lots of very white, very even teeth. What a miracle modern dentistry was. I wondered if she had them cosmetically whitened. Whether or not she did, I liked her smiling at me. 'That's very true,' she said.

Flipping heck. I took a large gulp of wine and as long a look at Zodiac as I dared. Black plastic-framed glasses, short-ish skirt, tights, lots of red hair, more curves than a scenic railway. Flipping heck indeed. I've always had a thing about women in glasses. And with red hair. It's not Freudian, not really. Honestly I swear. Personally, I blame it on Gillian Anderson. And Lea Thompson. Thank God for Paramount Comedy Channel and the re-runs of *Caroline in the City*. And Rose McGowan during those two seasons of *Charmed* when she dyed her hair red. And Rosie Millard, former arts correspondent of the BBC. And Miranda off *Sex and the City*. OK, OK, I'll stop now.

'Red wine or white?' said Zodiac.

'Red,' I said.

'Still or sparkling water?' she asked.

'Still,' I said. Was that the right answer? I hoped she wouldn't think I was flat.

'Starter or pudding?'

'Well,' I said, 'that depends what's for pudding.'

'Right answer,' said Zodiac. At least I had got one question right.

The bell rang to indicate the end of our allotted three minutes.

'See you soon,' I said as I got up to move over to my next date. I hope, I thought. Zodiac was definitely going to be ticked by me tonight. But would she tick me?

I sat down.

'Hi, I'm Heidi,' she said.

'Hi, I'm. . . ' Heidi? 'I'm Alex.'

I forced myself to look at her. My eyes wanted to look at Zodiac. I couldn't allow them to do. But out of the corner of my eye, I could see

just about make out her and the bloke she was talking to. She appeared to be laughing. Bastard. Did she laugh at my jokes? Did I make any jokes? Why didn't I make any jokes? Woman are supposed to like men who make them laugh.

'Hello, Alex,' said Heidi. 'Hello? Earth to Alex.'

'What? Oh, sorry, sorry. Er. . . yeah, yeah.'

'What do you do, Alex?'

'Do?' Oh, what the hell does it matter what I do? 'Computers.' I couldn't help myself. I quickly turned my head through forty-five degrees and back again. Yep, Zodiac was still laughing. At least, she was having a good time. 'What's your favourite book?'

'Er. . . well, I don't get as much time as I would like to read. I only really get the chance when I'm on holiday. But I really enjoyed Harry Potter. I read the latest one in Spain this year and I'm really looking forward to the next one.'

'Harry Potter?' I said. Harry Potter! I thought. Harry Potter. You're an ostensibly literate adult woman and the best book you can come with is Harry bloody Potter. Jesus Christ, it's a series of books about a boy wizard at a boarding school and not even a particularly good or original series. If you want to read a good book about a wizard at boarding school, you should read Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea*. I glanced over again towards Zodiac. She was still laughing. I bet she's read *A Wizard of Earthsea*. And I bet the bastard she's talking to hasn't.

'Yes, Harry Potter,' said Heidi. 'Have you read them?'

'I read the first couple,' I said.

'Oh, you must read the others.' No, I thought, no, I mustn't. Well, that line of questioning had provided the answers I was looking for. Try another one.

'Red wine or white?' I said.

'Sorry?'

'Do you prefer red wine or white wine?'

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‘I suppose I’m more of a white wine person really. I don’t mind a nice glass of Chardonnay every now and then. And I liked the white Rioja we had in Spain in the summer. But I’m not really that big a drinker.’ I looked at the drink on the table in front of her. It was clear and sparkling and in a tall glass. Probably not a G&T then and there was no point asking whether she had preferred still or sparkling. ‘I see you’re a bit of a red man,’ she said pointing at my glass.

‘Yes,’ I said, ‘yes, I am,’ I drained the glass. I smiled at her out of sheer desperation. What could I ask her? What she did? I hate asking that question. And there was no point asking her where she went on holiday. I already knew that.

‘What kinds of food do you like?’ My God, had it come to that one?

‘Well, I don’t really eat a lot of red meat. And I like fish. And Thai. I really like Thai. I’d say that’s my favourite. And what do you like?’

‘German,’ I said. ‘There just aren’t enough good German restaurants in London, don’t you think? I mean just where can you get a decent currywurst here? Or even *Krustenbraten mit Kartoffelknödel und Blaukraut*?’ The bell sounded. I almost leaped out of my seat. ‘Well, it was great to meet you.’

My next ‘date’ was round a corner. I took one last glance at Zodiac. It was probably best that I wouldn’t be able to see her any more. Far, far too distracting.

I smiled at and made polite conversation with eight more women, but I can’t say my mind was really on any of the eight woman. It was on Zodiac.

The end came eventually. I smiled at Heatseeker, wished her well with her plan to open a dog grooming parlour, stood up and looked around the room. I spotted Zodiac in the middle of the room. After the main event, there was an opportunity to spend some time casually mingling with one’s fellow speed-daters, but one of the things about these events is that the women tend to buzz off fairly sharpish after the end of the main event, so the opportunity was more theoretical than actual. I could try and buttonhole Zodiac now for a chat, but it was

more likely that I would have to stand idly by while she was button-holed by some braying City boy. I'd ticked her and if she had ticked me then we would have the chance to take things further electronically. I usually find that I am one of the group of sad, pathetic men left hanging around the bar after all of the women have left, bemoaning the perceived lack of interesting females to one another and ending up getting far drunker than is sensible on a school night, especially when you have to get to West London from the City. I knew that there was at least one *very* interesting female here tonight and I wanted to preserve the illusion that I might have a chance with her as long as I could. Zodiac was an attractive woman and I was surely not the only man to have noticed her. I certainly didn't want my mental image of her perfection to be besmirched by having to stand at the bar and listen at the bar to the fetid fantasies of some odious bottled lager-swilling twerp in an ill-fitting suit.

I took a last look around the bar. Zodiac was still there talking to one of the organisers. Good. No chance of bumping into her on the way out. I dropped my tick list into the box, got my overcoat from the cloakroom and headed into the dank dark of the London night.

Friday morning I was working at home when I got an email from the organisers of the speed dating event.

```
Congratulations! Seeker
_of
_truth
_and
_penit, You have 1 (one) match
from our recent speed dating
event.
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ELEVEN SHORT STORIES ABOUT LOVE

Just one match! Bloody hell, that had been pretty much a complete waste of \$23.95 then. I must have ticked at least twenty-five women, all the woman I could bring myself to imagine possibly going on a date with and I had still only got one match. It was a good job I hadn't been any fussier. I might have got no matches at all. I looked further down the email.

Your matches are:

Zodiac

You can contact your match
through our website.

Normally a badge name from a drunken evening a few nights ago would have meant little if anything to me. But Zodiac wasn't a normal badge name. There was no need to strain my memory cells for a dim recollection of what she had said, what she liked, much less what she looked like. Those things had been permanently burned into my cerebral cortex on the night of the dating event.

Bloody brilliant. It hadn't been a complete waste of an evening after all! Well, it wouldn't be if I could convert the match into a date. Should I send her a message straight away? If I had been in the office it wouldn't have been an option. But as I was at home, there was no risk of triggering the company's surf control system by trying to access a non-work-related site. It might seem overeager if I responded so quickly. But then was it likely that she checked her personal emails as often as I did? In which case she might not realise how fast I had replied.

I clicked on the link to the messaging section of the speed dating website.

Zodiac,

PAUL M. CRAY

great to meet you last
Wednesday. Reading anything good
at the moment? I'm reading
Michael Frayn's "Sweet Dreams".

Alex

(PS: my real email address is
a.g.blackwell@gmail.com)

Short and fairly phatic. Nothing there to cause offense, surely. I could say more, but I don't know this woman so she's hardly going to want to read my random witterings. And I've asked her a question. OK, it's a closed question. But one of the most interesting and revealing questions you can ask a person. And by answering the question, out of politeness, she'll have to ask me a question. Thus starting a conversation. Which is exactly what I want with Zodiac.

I pressed

SEND.

Sending a dating message is always a matter more of hope than expectation. As often as not, I don't get a reply. Perhaps Zodiac will have met someone in the nights since the event (quite likely if you look like her). Or she might simply have no recollection of me now or she might have woken up on Wednesday morning with a roaring hangover unable to remember what could possibly have possessed her to tick the geeky bloke the night before. Or perhaps she had simply put the tick in the wrong box and hadn't meant to match me at all. It had happened to me before.

A few minutes later, I returned to my desk with a cup of raspberry, strawberry and loganberry infusion to discover that I had an email from Heriot-Shaw, Zoë. Did I know anyone called Zoë Heriot-Shaw? Bloody spam filter must be playing up again. As I moved my mouse to the message to delete it, I noticed the subject:

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Towards the End of Morning. It was the name of Michael Frayn's Fleet Street novel. But which unknown person might be sending me emails with the title of a Michael Frayn novel as the subject? Zoë Heriot-Shaw? Bloody hell! Could it be? Zodiac? But she would have to have replied to my message virtually by return. Which could mean that she was keen, possibly even dangerously keen. Or more likely it could mean that she wasn't messing around and was going straight to the brush-off.

But she had emailed my personal account, not just replied to the message via the speed dating site. And she had used the title of a Michael Frayn novel as the subject. She wouldn't do those things if she was just going to brush me off. Would she?

I sat and stared at the unopened email. The longer I waited until I opened it, the longer I could live the fantasy that a woman like Zodiac might be interested in at least having an email conversation with me. If it was a brush-off, it was evident from the title that it was going to be a witty and considerate one. But a witty and considerate brush-off was still a brush-off. And I really didn't want to be brushed-off. Not again and not by Zodiac.

I opened the email.

from: "Zoe E. Heriot-Shaw"
<z.e.heriot-shaw@imperial.ac.uk>

to: "Alex Blackwell"
<a.g.blackwell@gmail.com>

subject: Towards the End of
Morning

Alex,

great to meet you too! Currently
reading "Midnight's Children".

PAUL M. CRAY

I'm ashamed to say that I hadn't got round to it until now.

We've already met in person once, so why don't we do it again? One of my favourite kinds of food is Indian (what's yours?). It's hard to beat a karahi gosht with pilau rice, a channa aloo and a keema naan. I also think that champagne is the only thing you should drink in an Indian restaurant ;-) OK, a decent Shiraz can be good. Or even a Cobra. How about the Punjab on Neal Street (do you know it?) at 19:30 next Tuesday? Does that work for you? If not, I'm pretty flexible next week - time and food-wise.

Looking forward to seeing you soon.

Btw, I'm a big fan of both Gene Wolfe and Michael Frayn too!

Zoe X

It's always good to score a date. It's even better to not to have put weeks of painstaking effort into scoring the date. And to get asked out on date by an attractive woman who is a Gene Wolfe fan and whose favourite meal was the same as one of my favourite meals? Well, that was definitely a result.

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Of course, the first thing I did was google her. Unsurprisingly for an academic, there were lots of hits. Her Imperial homepage had a very fetching picture of Zoë with her hair piled up, a CV from which I learnt that she had been a wrangler in maths at Cambridge, had a PhD from DAMTP, and done post-docs at SLAC and CERN. Hobbies included book collecting and Wildean conversation. A pretty formidable combination. I wasn't so much in a different league as in a different universe. But I had a date with her next week. Yes, next Tuesday was very good for me.

'I love curry,' Zoë said.

'Me too,' I said truthfully as I tucked enthusiastically into my acharri murgha. 'Um, this is really good. Try some.' Zoë dipped her keema naan into my picked chicken and scooped up a large dollop of meat and sauce.

'Yes, that is good, isn't it,?' You know a date is going well when you are only twenty-five minutes and you are already at the sharing food stage. 'So, you're a software engineer. What sort of programming do you do?'

'Well, I don't really get to do as much as I would like to these days,' I said. 'I'm involved in project management I'm ashamed to say too much of the time. But I really enjoy programming when I get the chance. Our company designs smart software agents used to predict how fast innovations diffuse.'

'That sounds exciting,' said Zoë. 'These smart software agents are a bit like characters in *The Sims*?'

'Yes, they're a bit like that. It's mostly companies like supermarkets that use the system for predicting take-up of fast moving consumer goods. The agents themselves are pretty abstract: they don't have avatars moving around a virtual supermarket.'

'That would be cool though,' said Zoë.

‘It certainly would,’ I said and took a sip of Cobra. I have to admit that I had been secretly relieved when Zoë had suggested beer rather than champagne. I didn’t work in the City. Should I have suggested champagne? Or even insisted on it? Zoë looked happy enough with her beer, but in dating even the smallest detail counts in arriving at the verdict to accept or reject. And it’s all about the verdict. ‘I’ve thought about implementing it as weekend hack, but it probably wouldn’t go down well. Senior management like to down play the godgame aspects of what we do. We’re only a small company and many of clients are pretty big corporates and the bosses don’t like anything that might suggest that what we do lacks gravitas or might be frivolous.’

‘It’s a pity,’ said Zoë, ‘given that you have such a great train set that you don’t get to play with it more often.’

‘Yes,’ I said, ‘it is. There are so many interesting things that you could do with the system. Like model the chances of two people meeting at a speed dating event.’ And hitting it off.

‘Or model all the different kinds of ways they could meet.’

‘Absolutely,’ I took another sip of beer. ‘You could model how the social web of a group of contemporary Londoners changes and evolves over the years. But mostly what we do is model buying patterns that have been mined from loyalty card data.’ Enough about me already, I thought. ‘It’s interesting enough as far as it goes, but it’s not glamorous or exciting like your job!’ I had noted from her homepage that Zoë had recently spoken at conferences in Rio de Janeiro and Osaka.

‘It’s not really that glamorous. I spend most of my time in a tiny office staring at a piece of paper covered in crossed-out equations. I do enjoy it though.’ She took a sip of Cobra. Of course, I wish the money were better, but I am being paid to do something I’d do for food if I had to, so I can hardly complain too much.’

‘So, are you working on something interesting at the moment?’ I said. ‘That you could explain in terms that the interested layman might be able to understand. I read *Scientific American*, but I have to admit that arXiv isn’t my homepage.’

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Zoë stopped eating and put down her knife and fork. 'I am very disappointed in you, Alex.' She leant over the table and touched my hand with her hand. 'I'm afraid it does tend to get mathematical fast, but in essence, I'm looking into the size of the universe.'

'And how big is it?' I said.

'Infinite, said Zoë. 'I think.'

'That's certainly pretty big,' I said.

'Yes, it is,' Zoë said. 'It has some interesting implications too.'

'Such as?' I said.

'If the universe is infinite,' said Zoë. 'it must contain an infinite amount of matter. In which case, you can show that every possible combination of matter will occur in the universe an infinite number of times.'

'Which means,' I said, 'that there are an infinite number of copies of us sitting in an infinite number of Punjab restaurants eating an infinite number of curries having an infinite number of conversations about the universe being infinite.'

'Not only that,' said Zoë, 'but every possible variation of this scenario too. For instance, somewhere in the universe there is a Punjab restaurant that will be destroyed by a meteorite hitting it in the next five seconds.' We paused for the count of five. 'But, luckily, not this one. In fact, there is an infinite number of such restaurants that you just destroyed.'

I paused in chewing my curry for a second. 'It's a pretty sobering thought,' I said. 'But do you actually believe it?'

'Well, yes, if the universe is infinite and homogeneous,' said Zoë, 'it has to be true.'

'From a mathematical point of view, perhaps,' I said, 'but is it really true in a. . . I don't really know the right philosophical term,' in the way that I did know the term for how much I fancied the arse off you her: i.e. lots, I thought, '... an ontological or epistemological way?'

‘It’s a very good question,’ said Zoë. ‘The average distance to our nearest pair of doppelgängers is so large that even if we had a spaceship that could travel at the speed of light, we could never reach them; the universe would have expanded to nothingness aeons beforehand. The same laws of physics though that we use to build computers and to predict the position of the planet Mercury in the sky tell us that the universe might be infinite. OK, we don’t know yet for sure. At the moment, we can’t say the universe is infinite in the way that we can say the Earth is round. But in 5 or 10 years, we probably will know if it is infinite or not. And if it is infinite, then there has to be an infinite number of doppelgängers of us.’

‘But,’ I said, ‘as you’ve just pointed out, we can never actually hope to meet one of our doppelgängers, so our knowledge that they do exist is of a fundamentally different kind from our knowledge that the universe is infinite. That’s based on observation, just as we can observe that the Earth is round. But we can never observe the doppelgängers.’

God, I thought to myself, there’s nothing quite like a bloody good mind-fuck!

‘Their existence is a consequence of our observations. We can’t observe them directly, but we can deduce that they must exist from the observations we make.’

‘I suppose,’ I said, ‘that I’m an some kind of empiricist. If I can’t see something, I don’t really believe it exists.’

‘Alex,’ said Zoë, ‘just because we can’t see something doesn’t mean that it doesn’t exist and just because we don’t like an idea or find it hard to grasp, doesn’t mean that it isn’t true. In my opinion, the argument from personal incredulity is no argument at all.’

How could I argue with that?

We had finished our meals.

‘Would you like some. . . pudding?’ Damn it! I nearly said “dessert” ‘Or coffee? Or a digestif?’

‘Yes,’ said Zoë, ‘I would like a coffee and a digestif.’

‘OK, no prob. . .’ I started to raise my arm.

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‘The thing is,’ she said, ‘in my flat, I have some rather nice Australian Skyberry and a bottle of more than decent Calvados than I bought in duty-free when I went to Rio.’

‘Of course, it is Tuesday, I understand, no need to go over the top on a school night. . .’

‘I was wondering if you might like to come back for a coffee and a Calvados.’

‘Oh,’ I said. ‘Yes, I think I’d like to do that.’

‘Do you ever wonder if we might be living in a computer simulation?’ said Zoë afterwards. As post-coital questions go, it wasn’t one that I had ever been asked before. More’s the pity.

‘All the time,’ I said.

‘Really?’

‘Really. Well, it explains so much, don’t you think?’

Zoë propped herself up on her elbow. One of the actual good things about the real world is though people don’t have sex with the frequency that Hollywood movies suggest, the women in it don’t have nudity clauses in their contracts and thus don’t keep the duvet tucked up around their necks. ‘Have you ever noticed,’ she said, ‘that as you get older, you keep meeting people who look just like people you’ve met before.’

I had noticed that I had never met someone who looked like Zoë before. Or rather I’d never got to go to bed with someone who looked like her. ‘I have,’ I said. ‘It’s like in a computer game. The simulation only has so many different pre-generated characters stored. When it’s used them all up, it has to start using ones you’ve seen before. Although you might think that the computer running the simulation would be powerful enough to be able to simulate enough people that you wouldn’t notice the same ones coming round again.’

‘That might not be the case,’ said Zoë. ‘Computing resources by their nature are always going to be limited and thus scarce. The number

of simulations being run at any given instant may well be astronomical, so it might well make sense to whoever is running the simulations to save a few ops in any given simulation wherever possible.'

'Whoever or *whatever*,' I said. 'The simulator might not be anything at all like us.'

'I know it's a terrible thing to say,' Zoë said, 'but when I'm on the tube, I can never believe that the other people are anything at all like me. Sometimes I wonder if they're computer-generated phantoms, other times I think they might be observers from higher levels of reality. When I'm pressed up against some random stranger during the rush hour, I often have the urge to talk to him or her to force the simulation into modelling the life history of the phantom or make the observer do some quick thinking on its feet.'

The idea of being pressed up against Zoë on the tube was an appealing one, although the reality of being pressed up against her in bed was, on balance, even better. 'So,' I said, 'which do you think I am? A computer-generated phantom or an observer from a higher level of reality?'

'How could I ever know?' said Zoë. 'I know I'm real in some kind of Cartesian sense. I could achieve a conceptual breakthrough and discover, for instance, that I was in reality an intelligent software agent running in simulation in a Matrioshka brain in a globular cluster. That wouldn't help me in knowing for certain the ontological status of other people. You can break through to a higher level of reality, but for all you know there might be an infinite number of even higher ones above it. You *feel* real enough,' she ran her hand along my flank. 'You can do that as often as you like, I thought. 'But I can't ever hope to know for sure that you are real.' She leaned over and kissed me. 'Whether or not you are real, you taste good. If a bit garlicky.'

'Of course,' I said, 'I could use exactly the same argument about *you*.' I gave Zoë a dig in the ribs. As playfully as I could.

'Ouch!' said Zoë. She flopped back against the pillows. 'That hurt. The saddest thing is that it is difficult enough to connect with another

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person when you think they are another person. It's even more difficult when you can't be sure that the other person even *is* a person at all in the way that you are.'

'So,' I said, 'if you can't be sure whether I am a person like you, an observer from a higher level of reality or merely a computer-generated phantom, what are you going to do?'

'Do?' said Zoë. She put her arm round me and rolled on top of me. 'I'm going to do you.'

I could have changed at King's Cross for a train to Farringdon, just round the corner from where I work, but instead I stayed on the Piccadilly Line to Holborn, which gave me five more minutes with Zoë. I can't say I particularly enjoyed those twenty minutes, but that's not really the point. The blood was thumping so loudly in my ears I could barely hear what she was saying and I was genuinely concerned that I was going to have a myocardial infarction or at the very least pass out from a surfeit of adrenalin and endorphins. Which is not a good way to end a first date. We had arranged a second date for Friday, which meant that she had the best part of three days to talk last night through with her friends and decide that she never wanted to see me again. Dropping dead of a heart attack would pretty much guarantee that I wouldn't get to see Zoë again without her having to bother to ask her friends for a second opinion. But I did to spend another twenty minutes with my arm around Zoë.

I managed to make it to Holborn without blacking out. I kissed Zoë — for the last time? — squeezed past her and off the train. I stood on the platform and looked to see if she was looking at me. And she was. She blew me a kiss as the train pulled out of the station. As I walked towards the exit I wanted to break into a sprint, but that wasn't really practical on a crowded station during the rush hour. Alex, Alex, try and think about something else other than Zoë, having sex with Zoë and being dumped by Zoë. The thermodynamics of nuclear rockets? Yes! That's

about as far removed from thoughts of love, sex and rejection as one can go. Focus on the thermodynamics of nuclear rockets, Alex, focus!

Shortly thereafter I found myself in the office toilet attempting to pass my regular half past nine stool. There was only so long I could stay focussed on the thermodynamics of nuclear rockets. I couldn't stop myself any longer. I had to think about the problem of Zoë.

Last night had been a totally unexpected delight. Zoë's had a hot brain and a body to match. I knew why I fancied her. But why did she fancy me? It made no sense. I didn't go to Cambridge. I didn't get a triple first in maths and I don't have a PhD in cosmology. I'm just a journeyman programmer. And I'm not even a much of a programmer these days, I'm a bloody project manager. OK, I might get another date out of her, but pretty soon she's going to realise the kind of guy she's dating. And then she's going to dump me. That's inevitable.

I took my phone out of my shirt pocket. Well, I could at least try and delay the inevitable. In the old days, there was a whole calculus associated with when to ring. Ringing too quickly indicated that you were desperate and needy and thus probably an incipient psychostalker serial killer. Leaving it too long implied that you weren't really that bothered and the women might well have lost interest. But this is the late noughties and technology has provided us with the perfect channel for short, quick, phatic and completely personal communication. I tapped out a text:

Hope you have a fun day at
Imperial. Looking forward to
Friday. Alex XX

A couple of minutes later as I was tidying up I felt my phone vibrate. It was a message from Zoë:

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Having a fun day at Imperial,
but would rather be curled up in
bed with you. Zoë XXX

Instantaneously my mouth was dry and my member was tumescent. For fuck's sake, Zoë, don't send me messages like that! I'm only a man. I'm only made of flesh and blood.

In truth, there are few things more depressing than wanking in a toilet cubicle at work. But in circumstances like these, you are compelled to do so by forces beyond your control. That doesn't make you feel any less soiled. Or guilty when someone comes in to the men's and you think 'Please let him only be coming in for a slash' and he is, but while he is having what seems to be the longest piss in history, some other fucker comes into the toilets and goes into the cubicle right next to you and starts trying to push one out. And you are standing there thinking 'How long have I been away from the office? Will people notice something when I get back? Should I try and think about the thermodynamics of nuclear rockets in an effort to make my hard-on go away?' But then you think of the text and you feel really horny and frustrated because what you really want to be doing right now is shagging Zoë or, failing that, wanking while thinking about shagging Zoë, so you try and have a really *quiet* wank, but you can't get it on because you are doing it so softly and you can't help thinking of the bloke straining away a couple of feet from you through two centimetres of plywood whether he can hear you stroking your cock, which despite everything, you are doing more forcefully and urgently now, or smell the pheromones and pre-cum. You feel dirtier and dirtier as you do it and not in a good way and it takes ages to come because you are still shagged out from the night and morning before and you have simply nothing left to give, but you carry on, you have to carry on.

Eventually, the bloke in the next cubicle finishes his shit. And a few minutes after that you are able to finish your wank.

I texted Zoë. I wanted to send her the following text

PAUL M. CRAY

Just had a wank while thinking
about you. Alex XX

but I wasn't sure yet if Zoë was the kind of woman who would appreciate the sentiment. The problem with sex texts is that I have a nightmare of accidentally sending one to the wrong person. It's a good job that Zoë's name begin with a Z, so there's zero risk of accidentally sending one to my mother, which hadn't been the case with my ex Margaret. Best to play it safe. I dispatched a harmless substitute.

I wish we were too. Thinking of
you. Alex XX

I didn't want to get into a sex text arms race. My testicles couldn't stand it.

We'd only been on one date, but it had hardly been an ordinary first date. Some kind of dramatic romantic gesture was called for on my part, I felt. A dozen red roses? I'd noticed that there had been fresh flowers in Zoë's flat last night. But were flowers too much of a cliché? And they faded in a few days and that was too much of a metaphor for the future course I feared our relationship was likely to take. Perhaps I should go for something more quirky. A book? Buying a new book seemed too mundane, but sourcing the right secondhand book would take a while even if I knew what she would want. Best to save a book for later (if there was a later). Jewellery? She'd worn a very attractive pendant last night; I'd even managed to compliment her on it. Was jewellery too intimate so soon in a relationship? Could I face the risk of the dramatic gesture backfiring? And, to be frank, could I face the risk to my bank account? But then I work just round the corner from Hatton Garden. The Fates obviously intended my gift to be jewellery and it would foolish indeed for me to incur the ire of the Parcae.

So lunchtime found me trailing down Hatton Garden looking for a shop that looked like it (a) sold a substantial range of non-diamond

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jewellery (De Beers might want us to believe that a diamond is forever, but I doubted my relationship with Zoë was, and even if I'd been able to afford them, I suspected that she was the kind of woman who would have very definite opinions concerning the cultural associations of diamonds, especially given the ethically dubious providence of so many of them and the creation of spurious tradition through one of the most successful marketing campaigns of all time); (b) jewellery at a price point that wouldn't require me to seriously weigh up whether it would be worth taking the risk of just sticking up the joint.

I felt pretty disheartened by the time I got back to the top of Hatton Garden. The prices were higher than I had naively hoped and I felt too intimidated to go in any of the shops and explore whether there was anything less expensive inside. I crossed the road and I noticed a shop I must have missed on my way down. I strolled over to it. I noticed the window that there were quite a few amber pieces along with the usual diamonds. Amber, it occurred to me, would go perfectly with Zoë's hair and skin. The sign above the door offered 'Contemporary Designer and Antique Jewellery'. Maybe they also sold pre-owned jewellery that hadn't yet made it to antique status and was lolling at the bottom of the time v. price curve. I looked at my watch. I had to get back to the office soon, but I hadn't made much progress today. I could just nip in for a quick look round. I didn't have to buy anything, just get a feel for what you got for your money and think about what I wanted to do overnight. I pushed open the door.

The first thing that struck me was the heavy, heady smell of incense. The second thing was the hypnotic, exotic music. Not quite what I had expected. I was pleasantly surprised that there was no shop assistant to be seen. The jewellery was displayed safely between thick glass in cases along each side of the room and I could browse without pressure. I went over and inspected a case: bracelets, brooches, earrings, finger rings, necklaces, pendants, torcs. Well, I did have until Friday to decide the on the right piece.

Out of the corner of my eye, I sensed a moving shape. I turned and saw that a tall, thin woman with long red hair had appeared by my side. Around her swan-like neck she wore a silver necklace from which hung a large piece of amber. The word 'Magnificent' swam into my mind. Which was odd as it wasn't a word I would usually associate with a piece of jewellery and words didn't usually swim into my mind.

'How may I help you?' she said.

'Er. . . I'm looking for some jewellery,' I said.

'For yourself?' Of course not for myself! Do I look like the kind of bloke who buys jewellery for himself?

'Oh, no. No. For my. . . er. . . girlfriend.' Was Zoë my girlfriend? Should I casually dropping the word 'girlfriend' into conversations with a complete stranger given that our first date had ended less four hours ago?

'Ah, for your *girlfriend*? What exactly are you looking for for your girlfriend?'

'Well, I'm. . . er. . . I'm not quite sure.'

'Ah, I see.' She saw? 'What kinds of jewellery does your girlfriend like?'

How the hell should I know? I've only met her twice. She'd be been wearing something vaguely contemporary and designer-y last night, so something like that. 'I think. . . I think a necklace might be good.' A brooch was too stuffy and a finger ring was obviously out of the question for the time being.

'Ah, a necklace. Tell me about your girlfriend. Is she tall or petite? Dark or fair?'

'Petite. And a redhead.' Like you I nearly added as I noticed that the woman's hair was exactly the same shade of red as Zoë's. They must use the same hair colourant.

'A redhead? Is she a fire sign?' I don't even know when her birthday is. And even if I did, I'd have no idea what sign she was, much less whether she was a fire sign. And we are talking about one of the country's leading young theoretical *cosmologists* here. Zoë had told me

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last night in the restaurant that she had featured in a *Sunday Telegraph* magazine picture spread on Britain's top twenty female scientists under forty. — wearing a ball gown. Of course, one of my main goals in life now was to track down a copy of that issue. Thank God for eBay! I had thought of asking Zoë if I could have a look at her copy when we were at her flat, but there were other things going on that distracted me and besides I was worried she might think that was a bit creepy. I couldn't exactly borrow it off her, not given what I intended to do with it. But just thinking about it was making me weak with desire.)

I looked at the shop assistant. Her mouth was arched upwards with amusement. 'Something in amber perhaps,' I said.

'Ah, amber. You have excellent taste.' She walked over to one of the cases on the opposite side of the room and unlocked it. She unclasped the necklace she was wearing, picked a silver necklace with an amber pendant out of the case and held it against her neck. 'Something like this?'

'It's. . . lovely,' I said. The combination of incense, music and hormones was obviously starting getting to me. Had I just said that out loud? It would complement Zoë's hair, eyes, and skin perfectly. Would it? I took as hard a look as I could at shop assistant's face as she held up the necklace. Her features were similar to Zoë's. In fact, were it not for the fact that her face was thinner I would have said they were almost uncannily so: the same high cheekbones, the same slender nose, the same deep chestnut eyes, the same creamy, lustrous skin. Yes, the necklace would suit Zoë.

'Like most amber, the amber in this pendant comes from Baltic coast of the Sambia peninsula of the Kalingrad oblast in what is now Russia, but was Prussia.' She had refasten her original necklace. 'It comes the same site as the amber in the necklace I am wearing. Amber is an ancient material and there are many legends associated with it. For instance, in the valley where this amber was mined, it is said that long ago there lived a wise woman, a seer, who both took her power from the amber and returned that power doubled to the amber. If a woman who

is pure of heart wears amber from that place, she too will become a seer, one who can see through the veil of illusion that shrouds this plane of existence to the true world beyond.'

A sickly warmth spread through by body and I felt myself sway. Was I going to faint? I gripped the bottom of the case to support myself 'Er... can I just take the necklace, please?'

As she was wrapping the necklace, the woman continued, 'It is said that if the first gift from a man to a woman is made of amber, they will soon marry.' She smiled the same ironically amused smile as she handed the package to me. 'I'm sure that Zoë will like the amber.' At least that's what I thought she said. But she couldn't have. I hadn't mentioned Zoë's name to her. I needed to get a breath of air as fresh as one can get in central London as fast as I could before I started seeing things as well as hearing them.

By the time I got back to the office, I was feeling more my usual self. They must have had the heating up too high in the shop and along with the smells and bells and everything that had happened in the last day... Well, at least I'd got something. As I put the bag from the jeweller's in my laptop case I noticed that there was something odd about the shape of the package. I took it out of the bag and saw that there must be two boxes wrapped up together: a large one and a smaller one. I didn't want to unwrap the package (wrapping presents is hardly my fortés), so I looked at the receipt:

(1) Silver amber pendant	£75.00 (inc. VAT)
necklace	
(2) Silver amber earrings	£25.00 (inc. VAT)

TOTAL	£100.00 (inc. VAT)

Did Zoë even have pierced ears? I hadn't noticed that she had. And I probably would have done if she had. Could I give her the earrings

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if she didn't? Would that seem like a lack of attention to detail? What to do? Perhaps there were clips-on. That seem unlikely surely. Or they could be converted to clips on? Could you even do that? But I had absolutely no recollection of buying the earrings. Yet there it was on the receipt, the amount on the credit card slip matched and presumably the earrings were in the small box. I didn't want to remove it and damage the wrapping. And what would I do with a random pair of earrings? Take them back to the shop? I wasn't sure I could bring myself to go back to it given that I had started losing track of buying things as well as hearing them, Perhaps I just wasn't cut out for this romance business. I took a deep breath. The thermodynamics of nuclear rockets. I felt my phone buzz in my shirt pocket.

It was Saturday morning. Zoë and I were in bed. *My* bed. We had gone to the Anglesea Arms in Brackenbury Village, handy for both of us as I lived in Brentford and Zoë worked in South Kensington. I had had to spend two evenings tidying the flat (correction: two evenings carrying out industrial-level deep cleansing of my flat), but it had been worth it as my bachelor pad seemed to have passed muster with Zoë. There was no way I could contemplate Zoë discovering how I actually lived my life. Or rather how I had lived it. I would have to put those days behind me now.

We were having breakfast: croissants, pain au chocolat, little cups of espresso that I had made with my Moka Express and freshly squeezed orange juice. I might not have been able to rustle up eggs benedict, but I could squeeze an orange as well as the next man. As I said, in dating, attention to even the smallest detail matters. It might have been good to have the Saturday *Guardian*, but there was no way I was getting dressed and going out in the cold and wet to the petrol station when I could be warm and dry and naked in bed with Zoë. Besides, we had hardly got to the stage where we needed a paper to prompt us for topics of conversation.

'I had a weird dream last night,' said Zoë.

'What was it about?' I said as I bit into a pain au chocolat.

'It's a bit embarrassing' she fingered the amber pendant. (She had swapped the necklace and earrings she had been wearing for the ones I had bought last night. So she had had pierced ears after all, but why had I been so sure she hadn't? The stimulation certainly seemed to be doing some serious messing around with me.) I have to admit that the sight of her wearing them had turned me on. And the sight of her still wearing them now was turning me on again. 'It was about us.'

'Why's that embarrassing?' Oh, my God! Had I blown it with Zoë because of something I had done in a dream? I stopped munching my pain au chocolat and felt the pastry instantly turned into a solid bolus in my mouth.

Zoë laughed. 'It's OK, Alex.' She leaned over. I quickly swallowed the lump of pastry and kissed her. She tasted of buttered croissant. I licked my lips. 'You're not in trouble. It's just that I don't remember my dreams often, but this one is so clear it feels almost as though it happened in real life.'

'So what was it that happened to us in your dream that felt like real life?'

'Are you sure you want to hear about it? It's only a dream.'

I rocked forward and gave her another kiss. 'Of course, I want to hear about it. A dream might just be the one part of the brain trying to make sense of the random firings of the neurons in another part, but this one's obviously made a big impact on you. You've piqued my curiosity now. I'm anxious to hear everything. Especially if it's about us.'

'If you're sure,' said Zoë. 'Are you comfortable?' I reclined back against the pillows.

'Yes,' I said, 'I am now.'

'Then,' she said, 'we'll begin.'